

LEVIATHAN FITNESS

MUSCLES & MONSTERS



ASHLEY BENNETT

"Quite simply the cozy monster romance of my dreams."

— *New York Times* bestselling author B.K. Borison

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LEVIATHAN FITNESS #1

MUSCLES & MONSTERS



ASHLEY BENNETT

BERKLEY ROMANCE

NEW YORK

BERKLEY ROMANCE
Published by Berkley
An imprint of Penguin Random House LLC
1745 Broadway, New York, NY 10019
penguinrandomhouse.com



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Cover art by Alex Conkins
Cover design by Reagan Hood
Book design by George Towne, adapted for ebook
Interior art: Fitness icons © Mayrisio / Shutterstock

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: Bennett, Ashley (Novelist) author
Title: Muscles & monsters / Ashley Bennett.
Description: New York: Berkley Romance, 2026. | Series: Leviathan fitness; 1
Identifiers: LCCN 2025032879 (print) | LCCN 2025032880 (ebook) | ISBN 9780593956977 trade paperback | ISBN 9780593956984 ebook
Subjects: LCGFT: Werewolf fiction | Romance fiction | Novels
Classification: LCC PS3602.E46853 M87 2026 (print) | LCC PS3602.E46853 (ebook) | DDC 813/.6—dc23/eng/20250919
LC record available at <https://lccn.loc.gov/2025032879>
LC ebook record available at <https://lccn.loc.gov/2025032880>

Muscles & Monsters was originally self-published, in different form, in 2022.

This revised and expanded edition published by Berkley Romance, an imprint of Penguin Random House LLC, 2026.

Ebook ISBN 9780593956984

The authorized representative in the EU for product safety and compliance is Penguin Random House Ireland, Morrison Chambers, 32 Nassau Street, Dublin D02 YH68, Ireland, <https://eu-contact.penguin.ie>.

ep_prh_7.3a_155047159_c0_r0

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CONTENTS

[Dedication](#)

[Author's Note](#)

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter Fourteen](#)

[Chapter Fifteen](#)

[Chapter Sixteen](#)

[Chapter Seventeen](#)

[Chapter Eighteen](#)

[Chapter Nineteen](#)

[Chapter Twenty](#)

[Chapter Twenty-One](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Two](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Three](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Four](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Five](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Six](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Seven](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Eight](#)
[Chapter Twenty-Nine](#)
[Chapter Thirty](#)
[Chapter Thirty-One](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Two](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Three](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Four](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Five](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Six](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Seven](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Eight](#)
[Chapter Thirty-Nine](#)
[Chapter Forty](#)
[Chapter Forty-One](#)
[Epilogue](#)

[Acknowledgments](#)

[Excerpt from Tentacles & Triathlons](#)

[About the Author](#)

*To anyone who's ever felt something for an anime wolf...and
to all the readers who loved this book the first time around.
None of this would be possible without you.*

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

Muscles & Monsters is a slice-of-life monster romance; however, it also contains the following: death of a parent (past, mentioned), death of a grandparent (past, mentioned), restrictive/nonrestrictive diets, distorted body image (MMC), body shaming (from the MMC's ex), sex (including primal play and knotting), and adult language. For an exhaustive list of content and trigger warnings, please refer to the author's website, AshleyBennettAuthor.com.

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One



TEGAN

“ALWAYS THE BAKER AND NEVER the bride.” I sighed to myself, stepping back from the three circular cake tiers lining the counter. They gradually increased in size, the biggest about the size of a tire.

Per the bride’s request, it was going to be a massive three-tiered red velvet cake slathered in textured cream cheese icing, large enough to feed the entire town of Briar Glenn. Because of the size, I’d assemble it on-site at the wedding venue tomorrow morning.

This particular wedding cake was for the mayor’s daughter, Jessica, who just so happened to have graduated high school with me. She was marrying a satyr who worked in finance, and in the spirit of supporting local businesses, they’d hired me to bake the wedding cake. It was an honor, really—but I couldn’t help the stinging jealousy I felt every time I thought about their upcoming nuptials.

Here she was getting married while I spent every waking moment of my life working at the bakery. So much, in fact, that my last relationship ended because of it. My girlfriend of two years just couldn’t handle my dedication to the family business. She gave me an ultimatum—her or the bakery. Of course I chose the bakery. At this point, I had pretty much resigned myself to being a childless cat lady. Not that there was anything wrong with that—it just wasn’t the white picket fence, two-point-five kids, and ridiculously attractive partner that I had dreamed of since I was a little girl.

Selene, my bakery assistant and one of my closest friends, joined me in admiring my work. “They came out perfect, Tegs. Just like they do every time. I don’t know how you do it.”

And they were perfect. Nice and even with no cracks, the icing smooth and level.

“Pastry school and years of practice under the most hard-ass baker I know,” I said, wiping my sugar-coated hands on my apron.

She laughed, warm and raspy. “Don’t talk about Mama Rollins like that.”

“It’s true! In the kitchen, she’s not the sweet lady you know her to be, I can tell you from experience.”

After my father’s death a year ago, my mother retired, and I inherited the Briar Glenn Bakery. Before that, my grandmother ran the bakery. A legacy of women business owners here in the tiny town of Briar Glenn, one I was happy to continue. Even if it meant I had no work-life balance.

“I am beat,” Selene said, leaning against the counter and wiping her forehead.

She’d been quieter today, none of her playful teasing or upbeat singing. Just silently working on the backup sheet cake for the wedding on the off chance there was a catastrophe. In all the years I’d worked at the bakery, that had yet to happen, but my mother always drilled it into my head that we needed to have some sort of backup plan—just in case. For the mayor’s daughter’s wedding, the biggest social event of the year, I wasn’t taking any chances.

“Are you okay?” I asked, taking in Selene’s flushed cheeks and dewy skin.

I kept the bakery cold to keep the icing from melting, and it had been hours since I ran the oven...

“I’m just not feeling great.”

“Why didn’t you say something earlier? I could have finished this on my own.”

“Well, I need the hours and you have enough on your plate as it is.”

Selene had only been working with me for a few months, but she'd picked things up quickly. I could rely on her to work on smaller orders like premade birthday cakes, while I worked on large orders like wedding cakes and special-order baked goods. She really had a knack for baking.

Much to the dismay of her parents, Selene was taking some time off from college. At the ripe age of twenty-two, she had plenty of time to go back and finish her engineering degree, and I was thankful for the help.

Even with the eight-year age difference between us, we'd become close. And working with Selene was a hell of a lot better than asking my mom to help out part-time. Pam Rollins had just passed me the reins. I wasn't about to let her micromanage the way I was running my business.

"Did you still want to go to the diner for dinner?" I asked, hoping Selene would join me. Outside of Sunday dinners at my mom's house, I'd been having one too many meals alone lately.

"Rain check on that one. I want to make sure I rest up for tomorrow. There's no way you can handle that behemoth on your own."

"Just let me know. I think I can manage it just fine."

"I'll be there. Besides, I wouldn't want you to be late for the wedding."

"Fuck," I huffed. "Are you sure you don't want to come with me?" Stupidly, I'd put myself down for a plus-one, thinking I could use the fact that the wedding was open bar to coerce Selene into going with me. Unfortunately, that wasn't the case. Apparently, she'd won tickets to see her favorite band and the concert was the same night as the wedding.

"Isn't Declan going?"

I snorted. "Not a chance. He hooked up with Jessica's brother, Brendan, a few years ago; and while it was just a fling for Dec, Brendan took it really hard. Moved to Cincinnati, and this is his first time back in town since."

Selene grimaced. "Sounds about right for Dec. Guess you're flying solo, then."

"Couldn't I just"—I shrugged, making a face—"not go?"

She pinned me with a stare, arching a perfectly sculpted brow. She might not have been feeling well, but her makeup was still on point. "Your mom is going to give you serious shit if you don't go."

I groaned. “Fine. Fine.” There was already tension between me and my older brother; I didn’t need it with my mother, too.

Selene gathered the icing-crusteds tools and tossed them in the sink.

“I’ve got those,” I said, already reaching for the dish soap.

“But—”

I cut her off. “Go home. Boss’s orders.”

She tugged off the bandana covering her hair, letting her bouncy brown curls free. “If you insist.”

Honestly, I expected more of an argument. She really wasn’t feeling well.

“What time should I be here tomorrow to load up the cake?”

“The venue is letting me in at nine, so probably eight thirty? I want to get it out of the way so I’m not rushing to get ready for the wedding.”

“You mean you’re not going to assemble the cake in your dress?” she teased.

“I don’t think it would shock anyone if I did, but no, I’m going to go home and get ready after.”

“What are you going to wear?”

“I was thinking maybe that emerald green dress you forced me to buy when it was on sale around Christmas.” I said *forced*, but in reality I’d been obsessed with the dress since the moment I tried it on. Selene just gave me the push I needed to actually drop that kind of money on a piece of clothing—even if it was on sale. “I haven’t had a chance to wear it yet.” And I was dying to.

She clapped her hands together, brightening up a little bit. “Oh, the pinup one! That’ll be perfect for the wedding. Your ass looks so good in that dress.”

It really did.

“If I have to go, I might as well look hot while doing it.”

“Love that mindset for you.” She hugged my shoulders, giving them a little squeeze. “I’ll see you in the morning. Tell Dec I said hi.”

“Will do. Try not to be late,” I shouted after her.

She slipped out the back door, leaving me in the absolute worst place to be: alone with my thoughts.

As the warm water turned my hands red and the icing swirled around the drain, I couldn't help but feel like it was a metaphor for my love life.

I'd spent so much time devoting myself to the bakery, making sure it had continued success now that it had switched hands, that I felt like I was falling behind in the other aspects of my life.

I wanted to have someone to go home to. A reason to hurry out of the bakery in the evenings. I wanted to have someone to rely on other than myself, someone to take control every once in a while so I could get out of the endless to-do list that reeled through my head.

To find that person, I was going to have to make some serious changes to my life. It wasn't going to be easy.

Once I was finished cleaning up, I locked the shop and started down Main Street toward the neon-blue beacon of Dale's Diner. It was a Briar Glenn staple, the quintessential small-town greasy spoon serving breakfast, lunch, and dinner. If anything could cure me, it was an emotional-support bacon double cheeseburger and a hot plate of fries.

The overhead bell tinkled when I stepped inside, drawing the attention of every patron lining the counter and filling the booths.

"Hey," I said, giving a little wave.

One of the downsides of living in a small town was the fact that you knew everyone, they knew you, and both of you knew everything about each other.

But these days, I didn't exactly know everyone.

Over the past year, Briar Glenn had experienced a lot of growth thanks to the mayor's revitalization initiative. It was a program that provided grants and incentives for relocating to the town or starting a business. And it was working.

Every month it felt like there were more and more unfamiliar faces, more homes being built, and more businesses popping up. While I generally wasn't a fan of change, I was happy to see the town grow while still maintaining its charm.

A few waves and murmured hellos greeted me as I made my way to my favorite booth. It was tucked in the back corner, next to a vintage jukebox that had been there since the diner first opened. There was enough noise to drown out your conversation from listening ears, and the wide window gave you a clear view down Main Street for prime people watching.

No sooner had my ass touched the vinyl seat than a familiar voice cooed from the kitchen, “Is that my girl?”

One of the waitresses, Connie, who had known me since I was born, set a fresh fountain Sprite down in front of me. “Yeah, it’s her,” she shouted in her gravelly smoker’s voice, rolling her eyes.

The eye roll wasn’t for me—but for what happened next.

A squeal sounded from the kitchen, followed by the swinging doors bursting open to reveal my best friend and resident chef of the diner, Declan, rushing toward me with a plate of food in his hands.

Our parents were old friends, and it was decided that Dec and I would be friends before we were even born. From our first steps, to T-ball games, to our emo phase as teenagers, we did all of it together. I loved him just as much as—and at the present moment, more than—my own brother.

Dec was wearing his typical line chef uniform. A grease-splattered apron stretched across his chubby belly, and striped chef pants completely clashed with the tie-dye nonslip Crocs on his feet. A hairnet clung to his dark brown hair, and a special one covered his full beard.

He looked absolutely ridiculous. Like if Zach Galifianakis was moonlighting as a fry cook.

“Why don’t you just shave that thing off?” I asked, reaching for his beard.

Dec swatted my hand away. “No way. It makes me look rugged.” He slipped off the beard hairnet and ran his fingers through the thick bush sprouting from his face.

“You? Rugged?” It was hilarious considering I couldn’t even get Dec to go for a hike around the lake, let alone a camping trip.

“I will take this burger right back to the kitchen, missy,” he said, sliding the plate away from me. “No more comp meals for you.”

“No.” I grabbed his hand. “I need this today.”

Like me, he’d inherited the family business from his father, Dale. The one the diner was named after. For a long time Dec debated changing the name, but Declan’s Diner didn’t quite have the same ring to it. And all the locals would have still called it *Dale’s* anyway.

“That’s what I thought.” My bestie shimmied into the booth, his brows pinching together as he stared at me. “Why so glum, chum? You’ve got this sour-ass look on your face.”

“I just got done putting the finishing touches on Jessica’s wedding cake.”

“Oh, that’s right. Little Miss Silver Spoon herself is getting married tomorrow.”

“Declan.” I swatted his arm, thankful no one could hear us over the classic rock ballad blaring from the jukebox.

“What?” He laughed. “An extravagant wedding and a brand-new house in Briar Lakes that her daddy paid for. Everyone knows she’s a spoiled brat.”

“Yeah, she is, but at least she found someone to spend her life with, even if he is a finance bro. That’s more than we can say.”

“Excuse me,” he said, affronted. “I’m single by choice.”

“Is a fear of commitment a choice?”

When we were in our early twenties, Dec had his heart broken by his first real boyfriend, and he’d never truly recovered from it. He acted like he preferred hookup culture, but I knew it was a defense mechanism. He was afraid of getting hurt again.

Dec ignored the question, strategically steering the conversation back to me. “What about that cute centaur couple that moved onto your street?”

“Dec!” I snorted. “They’re married.”

He shrugged. “Throuples are a big thing these days. You could be their unicorn in a more literal sense.”

I rolled my eyes. I wasn’t sure I could make time for one partner, let alone two. “You’re terrible.”

He snatched a fry from my plate, chewing it as he said, “You know. If you weren’t so invested in the bakery, you could meet someone.”

I scoffed. “You’re one to talk.” In addition to the whole fear-of-commitment thing, Dec was another workaholic. Maybe he was onto something with hookup culture.

“This isn’t about me.”

“I’m gonna make time soon.” I hoped that if I said it enough, I’d will it into reality.

Dec saw right through me. “Hmm. Sounds like bullshit to me.”

“Shut up.”

“On that note, I better get back,” he said, sliding out of the booth with some difficulty. He tugged the beard net on and I bit back a smile. I couldn’t take him seriously with that thing on. “Pop in the kitchen before you leave, okay? I’ll pack up a slice of pie for you to go.”

I might have been a baker, but Declan truly made the best blueberry pie in all of Briar Glenn.

“All right,” I said with a resigned shake of my head.

Dec gripped my shoulder, giving me a sad smile before he walked back to the kitchen. Once again, I was alone.

At least I had a big slice of pie to look forward to.

Two



ATLAS

I WAS GOING TO KILL my best friend.

“Fallon,” I gritted out, hoisting a bar holding 550 pounds back onto the rack. It was a new personal record for me, but he was too preoccupied to see it.

Currently, my best friend and would-be spotter, Fallon, was flirting with two human women attempting to use the hip abductor.

When I hired Fallon to work as a personal trainer at my gym, I didn’t expect him to use it as a hunting ground for his conquests. Which, knowing him, I should have. That one was on me, but it still didn’t make it okay.

I silently strolled over to where he was chatting up the ladies, placing a hand on his feathered shoulder, which made him jump.

“Oh, uh, hey, Atlas,” he said, fixing his beady bird eyes on me.

Fallon was a griffin. A big monster with a birdlike upper body and the lower half of a lion. His hands were scaly talons, and he had big paws for feet. A large pair of wings hung from his back, allowing him to fly short distances. While the ladies loved his little lion tail, they *really* had a thing for another interesting part of his anatomy. An interest he took full advantage of.

“This is Melanie and Molly,” he said. “I was just giving them some tips on using the hip abductor.” He leaned against the machine, giving them that

same flirtatious look he'd been using since college. "Isn't that right, ladies?"

They nodded, both fighting back smiles. They were falling for his shtick hook, line, and sinker.

"Hey, Fal," I said calmly, doing my best to keep up pretenses around the gym patrons. "Do you think you could help me with something in my office?"

"Sure thing, boss man." He dug one of his taloned hands into the pocket of his gym shorts, fishing out one of his business cards. "Here's my card. And remember—I'm available for private sessions."

The wink he gave them made me want to throw up in my mouth.

Instead, I wrapped my arm around his shoulder, leading him away while the girls giggled behind us.

"Fal, what the fuck was that about? You were supposed to be spotting me," I growled under my breath.

He chuffed, puffing out his feathers. "Come on, man. We both know you had it under control. You're stronger than me, and when I'm spotting you, we're really just hanging out while we lift..."

He wasn't wrong. I preferred working out in the early morning, when the gym was silent and I could just zone out, focusing on lifting and lifting alone. But I'd been so busy running the business that I hadn't hung out with him as much lately.

"I know that's what we're doing but you can't use the gym to pick up women. If you sleep with half the population of Briar Glenn, we won't be able to retain any members."

"You saw me give them my card. I was trying to get them to sign up for training sessions."

I rolled my eyes. He seemed to forget that we'd been friends since we were kids. I knew him better than my own brothers. "You're so full of shit."

He whistled—the griffin equivalent of a laugh. "I'm just trying to meet some new people. Have a little bit of fun."

Now that I was a business owner, his idea of fun and mine were two completely different things. He liked to get shit-faced and pick up girls at

clubs, I liked staying in and playing video games before crawling into bed at nine. We were in totally different places in our lives.

I'd recently opened my gym, Leviathan Fitness, after moving here to Briar Glenn six months ago. It was the perfect up-and-coming small town to open a business in, and thanks to a grant from the city, I was able to purchase the former rec center, converting it into a state-of-the-art gym.

Things had been slow at first, but membership was growing every day. Now that we were finally turning a profit, I could breathe a little easier.

We headed inside my office and Fallon scanned the room. "So what did you need help with?"

I plopped down in my desk chair and threw back my head. Gods, he was dense.

"I didn't need help with anything."

Fallon sat in the chair across from me, propping his paws up on the corner of my desk before I shoved them off. "Did you give any more thought to taking me as your guest to the wedding? I know you were gonna go with Jade, but now—"

Jade.

My ex.

The breakup was still fresh, and even though I was the one who broke off the engagement, I was having a hard time adjusting to being single. I guess that was to be expected after a fourteen-year relationship.

"Come on," Fallon pressed. "I can be your wingman."

"I don't recall a time that you were ever Atlas's wingman," a suave British accent chimed in.

Our friend Cyrus shuffled inside, his tentacles propelling him across the floor. He was a kraken, an ancient species of monster that was so rare that most lived their lives without ever meeting one. The three of us were roommates in college, when a tense living situation evolved into a lifelong friendship.

"I was before he started dating Jade," Fallon said. "Atlas could have been living it up in college but instead—"

"Enough," Cyrus hissed, showing his sharp teeth as a warning.

I didn't want to reminisce about those days. They were long gone. And for good reason.

"Okay. Okay," Fallon said, holding up his talons. "Message received."

"I don't even want to go to the wedding," I said, raking my claws through my fur.

Stuffy music. Uncomfortable suit. *No date.*

Attending a wedding after calling off your engagement was a special kind of torture. Nothing reminds you of your shortcomings quite like other people's happiness.

Wouldn't it be enough to send a gift?

Unfortunately, I felt obligated to attend. A few months ago, the mayor himself had strolled into Leviathan Fitness with a wedding invitation addressed to me in hand. Apparently, he'd invited all the small-business owners on Main Street to join in his daughter's special day. It would be a great networking opportunity. I'd been so busy opening the gym that I hadn't had much of a chance to get to know anyone outside of the few friends who'd relocated here with me.

"You say that now, but I know you. You'll get there and you'll have a great time. People are always drawn to you, A-man."

Cyrus nodded his agreement. "He's right. People can't resist that charming tail of yours."

I groaned. I hoped they were right. "I guess I'll go."

"That's the wolf daddy I know," Fallon said.

"What did I say about calling me that?" I barked. Him and that fucking nickname! He was the last person I wanted to call me *daddy*.

Fallon gave me finger guns with his talons. "You know you love it." He stood up and stretched out his wings. "I gotta get going. I'm training that hot older woman today and I want to make sure I shower first."

I rubbed my temples because what the fuck was I going to do with him.

"Are you going to be home for dinner?" Cyrus asked him.

"Yeah," Fallon said. "What are you making?"

"Eggplant parm."

"Fuck yeah," Fallon chirped. "My favorite."

I chuckled. "I swear the two of you are like an old married couple."

"No," Cyrus said flatly. "We are not."

"I'll see you at home, honey," Fallon said, blowing Cyrus a kiss as he walked past him.

"I don't know how you can still live with him after all this time," I said, shaking my head.

After we graduated from college, I moved in with Jade, and Cyrus and Fallon got an apartment together. All these years later, and they were still roommates.

"If he didn't live with me, he'd live with you, so consider it a favor."

I pressed my hand to my chest. "I'm forever in your debt."

Cyrus's wide blue eyes searched my face. "Are you going to be all right going to the wedding alone?" he asked.

Damn it, he was good. He could see right through me.

"Yeah, I'll be okay," I said, forcing myself to sound confident. "I just hope my suit still fits." There was no way I could attend a wedding in joggers and a hoodie.

Cyrus tapped two tentacles against the doorframe, obviously contemplating something. "You know, you've been spending a lot of time here since the breakup."

"Well, between Chai being sick, getting all the tax paperwork together —"

"Those sound like excuses," he said, cutting me off.

"What else am I going to do?"

"All the things you've missed out on over the last fourteen years," he suggested.

Fourteen years. I'd wasted my twenties on someone who saw me only for what I could give her. She wanted the perfect house. The perfect boyfriend. The perfect husband. And I didn't get shit in return.

"I think it's a little too late for that," I said.

I was never getting that time back.

Before he could press me any further, I asked, "How's painting going?"

Cy was going through something of his own. He was an acclaimed artist, but lately he'd been spending more time staring at his canvas rather than painting. While I wasn't one to pry, I was genuinely concerned about my friend.

"You cheeky bastard," he said, flashing me a sharp-toothed grin. "Don't change the subject."

"Just giving you a taste of your own medicine."

"If you're worried about my art output, you could always come over and model for me. I could paint a nude portrait for you to hang in the office," he teased.

I barked a laugh. "No, thanks."

"It would be tasteful," he scoffed, sending the both of us into a fit of laughter.

When we finally got ourselves together, he looked at me with a soft expression and asked, "You know you can always talk to me, right?"

"I know. And the same goes for you."

"I'm gonna take a dip in the pool. Want to join?"

Cyrus was one of the main reasons I'd insisted on having a saltwater pool. Krakens could spend time out of water, but he needed a place to swim and replenish his saltwater stores.

"Nah. I'm good."

"I'll leave you to it, then." He tipped his head and started to turn away before he whipped back around. "Oh, and let me know if your suit needs alterations. I'm happy to help."

That was the thing with krakens. They had exceptionally long lifespans, giving them plenty of time to pursue hobbies. In his seven hundred years, there wasn't much Cyrus hadn't tried and mastered.

"Thanks, Cy."

He waved with one of his tentacles and scuttled out the door.

I'd work for a few hours tomorrow getting the tax paperwork together for my accountant, make sure Chai was good to work the front desk, then attend the wedding later in the evening.

But first, I was going to go home and try on my suit.

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Three



TEGAN

MY BINGO ARMS SHOOK FROM overexertion. Yes, that's right—bingo arms. You know, the kind all the old bats at bingo night have when they're waving their dabbers around. Yep. At thirty, I had a set of those bad boys.

"Steady, steady. Just a little bit closer," I said. I'm sure I looked ridiculous, talking to myself as I struggled to load the largest tier of the wedding cake into the back of my SUV.

After yesterday, I should have known Selene was going to call out sick. I was glad she wasn't spreading her germs all over the place, but carrying the biggest tier of the cake was proving to be a real challenge.

I was so close to having the cake safely in the back of the SUV that I could almost taste the sweet, sweet flavor of victory—when disaster struck. The muscles in my right arm cramped and I gritted my teeth in agony. It felt as if time slowed. The box slid from my grip and toppled to the ground, sending hunks of red velvet coated in thick, rich cream cheese icing all over the sidewalk.

Splat.

"No, no, no," I groaned as I rubbed my arm, trying to work out the knot.

I wanted to crawl into a hole and die. The defining cake of my career was splattered all over the ground. Luckily for me, it was the bottom tier, and I had the backup sheet cake—but it was still an embarrassing mistake. I could feel the tears welling up in my eyes as my knees hit the pavement.

My lip quivered as I piled pieces of cake back into what remained of the box.

As I wiped away a tear, a giant shadow blocked out the sun. A pair of large furred feet, complete with sharp black claws, appeared in my line of sight. I looked up slowly, taking in the wall of dark gray fur standing in front of me. He was solid muscle, strong calves and thighs topped with a stomach that I'm sure had a six-pack his shirt was hiding. My eyes continued upward, over his broad chest and thick neck to his face. His muzzle was long and pointed, the fur deepening to a dark black that matched the color of his canine snout. Briar Glenn was home to a lot of monsters, but he was the first wolverine I'd seen around.

Did he just move here?

Is he visiting?

I would have definitely noticed him...

The corners of his muzzle curled up in a kind smile and his ears twitched as he looked down at me. "It looks like you're having a bad day. Can I give you a hand?" he asked in a deep, rumbling voice.

"That—that would be great," I sniffled. Any other cake and I would have refused, but this was a two-person job.

His body swayed back and forth slightly, a fluffy mass of gray and black popping out from one side and then the other.

A tail.

He was wagging his tail at me.

My lips twitched, fighting back a smile, because it was just so damn cute.

He bent over, his gym shorts straining against his tree-trunk thighs, as he scooped up handfuls of ruined cake with his massive, claw-tipped hands and tossed them into the box.

I stared at him for a moment, admiring the way his muscular physique flexed with his movements. Gods, he was handsome. Dirty thoughts crept into my mind, like what it would be like to feel that furred, muscular body rubbing against my naked skin. If the other aspects of his anatomy matched his stature, he would probably be more than I could handle.

I shook my head, clearing my thoughts. I'd officially reached a new low. I just dropped the most important cake of my career, and now I was having sexual fantasies about someone I'd just met.

"I'm assuming this was for the wedding today?" he asked in that delicious gravelly voice.

To hide the fact that I'd been staring at him instead of helping, I grabbed a few chunks of cake and tossed them into the box. "Of course it was." I swiped my hair out of my face, smearing icing along my brow. "Dammit!" I hissed. "This is just my luck. My assistant called out today and the cake was too heavy for me and my muscles cramped—" I was spiraling in front of a complete stranger. A hot stranger at that.

One of his icing-coated hands gripped my arm, making my breath hitch. He was so gentle, careful to avoid piercing my skin with his sharp claws. "Hey," he said calmly—sweetly even. "It's okay."

I stared into his bright yellow eyes. Against his dark fur they looked like full moons on a cloudless night. I wasn't sure if it was his words or his demeanor, but all of my embarrassment and worry slipped away.

He cleared his throat, letting go of my arm to point a clawed finger down the street. "Do you see that gym down there? Leviathan Fitness? That's my gym." He gestured to the T-shirt on his chest emblazoned with a tentacle holding a barbell. "Anytime you need help with a heavy cake, come see me."

He flashed me a wolfish grin and I wondered if the offer was only good for cakes. I could think of plenty of other things I'd like him to help me with.

When we'd finished scraping the remainder of the cake off the sidewalk, he carried the box around back and threw it in the dumpster for me.

"Thank you for your help," I said. "Did you want to come inside and wash your hands?" I wiggled my icing-crusting fingers out in front of me and he released a deep bark of laughter.

"I'd like that very much." Using his elbow, he maneuvered the door to my shop open, careful to avoid getting icing on the glass door. "After you,"

he said with a nod.

I must have died and gone to heaven. The freaking manners on this wolver.

I turned my head to hide the blush blooming over my freckled cheeks, leading him past the display cases of baked goods that lined the lobby. When I looked behind me, I saw him stealing glances at the towering bright white wedding cakes dotted with buttercream roses in muted pinks and yellows that covered every surface.

“These look amazing,” he said. “You’re very talented.” I wanted to preen over his praise. Until I remembered what just happened, that is.

“I’m talented when they make it to the wedding instead of ending up on the sidewalk.” I shook my head and turned on the tap of the kitchen washbasin. When the water ran warm, I put my hands under the spray and set to work scrubbing off the icing, watching as thick gobs settled along the drain. What a shame. Cream cheese was my favorite, too.

I dried off my hands and erupted with laughter when I turned around to face him. He looked like a deer caught in the headlights as the wide pad of his tongue flicked out to lick the icing off his fingertips.

“Uhh. I can explain,” he blurted, shoving his hands behind his back. “See, it just looked and smelled so good and cream cheese is my favorite...I couldn’t help myself.” His ears lay flat against his head and those twin moons widened into total puppy-dog eyes.

“Cream cheese is my favorite, too. But if you wanted to try it, all you had to do was ask. I would have been happy to give you some that—you know—didn’t fall on the ground.”

He smiled down his muzzle at me as I stepped out of the way to make room for him at the sink. Due to his height, he had to bend over considerably to wash his hands. It made total sense that he worked at a gym. His tight shorts clung to his ass, and I swear you could bounce a quarter off that thing. He probably did squats. Lots and lots of squats.

I could see him in the gym, a heavy bar slung over his back, the fluffy tip of his tail brushing the floor as he squatted down. The tight muscles of his ass clenching on his way back to a standing position.

Shit.

The image had heat pooling low in my belly.

He turned off the water and spun around to face me, running a wet hand along the back of his head. “Do you think I could take you up on that offer? To try some, that is?” His eyes scrunched up with his smile.

He was adorable.

“It’s the least I can do for you after you helped me with that mess. Follow me.” I wanted to grab his hand and pull him along beside me, but I resisted the urge, motioning for him to follow me instead. I stopped in front of the double refrigerator and he almost crashed into me. Almost. Like our bodies colliding would have been a bad thing, right?

Gripping the handles, I opened the doors to reveal rows of perfectly decorated cupcakes, all ready to eat.

“Wow,” he said. A tiny bead of drool formed in the corner of his mouth, and his tail swayed from side to side. “How can I possibly choose?”

He’d leaned closer to the racks of sweet treats, looking them over. His nostrils flared, inhaling the sugary scent of the cupcakes, and he let out a small whine—like he was struggling to make a decision—and it broke my heart.

He’d stopped to help me when he could have just walked by. I could do better than one cupcake.

“Wait here for just a second,” I said before rushing out of the kitchen and into the lobby. I grabbed one of the cupcake boxes from the stack on the counter and carried it back to where he was standing at the fridge.

“Why don’t I just give you a mixed dozen? That way you don’t have to choose. And you know where to find me. You can always come back for more.” In fact, I’d love it if he came back so I could get another eyeful of those delicious glutes again.

He looked down at his feet and scrubbed a hand along the back of his neck. “Really? Are you sure?”

How could a gigantic monster be so fucking darling?

“Mhm. Positive.” I nodded eagerly and passed him the box while I carefully filled it with cupcakes.

After I'd placed the last cupcake in the box, I carefully closed the lid and smiled up at him. We stood there, gazing at each other for a few beats before my phone buzzed.

"Shoot," I said as I wrangled it out of my pocket to shut off the alarm. "I have to get going."

His expression dropped slightly. "Oh, right. The wedding. Ha, it's kind of important that the cake is there."

Together we walked to the front of the shop, and while I locked the door, he waited patiently.

"Thank you again for the cupcakes." His tail wagged as he spoke.

"Thank you for helping me with the cake."

"I meant what I said. If you need help, you know where to find me." He grinned, his sharp teeth on full display, and gave me a little wave before heading off toward the gym.

What even was that?

Maybe Selene should call out sick more often.

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Four



ATLAS

FROM THE MOMENT I SAW her scraping cake off the sidewalk, my tail had wagged nonstop. She was adorable, all soft curves and smooth skin. Her emerald green eyes were rimmed red as tears tracked over the smattering of light brown freckles on her cheeks. There was no way I could walk by and leave her to handle that mess alone. I just couldn't.

As I walked back to the gym with a box of cupcakes in my hands and a stupid smile plastered to my muzzle, I realized I'd made a mistake. I hadn't even gotten her name. I should have gotten her number.

Right?

When I was washing my hands, I could have sworn she was checking out my ass. It made me feel better about the fact that when she was washing *her* hands, I was checking out her ass, too.

It looked so full and soft. Perfect for resting my head on.

Fuck.

This was the first time since I'd ended things with Jade that I felt even the tiniest inkling of attraction to someone, and boy, was I feeling it in a big way. I needed to calm down or everyone at the gym would see the boner I was sporting underneath my shorts.

I took a deep breath in through my nose and tried to send my thoughts drifting back to something else before I passed through the gym doors.

Fallon made that one easy for me.

“Hey, A-man! How goes it, bro?” Fallon’s beak clicked with each word, his beady bird eyes blinking at me assessingly.

“Hey, my guy. Uh, just getting back from that bakery down the street.” I raised the box of cupcakes and headed for my office, with him following close behind.

“The bakery?” he asked. “What were you doing there?”

“I helped the owner out.” I set the box of cupcakes on my desk and opened the lid. The tantalizing aroma of vanilla, lemon, and raspberry wafted out of the box and I licked my lips. “Help yourself,” I said to Fallon. “Goddess knows I don’t need all of them.”

“Psh, you’re bulking, man. It would take more than a box of cupcakes to throw off your gains. You look great.”

I flexed in the mirror behind my desk, admiring the progress I’d made since my breakup six months ago. Yeah, it had fucking hurt, but damn did it help to push me at the gym.

“See?” Fallon mumbled through a beak full of icing. “You’re fucking ripped.”

I sighed and sat down in my desk chair, hitting the power button on my computer to boot it up for the day. When I opened the gym, I thought I’d spend the majority of my time working with clients and training, but in reality, I spent most of my time doing clerical shit and writing checks. I desperately needed to hire someone for this.

“Do you need something?” I asked, typing in the password for my computer.

“I know you’re busy with the wedding this weekend, but I was wondering if you wanted to hit the club with me next weekend. We can—”

“Dude, I told you. Clubs just aren’t for me. I don’t drink. I don’t do random hookups, and besides, I just met someone—” I snapped my muzzle shut before I spilled the last part. The last thing I needed was this giant chicken trying to play matchmaker.

Fallon stared at me, the wheels in his bird brain turning until it finally clicked. “There’s someone you’re interested in.”

Shit. I’d really done it now.

I groaned and dragged my claws through my fur. “I mean, I guess so?”

“Who?” he asked.

“The woman who owns the bakery down the street was loading up a cake and she dropped it. She was kneeling on the sidewalk crying so I stopped to help her.”

“Okay. And? That sounds like your typical nice-guy shit, if you ask me.”

“I just—I don’t know. She made me feel things.”

“Like what sort of things?” he asked. He was so invested in our conversation that he was on the edge of his seat, nearly leaning over my desk.

“I haven’t been attracted to someone like that in a long time,” I admitted.

“Oh. My. Gods,” he shrieked. “And I thought this day was never going to come.”

I balled up a piece of paper and tossed it at him. “Shut up.”

“Did you get her number?”

“No,” I snapped, rearing back. “That would have been weird.”

He sighed, rubbing his temple with his talons like I was a massive disappointment. “You have been out of this for so long that you have absolutely no game. You should have asked for her number. Or at least given her your card.”

“I told her where I work and to let me know if she ever needs help.”

“You need to do more than that if you’re interested in her, though.” He was quiet for a second, then bolted upright. “You know what—was the cake for the wedding tonight?”

“Yeah, why?”

“Didn’t you say the mayor invited everyone from the local businesses? If she owns the bakery and made the cake, she’s probably going to be there tonight.”

My ears perked up at the prospect of seeing her again. “You’re right.”

I had to give Fal credit. He was smarter than he looked.

“Dude. You totally have a crush on her.”

“I do not. I just—want to get to know her better.” Wow. That didn’t sound convincing at all.

“You know what they say. The best way to get over someone is to get under somebody else.”

“It isn’t like that.” Sure, my mystery woman was attractive, but hooking up with her wasn’t a priority—at least not yet.

“You sure you don’t want to take me as your wingman?” he suggested.

“No way. If she’s there, I don’t need you scaring her away.”

“I’m so proud of you,” he said, wiggling his shoulders excitedly. “It’s like my little pup is all grown up.”

I rolled my eyes. “Get out of here. I have a lot of work to do if I want to make it out of here in time for the wedding.”

He stood in front of the desk, staring down at me like he was some superior life-form. “Yeah, yeah. All right. I can take a hint. But if you change your mind, send me a text.”

“Will do,” I said with an eye roll as I watched him walk out the door.

There was no way I was going to text him, but one thing was for sure: The prospect of seeing her again made attending the wedding a lot more appealing.

Five



TEGAN

"NO, MOM. IT ENDED UP turning out okay. I had the sheet cake as backup, just like you taught me," I said while lying in bed eating popcorn, my phone resting on my tits.

After the disaster that was this morning, I'd spent the rest of the day trying to decompress before the wedding. That meant rotting in bed, binge-watching my favorite TV show, and eating snacks.

"And what about the guy who helped you clean up the cake?" she asked. "You said he was cute."

Oh man, I fucked up. I should have left out that detail in my text message to her.

"He was so hot, Mom. This big, buff wolverine. He owns that gym on Main Street, Leviathan Fitness."

"Oh, a wolverine. My friend's niece dates a wolverine over in Rock Harbor. She says he's adorable, and a true gentleman, too. Did you get this guy's number, honey?" I could hear the hope in her voice. If anyone was aware of the ticking of my biological clock, it was my mother. She started pestering me about having children the moment I turned twenty-five.

"No. I didn't even get his name. Or tell him mine," I groaned, and pulled a pillow over my head.

"Tegan, honey, you said he owns the gym. Why don't you just go down there?"

“I don’t want to seem like some crazed stalker.”

“You’re going to have to do something if you want to see this guy again.”

I sighed. “I’ll think about it.”

“Tegan—”

“So do you need a ride to the wedding?” I asked, steering the conversation away from my nonexistent love life.

I loved my mother dearly, but when it came to alcohol, especially cheap wine, she was known to overindulge. There was no way I was letting her drive herself.

“Nope. Your brother is my chauffeur for the evening.”

Shit.

My older brother, Reece, was the head park ranger of the Briar Glenn Parks Department, working closely with the mayor. Of course he wouldn’t miss the wedding.

“Lovely,” I huffed.

“Tegan,” she admonished, like only a mother could. “The two of you are family. You’re going to have to work things out at some point.”

Since our father’s death, Reece had taken over the role of the Rollins family paterfamilias. As far as I was concerned, he’d taken things a little too seriously, turning into a completely overbearing dick.

“All right, well, I’m gonna go,” I said, totally ignoring what she’d just said. I’d work things out with Reece when he pulled his head out of his ass, and that wasn’t happening anytime soon. “I have to get in the shower and start getting ready.”

“Okay, honey. I’ll see you later. Love you.”

“Love you, too, Mom. Bye.”

As soon as the call disconnected, I pulled up the browser on my phone and typed “Leviathan Fitness” into the search bar. I don’t know why I didn’t think of this earlier. I mean, we lived in the age of the internet. You could find all the dirt on a person you wanted.

I was completely contradicting myself by going full-on stalker, but I guess it didn’t really matter at this point. Might as well lean on into it.

The very first hit was a website that showed pictures of the gym in all its glory. State-of-the-art equipment, loads of free weights and racks, and an Olympic-size swimming pool with tentacles snaking out from beneath the water's surface. I couldn't believe it was the same run-down rec center from my childhood.

My finger hovered over the About button.

Fuck it.

I clicked on the link, and a professional headshot of the wolverine I'd run into earlier filled the screen. My lips parted and a breathy sigh of appreciation slipped out. Just like this morning, he was dressed in a Leviathan Fitness tank top that strained against his muscular chest.

Jesus, he was hot.

Below the photo was an About the Owner section.

Atlas Oberon

Owner

Atlas Oberon is the owner of Leviathan Fitness. After being bullied as a child, Atlas found a passion for fitness in his teen years. He was captain of his high school varsity football and wrestling teams—leading both to win state championship titles.

He attended Brighton Valley College on a full-ride scholarship for wrestling, where he obtained a bachelor's degree in kinesiology, going on to complete his master of science in kinesiology. For several years, he competed in the professional bodybuilding circuit, winning numerous medals for his physique. Atlas has trained professional athletes, bodybuilders, and even a few celebrities.

After his retirement from bodybuilding, he combined his love for fitness and entrepreneurial aspirations by opening a state-of-the-art gym—Leviathan Fitness.

Atlas was raised in upstate New York, and he is the youngest of three male wolverines. He enjoys cheat meals, long hikes through the

woods, and of course, working out.

Below the About the Owner section was a series of competition photos of Atlas. He stood tall and proud, that furry muscular chest on full display. A shiny gold medal hung around his neck, sitting just above a cut six-pack.

Wait, wait, wait.

I slid my fingers across the phone screen, zooming in.

Was that an eight-pack?

My eyes drifted lower, to the skimpy banana hammock covering his crotch. The entire outline of his cock was visible through the thin piece of material. It was massive—like he was trying to smuggle a can of Pringles into the competition.

I was drooling.

My thoughts circled back to how he looked as he cleaned the icing off his fingers with that wide pink tongue. I bet he ate pussy like a champ.

And those sharp claws and those muscles. He had to have some serious stamina.

His soft fur rubbing against my naked body would feel like heaven.

My free hand slid down my stomach, under the band of my underwear, to the slick folds of my pussy. I was already wet. Embarrassingly wet. Hot and achy from just a photo of Atlas. I slid two fingers inside, pulsing them in and out a few times, filling the room with obscene, sloppy sounds.

This was so fucked up. Masturbating to a photo of someone I'd just met.

"Atlas." I moaned his name experimentally, loving the way it sounded on a breathy exhale.

I stroked the wet folds of my center, swirling two fingers over my clit before withdrawing my hand and scrambling toward my nightstand.

Opening the drawer, I pulled out my biggest vibrator and wondered how it compared to Atlas's cock.

Would I be able to take him?

Would it hurt?

Did I want it to?

I imagined there would be pleasure mixed with pain. The most delicious kind, the type that I craved. My sexual encounters had been subpar at best. I needed someone with dominant energy. Someone who would take control and use my body, getting me out of my head so I could let go and enjoy myself. I was willing to bet money on the fact that Atlas was that type.

With a buzz, I started up my vibrator and worked it inside of me as I centered the suctioning head over my clit.

“Yes, Atlas, yes,” I moaned as I looked over the photo, taking in every crease and shadow created by his muscles.

I rocked my hips, fucking my vibe and wishing it was him. Wishing the big bad wolf would huff and puff and give me the best orgasm of my life.

My belly started to feel tight, the tension building until it finally snapped, sending waves of pleasure coursing through me.

“Ahh! Fuck!” I screamed as warm liquid gushed out of my body and onto the bed, my legs shaking with the force of my orgasm.

I threw my head back against the pillow, my eyes focused on the ceiling as I panted to try to catch my breath.

Apparently, all it took to give me an earth-shattering orgasm was just a picture of Atlas. The mere image of him doing devious things to me had pushed me over the edge.

But what would it be like to have the real thing?

Six



TEGAN

IT WAS A BEAUTIFUL EARLY-FALL day. Clear blue skies, a light breeze, the last rays of the summer sun warming my skin.

Perfect for a wedding.

My wedding.

I was standing on the church steps, wearing the dress of my dreams. A vintage cream-colored gown that hugged my body in all the right places.

Clenched between my sweaty palms was a bouquet of all my favorite flowers. They were fresh and fragrant, like I'd plucked them from my own garden for this very special day.

Behind the heavy church doors, the organ groaned and the bridal march began to play. I stared down at my feet, taking a steadying breath before walking inside.

The church was packed to the eaves with rows and rows of Briar Glenn residents. Everyone lining the pews whipped their heads around to watch me stroll down the aisle, but their faces were a blur—I only had eyes for him.

At the end of the aisle, dressed in a perfectly tailored gray suit—

A round of applause erupted around me, and my mother nudged my shoulder, urging me to join in.

“Oh my gods,” I murmured, shaking off the fantasy that had so easily slipped into my mind. I hadn't realized I was so desperate to get married

that I'd fantasize about it at someone else's wedding.

Mr. and Mrs. Costas had just cut the cake—a two-layered one, not the massive three-layered one we planned—and I had spaced out for the entire thing. As the baker of such an important cake, I should have been proud. Invested. But I was too preoccupied to care.

“The cake looks lovely,” my mom said sincerely. “Great job, honey.”

I took a sip of my mocktail, recalling the interesting string of events leading up to this moment. “I'm just glad we have the sheet cake. It wouldn't have been enough to feed all these guests if we didn't.”

Scanning the reception hall, I took stock of who was in attendance, because I'd have to make my rounds at some point.

There was Brian, the owner of the Busy Bean, the only coffee shop in Briar Glenn. Spencer and her mom Daria, the owner of the Briar Glenn Bookshop. My centaur neighbors stood at one of the high-top tables, happily chatting while they ate their cake, and I laughed to myself, remembering Declan's suggestion of becoming their third.

That's when someone tucked into a table at the very back of the hall caught my eye.

Even with the low lighting, his massive body was hard to miss.

It was Atlas.

He was dressed in a deep gray suit that matched the color of his fur. It looked like it was custom tailored for him, perfectly fitted to accommodate his broad shoulders and burly arms. He was hot in workout clothes, but in a suit? He was stunning.

And I was going to talk to him.

I snatched my clutch from the table, pulling out my compact to give my makeup a once-over before scooching back from the table.

“Where are you going?” Mom asked.

“He's here, Mom.”

She cocked her head. “Honey, half of Briar Glenn is here. I'm gonna need a little more than that.”

“The guy who helped me clean up the cake,” I hissed. “The wolveren.”

“Where?” Her eyes lit up and she searched the room like her head was on a swivel.

“Way to be obvious.” I tipped my head in his direction. “He’s over there.”

She pushed her glasses up her nose, staring *right* where he was seated. Pamela Rollins was many things, but discreet wasn’t one of them. “Oh, Tegan. He is a total hottie.”

“I told you!” I mean, those weren’t my exact words, but she wasn’t wrong.

“And he’s sitting all by himself,” she said dejectedly, still staring in Atlas’s direction. Luckily, he didn’t seem to notice. “You should go talk to him.”

“What do you think I’m doing?”

“She should go talk to who?” My brother, Reece, joined us at the table.

“It’s none of your business,” I snapped.

Reece’s light red brows drew back. Like me and my mother, he was on the ginger spectrum. “Excuse me? As your big brother, it is my business.”

Before I could stab my brother with a fork, Mom chimed in. “Tegan met someone. He helped her clean up the wedding cake she dropped this morning.”

“You dropped the cake?” The way Reece said it was a little too judgy for my liking. Like how he’d reacted when I got a C+ in phys ed my sophomore year at Briar Glenn High.

“It was heavy, and Selene wasn’t there to help me,” I said, matter-of-factly.

“You should really start working out,” Reece said, taking a big bite of his cake. My brother was the poster boy for physical fitness. Biking, running, rock climbing. He practically lived for exercise. But he also had an intense sweet tooth. “So, what’s his deal?”

“He owns that new gym on Main Street,” I said.

“You know, in the old rec center where you and Tegan used to take swimming lessons,” Mom added.

“Hmph,” Reece grumbled around a mouthful of cake.

In his eyes, no one would ever be good enough for me, and it was clear he wasn't impressed.

He was just going to have to suck it up, though.

I was a grown woman. I didn't need—or want—my brother's approval.

I stood and straightened my dress. "All right, I'm going now."

"Attagirl, honey," Mom said. "Make me proud."

Before Reece could voice any more complaints, I started to make my way across the room to Atlas's table.

He was still sitting by himself, so distracted by everything going on around him that he didn't notice me approaching.

"Atlas?" I said, gently placing my hand on his shoulder. "Fancy seeing you here."

Shit.

Now how was I going to explain that? *Oh, hey, Atlas. You never told me your name, but I looked you up on the internet like the total stalker I am. Masturbated to a photo of you. Squirted all over my sheets. You know, the usual.*

Blessed goddess, I was absolutely losing it.

"Oh!" His golden eyes widened and his muzzle scrunched into a smile. He seemed genuinely excited to see me. "Hey!"

"Hi." I slipped my hand away, pointing at the empty seat next to him. "Do you mind if I sit?"

"No, not at all." Like a gentleman, he slid the chair out for me. "I, uh, I realized I never got your name this morning," he said bashfully, his ears drooping slightly on either side of his head.

Fucking adorable.

"Tegan," I said, a little too enthusiastically. "I'm Tegan." I held out my palm and his giant hand enveloped mine, giving it a soft shake.

"Tegan," he said with a hum. The way my name sounded, rumbling out of his chest, made my stomach flip. "That's a very pretty name."

I could feel all the blood rush to my face and I'm pretty sure I looked like a walking, talking tomato. "Thank you," I forced out.

A+ flirting game, Teg.

“I’m Atlas, but it sounds like you already knew that.” He grinned and his bright yellow eyes twinkled as he looked down at me.

“I, um, I might have looked you up. Looked the gym up,” I rushed to add. “I remembered your tank top and looked up the gym.” Ha, I certainly did remember his tank top and the way it clung to his pecs. I’m pretty sure I could see his nipples peeking through the material.

He nodded and his upper canine dug into his bottom lip. “Ah, I see.” Damn, he was smug.

Was it just my imagination or was he flirting with me just now?

I looked around at the empty table, wondering if everyone had jumped ship because he was the new guy in town, when I noticed the place card in front of me.

MR. OBERON’S GUEST.

Was he here with someone?

“Did you bring a date?” I asked, feeling bold.

Maybe he did but they were in the bathroom? Or they were mingling? There was no way a guy like him was here by—

He shook his head, that canine digging deeper into his lip like he was fighting back a grin. “No date.”

“Me, neither.” I wanted him to know that I was here alone, hoping it would convey the fact that I was single.

“If I’m being honest with you,” he said, “I’m not a huge fan of weddings. I wasn’t going to come, but I figured it would look bad if I didn’t. The mayor invited me personally.”

“Hmm,” I said, looking through the crowd for the mayor. When I spotted him, he was nursing an amber drink, likely a glass of bourbon, engaged in a lively conversation with the high school football coach. He was having the time of his life, enjoying his daughter’s special day. The last thing on his mind was the guest list. “Looks to me like he’s a little too preoccupied to keep tabs on who showed up and who didn’t.”

“Apparently so. Can’t say I regret coming, though.” The way his gaze swept over my body, slow and shameless, had heat rushing to my face again.

“I don’t regret coming, either,” I admitted. *Not now, and not earlier.*

“Are you going to eat your cake?” I asked, noticing the untouched slice sitting in front of him.

“Well, I demolished a box of cupcakes someone gave me, so I’m trying to watch my weight.”

I looked him up and down, making him shift in his seat. *Two could play that game.* “You look just fine to me.”

“You really think so?” There was nothing sarcastic about the way he asked. He seemed genuinely unsure of how good he looked in his suit.

“Absolutely. Now eat some of your cake,” I told him. “Didn’t you say cream cheese is your favorite?”

He picked up his fork, shoveled a big bite into his mouth, and nodded.

The lights dimmed and the DJ’s voice filled the reception hall. “Ladies and gentlemen, please put your hands together and welcome the newlyweds, Jessica and Todd, to the dance floor to share their first dance as husband and wife.”

They shuffled onto the dance floor, the groom’s hooves tapping against the floor as they slow-danced to some popular yet cliché Ed Sheeran song about falling in love.

“They look happy,” I said, with only a teeny tiny bit of jealousy. Someday it would be my chance.

“Yeah.” Atlas sighed. “They do.”

It was on the tip of my tongue to ask if he’d ever given any thought to marriage, but I decided against it because wow, what an insane question to ask someone you’d just met.

The song faded out, the newlyweds ending their dance number with a romantic kiss that made the hall erupt with applause and wolf whistles.

“What a beautiful first dance,” the DJ said over the loudspeaker. “Now Mr. and Mrs. Costas would like to invite you onto the dance floor to celebrate with them.”

A horn sounded three times, followed by a remix of a song I used to dance around my room to in high school. It had to be one of Jessica’s picks.

I leaned against Atlas's shoulder to whisper in his ear, "I used to love this song."

"Same. It was the intro song for my high school football team."

"How old are you?" I asked. We had to be around the same age.

"Thirty-two," he said, scrunching up his muzzle. "I'm getting old."

"I just turned thirty." In my eyes, a two-year age gap was perfect. "Do you want to dance?" I asked.

Would it even be possible for him to dance with how his suit was straining at the seams?

His ears drooped. "I, uh, I'm not much of a dancer."

Oh my gods, he was so cute. My heart was going to burst just by looking at him.

"Come on," I said, scooting out of my chair and holding my hand out to him. "It'll be fun. And I'll give you all the details about everyone in town."

Seven



ATLAS

I DIDN'T EVEN THINK TWICE. I just grabbed Tegan's hand and let her lead me to the dance floor. A pop song with a catchy beat pulsed through the speakers, and I swear half the town of Briar Glenn was out there dancing.

"I have no idea what I'm doing," I shouted over the music. I swayed on my feet awkwardly, trying to find my rhythm. I didn't dance, but I couldn't bring myself to tell her no.

"Just start moving your body to the beat," Tegan said, rolling her shoulders and shimmying her hips. On anyone else it would have looked innocent enough, but with her soft curves and rhythmic movements, it was seductive.

I stood there rooted to the spot, the only one on the dance floor who wasn't dancing, because I was absolutely mesmerized by her.

"Here," she said, gently pulling me closer.

There was still a respectable amount of space between us—enough for that whole "pretend there's a balloon between you" thing they enforced at prom—but I still wasn't getting the motions right.

Tegan reached up, placing her hand on my shoulder, making me rock with her to the beat of the music. "This okay?" she asked.

I appreciated that she was checking in with me, but it was more than okay. I liked her touching me. I wanted her to be closer. I wanted to feel her body rubbing against mine.

I grabbed her hip, splaying my fingers on her lower back right above her ass, tugging her to me until our bodies were pressed together. I could feel her breath skitter in her chest, and I leaned in to whisper in her ear, “This okay?”

She glanced up at me, those green eyes wide and almost hungry. She nodded, a slow smile playing on her lips.

“Good,” I purred, my lips grazing the shell of her ear.

I straightened up, moving my body in sync with hers, feeling her breasts brush against me. I wanted to slide my hand lower and cup her ass, but I stopped myself.

What was this woman doing to me?

We danced like that for a few songs, our bodies grinding against each other without a care in the world. Tegan was so comfortable with herself. Confident. It was hot.

Jade would have never danced with me like that. We would have sat at the table while she played on her phone.

Tegan tugged my tie, pulling me down toward her. “Do you want to take a break?” she asked. Her chest was heaving and her skin was slick and shiny with sweat.

More than once while we were dancing I’d had to shift my pelvis away from her, absolutely afraid of rubbing my half boner against her like some sort of creep. I couldn’t help it when it came to her.

Fuck, I needed to put some distance between us.

I stepped back and nodded, letting Tegan lead me back to our table.

“That’s the most fun I’ve had in a while,” I said, collapsing in my seat.

“I told you it would be fun!”

“You did.” I reached for my glass, but it was empty. And so was the pitcher on the table. “Shoot.”

“Oh, I need a drink, too.”

“Allow me—” I said, but she was already getting up.

“You just relax.” She leaned over, grabbing the pitcher, putting her breasts right in my face. I wasn’t sure if it was accidental or on purpose, but

it certainly didn't help the whole boner situation. She gave my shoulder a little shake. "You deserve it after showing me all your moves."

I laughed, knowing I'd probably embarrassed myself, but I was too happy to care. Running into Tegan again was exactly what I'd hoped for. Getting the chance to dance with her was just a bonus.

"Beer? Wine? Champagne?" she asked.

"Water, please. I don't drink. Did enough of that in college to last a lifetime."

She smiled then, so goddamn bright and beautiful. "Me, neither. Water it is, then."

Before I could offer to go with her, she started to walk away. I couldn't take my eyes off her, mesmerized by the sway of her hips and the slow jiggle of her ass with each of her steps.

On the way to the bar, she was stopped by a few people. It was like she was the sun and they were pulled in by her.

I was being pulled in, too.

"What are you doing, Atlas?" I asked myself, tipping my head back and taking a deep breath.

I'd just met the girl and here I was pining over her like she was some long-lost love. It was too soon.

Too soon since I'd met her and too soon since my breakup with Jade.

Before I knew it, Tegan was back, setting a pitcher full of ice water in front of me. "Here you go."

"Thank you." I filled a cup for her, then one for me.

"You're welcome." She took a long drink, and I watched her throat bob as she swallowed. When she set her cup back down, there was a smudge on the glass from her lips, and what I would have given to have her mouth on me like that.

Her brows pinched together, an adorable little furrow forming between them. "Everything okay?"

"Mhm." I loosened my tie and unbuttoned my shirt collar. "Just feeling a little warm, is all." It wasn't an outright lie. I was hot—but *I was also hot for her*.

The way she bit her lip while looking at me only made it worse. “Why don’t we step outside and get some fresh air? There’s a beautiful garden around back.”

Me and her, alone in a beautiful garden?

She didn’t need to ask me twice.

“That sounds great.”

I followed behind her as she made her way across the room. More people stopped her to chat, and she happily introduced me to each and every one of them. Once we were out of earshot, she’d give me a little anecdote about them, a story from when she was a kid or something she’d heard through the town gossip mill. It was obvious she’d lived here for a long time and was well loved by the people in town.

When we reached the exit, I held the door open for her and we stepped outside. Tegan led the way to the garden, with me following behind her. In fact, I’d been following her around all evening, but I wasn’t mad about it one bit. The wedding would be over before I knew it, and I hadn’t even asked for her number yet.

“Thank you for introducing me to everyone back there,” I said.

“It’s no problem,” she said over her shoulder, still leading me down the path.

“You know, I was hoping I’d run into you tonight.”

“Were you?” she asked.

“Mhm.”

“And why is that?” she asked coyly.

“Who doesn’t want to see a friendly face among a sea of strangers?” I was too scared to tell her the truth.

“Darn,” she said, sounding genuinely sad. “I was hoping you were going to say you just wanted to see me again.”

I swallowed hard, trying to work up the nerve for what I was about to ask. “And what would you have thought if I said that?”

She stopped, turning to face me. “Maybe I wanted to see you again, too.”

I opened my mouth to say something, but I was at a loss for words. This woman was stirring up feelings in me. Feelings my wagging tail was giving away.

She smirked before turning around again, leading us down a tree-lined path that led to an open courtyard. A fountain bubbled in the center, surrounded by bare bushes with tiny unopened buds. The garden wasn't much to look at now, but in a few weeks it would be alive with the colors and scents of spring.

Tegan sat on a bench near the fountain, shuddering when her butt touched the cool concrete.

It was the middle of April, but the Northeast was late to get the memo. At night there was a noticeable nip in the air.

"It's beautiful." She stared up at the night sky and I stared at her, admiring the way she seemed to glow under the moonlight.

"Sure is," I said mindlessly.

Tonight was a waning crescent, the faintest sliver of silver hanging in the sky, but what I'd give to see her under the rays of the full moon.

As a wolven, the thought shook me up a little bit.

We were different under the full moon. Wild and feral, running through the woods with our packs, or with our mates, and in my case—alone.

I wasn't sure if I could trust myself to keep my composure around her during the full moon.

The thought hit me like a ton of bricks. *Why was I even thinking about that?*

"Atlas?" Tegan's voice pulled me out of my stupor.

I cleared my throat. "Yes?"

"I asked you if you like living here."

"Oh yeah. I do. I liked it from the moment I first visited. It has a small-town feel, but there are enough businesses in town and cities to visit nearby. It reminds me a lot of where I grew up, actually."

"And where was that?" she asked.

"Pinewood. A tiny town in upstate New York."

"Hmm. Never heard of it."

“I would have been shocked if you had. There’s not a lot going on there. When I was a teenager, I was in such a rush to get away from it, but after going to college and a few years working in the city, I was ready to get back to the pace of small-town life again—if that makes sense.” I conveniently left out the parts about Jade, and how everything fell apart after my move here. That wasn’t something I needed to share with someone I’d just met, especially not someone I was interested in.

She nodded. “It makes total sense.”

“What about you?” I asked.

“My family has been here for generations. It’s all I’ve ever known.”

A slight breeze blew by, rustling the leaves of the trees around us, making her shudder again.

“Tegan, you’re freezing,” I said, noticing the goose bumps pebbling her bare skin. In our rush to get out of the reception hall, she’d forgotten her coat.

“I’m—”

Before she could tell me she was fine, I was already taking off my jacket. I draped it around her shoulders and it practically swallowed her whole.

She pulled it tighter, snuggling into it. “Thank you.”

“No problem.” I shimmied closer in the hopes that some of my body heat would radiate into her.

Or maybe I just wanted to be close to her.

I’m sure it was because Briar Glenn was a small town, but it was twice now that we’d run into each other. It felt like more than just a coincidence. Or maybe I was just trying to convince myself that was the case.

“Tell me the truth. Did you really want to see me again?” I asked because I needed to know how she felt. I wanted confirmation that whatever this was between us, she felt it, too.

Tegan looked up at me through her lashes, making my chest feel tight. “Yes,” she whispered.

I leaned in closer, until I felt her breath flutter against the tip of my nose, and—

A loud voice boomed through the garden, shattering the moment. "Tegan!" It was a man's voice.

"You have got to be kidding me," she huffed, peering through the trees toward the venue.

I leaned over her, following her line of sight. A guy paced back and forth on the terrace, the glow of the reception hall catching his fiery red hair.

"Who's that?" I asked.

"My idiot brother." Tegan sighed. "Come on. Let's get this over with." She grabbed my hand, gently dragging me along with her. She was surprisingly strong for how small she was.

When we stepped onto the terrace, her brother stared at our joined hands. His gaze shifted upward, his eyes narrowing on me.

"Why don't you come back inside? Aren't you getting cold out here?" he asked, addressing her and ignoring me completely.

"We were just fine. Right?" She stared up at me, giving my hand a little squeeze.

My eyes snapped between her and her brother, taking in her hopeful expression and his heated gaze. Fuck, it was awkward.

"I, uh, I should get going," I said, slipping my hand out of Tegan's grip. "I have an early morning at the gym tomorrow."

"Oh, um, okay." From the tone of her voice, she was obviously upset, but I couldn't stand another awkward moment of whatever this was.

She passed me my jacket, wrapping her bare arms around herself. "I'll see you around."

I nodded. "You know where to find me."

Her brother stood there silent as a sentry, glaring at me so intensely, it made my skin crawl.

What was with this guy?

"Have a good night," Tegan said half-heartedly.

"You, too." I gave her a little wave before I turned to walk away.

I heard her brother ask, "What were you doing out there?"

“That’s not really any of your business, now, is it?” Her reply was full of sass.

“You’re my sister,” he snapped. “Of course it’s my business.”

I stopped in my tracks, listening to the two of them bicker as they walked inside. One thing was for sure—even if Tegan was interested in me, her brother definitely didn’t approve.

Not that it mattered anyway. We were two people who were swept up in the moment. That was it. That’s all it would ever be.

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Eight



TEGAN

THE OVERHEAD BELL OF THE bakery tinkled and my eyes immediately snapped to the door.

Ever since the wedding, I'd been trapped in some Pavlovian hell, conditioned to think that each time the bell of the bakery rang, it was going to be Atlas. So far, I'd been sorely disappointed.

Just like I was right now as Brian, the owner of the Busy Bean, walked through the door.

"Hey, Brian. How are you today?" I put on my best customer service voice, forcing myself to sound more upbeat than I felt.

"I'm doing great," he said, flashing that perfect boy-next-door smile he was known for. "Just stopping in to pick up the kolaches." He held up a cardboard drink carrier with two Busy Bean to-go cups inside of it. "I brought you and Selene lattes."

"Thank you. That was so sweet of you."

"It's the least I can do for you, since you're special-making these for me."

At a coffee convention in Texas, he'd fallen in love with kolaches. Apparently, they weren't a thing in our area, so he'd recruited me to supply them for the coffee shop.

I pulled the box from the display case and slid it across the counter. "There's cherry, apple, and cream cheese in there, but I was thinking we

could try strawberry in the summer.”

“Strawberry would be great.” He stood there for a minute, awkwardly staring at me.

“Is there anything else I can do for you?”

“Uh, I was wondering—” It was obvious he was working up the courage to ask whatever it was that was on his mind. “Was that guy you were with at the wedding your boyfriend?” Poor guy blurted the last part in a single breath. It was so rushed, I almost missed it.

“No. He’s just—” I hesitated for a second. Could I call Atlas a friend? Or was he more of an acquaintance? We’d almost kissed, but I didn’t really know him. Not nearly as well as I wanted to. “He’s a friend.”

“Um, you know. If you aren’t seeing anyone, I would love to take you out sometime.” Brian looked at me pleadingly, his crystal-blue puppy-dog eyes full of hope.

Interesting.

The last I’d heard, he was dating Spencer from the bookstore. They looked awfully friendly at the wedding, but from the way Atlas and I were dancing together that night, I guessed we did, too.

“That’s really sweet of you, but I’ve been devoting a lot of time to the bakery and I’m not sure there’s a place in my life for dating right now.” It was a total lie, of course. I was looking to date someone—just not him.

To most people, Brian would have been a catch.

He was an attractive guy. Blond hair. Ice-blue eyes. Nice, polite business owner. As his smile suggested, he gave off real boy-next-door vibes. But he was almost *too* nice. Too much of a pushover.

Hurt flashed across his face but he quickly shuttered his expression. “Oh yeah. I’m pretty busy with the coffee shop, too, so I get it.”

I nodded, unsure of what to say next.

It was at that moment the overhead bell rang again, and my gaze shot right to the front door. It wasn’t Atlas, but I’d never been happier to see Dec, because if there was anyone who could save me from this awkwardness, it was him.

“Hey there, Bri Bri,” Dec said, strolling right up to Brian. He slipped his oversize sunglasses down his nose, looking Brian up and down. “Don’t you look nice today.” He wiggled his brows for good measure, and I bit back a laugh. This was the perfect interruption.

“Uh, thanks, Dec.” Brian grabbed the kolaches. His body shifted between me and Dec, like he was glitching out. Poor guy. “Well, I better get back,” he finally said once he rebooted.

“But why?” Dec pouted. “I just got here.”

“Sorry,” Brian said. “I’ll see you both around. Bye, Tegan.”

“Bye. And thank you again for the lattes,” I said, throwing him a wave as he slipped out the door.

Dec kept his gaze locked on Brian until he disappeared down the street, then turned his attention to me. “What the fuck was that about?”

“Shouldn’t you be at the diner?” I asked. If I wasn’t mistaken, it was about time for the lunch rush, and here he was hitting on innocent bystanders and yapping with me.

“The old man wanted to work the lunch shift, and who am I to deny him? Besides, I wanted to check in on you. You’ve been in a mood since the wedding.”

“Brian just asked me out,” I told him, pivoting the subject away from Atlas and the wedding.

“You lucky bitch,” Dec scoffed. I knew that would get his attention.

“Hardly.”

“So you turned him down?” he asked.

I nodded. “Of course I did.”

“Why? Brian is, like, the hottest guy in Briar Glenn. Other than your brother, that is.”

Dec calling Reece *hot* made me scrunch up my nose. “Gross.”

His eyes lit up and he slapped his hand against his chest. *Dramatic*. “Ah—I know why you said no. Holding out hope for our gym bro in shining athletic shorts. I’m assuming he still hasn’t shown his face around here?”

“Nope,” I said, popping the *p*.

How was it that I had been single for years, but the moment someone showed interest in me, it was a competition?

Why couldn't I stop thinking about him?

Every time I closed my eyes, that near kiss played in my mind. The masculine scent of his cologne lingering on his jacket, the warmth radiating off his body, the way his breath felt fluttering against my face, those golden eyes focused on me.

Everything was going great—until my stupid brother had to come along and ruin it. I could have kissed Atlas. I could have ignored Reece and kissed him. But if my brother caught us making out in the garden, he would have made an even bigger spectacle.

Exactly who did he think he was? My chaperone or something?

The look on Atlas's face was burned into my mind. It was heartbreaking. Mortifying, even.

Every day since the wedding I had hoped I would run into him. That he'd stop by the shop for some cupcakes, or we'd have a casual meet-cute at the grocery store.

But no such luck.

I grabbed the lattes and walked into the back of the bakery with Declan on my heels.

"Brian brought us lattes," I said, setting Selene's cup next to her on the counter.

"That was nice of him," she said without looking up from the donuts she was frosting. They were her new passion project, one that made a great addition to the bakery's offerings, so I was happy to let her experiment.

"He also asked Tegan out on a date," Dec added.

Her head snapped up so fast. "He what? I thought he was dating Spencer."

I shrugged. "I guess not."

"I like Brian," Selene said. "He's a nice guy."

What was this, some sort of Brian fan club?

"He's all right." I took a sip of my latte and let out a heavy sigh.

"How long are you going to mope?" Dec asked.

“I’m not moping. I’m just—sulking.” After the wedding, I’d filled her and Dec in with all of the juicy details: running into Atlas at the wedding, pulling him onto the dance floor, and how we’d almost kissed.

“Okay, well first, those are the same thing,” Dec corrected. “And second, the Tegan Rollins I know wouldn’t just sulk. She would do something about it.”

“He probably doesn’t want to see me again.” That whole “if he wanted to, he would” argument came to mind.

“Tegan—he almost kissed you,” Selene said. “I’m sure he wants to see you again.”

“That was before Reece showed up. Things got really awkward and he left.”

“I mean, I would feel awkward if Javi did something like that, but I wouldn’t let it ruin something for me,” Selene said before sipping her latte.

I snorted. “Javier would never do something like that, though.”

Javier was Selene’s older brother, this hotter-than-sin absolute golden retriever of a guy who worked with my brother at the Briar Glenn Parks Department. The two couldn’t have been more different, but somehow they made it work, forming a friendship as strong as the one Selene and I had.

“Regardless—it seems like you and Atlas really hit it off,” she said. “It would be a shame to miss out on something because of your idiot brother.”

She was right. I felt a real connection with Atlas and I wasn’t about to let my chance at happiness slip through my fingers.

But how—

“You know,” Dec said, a sly smile curling up the corner of his lips. “If you wanted to be low-key about it, you could always sign up for a gym membership. After the whole cake thing, you said you wanted to start working out. Sounds like kismet to me.”

I bit my lip, mulling the idea over for a moment. I definitely wanted to get stronger to avoid any future cake mishaps, and I needed a hobby outside of the bakery, but more than anything, I wanted an excuse to see Atlas again.

It didn't take me long to make my decision. "I'm gonna do it. I'm gonna sign up for a membership."

"That's the spirit!" Dec said, clapping his hands together like my own personal cheerleader.

"Why don't you run home and get your gym gear on and I'll hold down the fort here," Selene suggested.

Mentally I ran through my to-do list for the day. I had to make some scones for the Busy Bean, put the finishing touches on an excavator-themed birthday cake, and finish icing a large cupcake order. It was nothing Selene couldn't handle. It was about time I stopped micromanaging and passed some of the responsibility on to her.

If I wanted to have some semblance of a work-life balance, I needed to learn when to let go. When to let others step in for me from time to time.

This was one of those moments.

"Okay," I relented.

Her eyes lit up. "You're serious?"

"Yes, I'm serious."

She launched herself at me, hugging me tight. "I could kiss you."

I knew she'd be excited, but I hadn't expected her to be *that* excited. Maybe the bakery was becoming more than just a part-time job for her. If that was the case, it was going to be a tough pill for her parents to swallow...

"Promise you'll call me if you need anything."

"I promise." She released me, giving me a gentle shove toward the back door. "Now go. Get out of here and get your man."

"And Tegan," Dec said. "Make sure you wear something tight. You've got a great body. Put it to work."

Nine



ATLAS

SATURDAY MORNINGS WERE ONE OF my favorite times to hit the gym early. Four a.m. might seem obscene to some people, but I liked working out without an audience. While everyone was tucked safe and warm in their beds, sleeping off their hangovers from the night before, I was praying in the iron chapel.

My headphones blared some loud-as-fuck song into my ears as I grunted, heaving the loaded bar up over my body.

Just another rep, I told myself as my muscles burned, the satisfying ache spurring me on.

Push yourself just a little further.

Be better today than you were yesterday.

But it was hard to keep my focus when all I could think about was her.

Ever since the wedding, my thoughts seemed to gravitate back to Tegan.

On my way to the gym this morning, I smiled wide when I passed by the dark window of the bakery. If I wanted to see her again, I couldn't just stand around, waiting for fate to intervene. I had to take action.

Maybe I'd stop by when I left today—if I left at a reasonable hour.

Today I was manning the front desk for one of my trainers, Chai. She'd been having some medical issues lately, so I'd been filling in to pick up the slack. It was a nice change from the day-to-day minutiae of the office work

I was used to doing. I missed interacting with clients and helping them achieve their goals, whether it was weight loss or getting ripped.

I was particularly fond of the getting-ripped part.

When my set was finished, I placed the bar back on the rack and took a deep swig from my water bottle. Beads of sweat matted the fur on my forehead and dripped down into my eyes. I wiped it away with my towel before putting my hat on backward, pulling my ears through the holes at the top.

Catching my reflection in the mirror, I took a moment to look at myself. Really look at myself.

I was hot, right?

The heated gazes Tegan gave me at the wedding made me think so. It was such a stark contrast from the way Jade looked at me. If my body comp was anything less than perfect, she made me feel like shit about it. And then there was Tegan, eye-fucking me while she force-fed me cake, telling me I looked great exactly how I was.

It was refreshing.

Kael, one of our first members, sat down on the weight bench next to mine. He was a massive orc who owned the auto shop outside of town. The guy could bench a crazy amount of weight. Clients like him were the reason I bought the best equipment I could.

“Getting your workout in early this morning, Atlas?” Kael asked. I could just barely make out what he was saying over my music.

I pulled my earbuds out so we could have an actual conversation. “Yep. You know I like it when it’s quiet.”

He tugged his lifting gloves onto his large green hands. “Same.”

“You like being a member here so far?” I asked. I wanted to make sure my guests were having a good experience, so I always asked for feedback from our members.

“Oh yeah, it’s great. Open twenty-four hours, plenty of equipment. Uh, there’s something I wanted to ask you about, though.” I could have sworn his green cheeks flushed a little. “Are classes included with the platinum membership?”

“Yeah, unlimited classes are included with the platinum membership. Were you thinking of taking something?” *Well, color me intrigued.* I couldn’t imagine him taking a spin class. Maybe he was asking about BJJ or tae kwon do.

He grunted as he set up his bar. “I was considering it.” He stepped closer to me and lowered his voice an octave. “Do you know which class that cute pixie teaches?”

And there it was.

The cute pixie, Ellie, taught the gym’s Jazzercise class. Her sprite-like body dressed in tight, bright spandex bounced around the stage as she motivated a class full of mostly older women.

I laughed under my breath at the thought of Kael taking a Jazzercise class. The guy didn’t exactly exude grace. “That’s Ellie. She teaches the Jazzercise class.”

Kael’s mouth curved into a smirk, his shiny white tusks digging into his thin upper lip. “Hmm. Well, it looks like I’ll be signing up for Jazzercise, then.”

“That bad, huh? Well, I’ll make sure I’m here that day. It’ll be entertaining,” I said with a smile.

“Hey, man, I have some moves,” he said with a straight face. It sent us both into a fit of laughter.

I checked my watch and hopped off the weight bench. “Shit, I gotta get ready to work the desk. Have a great workout, Kael.”

He popped his earbuds into his tiny green ears and waved me off.

In the locker room, I lifted my arms and took a whiff of my armpits.

Shower it is.

I stepped into one of the private stalls, the tile floor clicking beneath my clawed feet. I put my hat in my bag, pulled my sweat-dampened tank top over my head, and slipped my shorts and underwear off my waist. Adjusting the tap, I started the water and stepped under the spray once it was warm.

I let out a groan, rolling my neck. The hot water felt amazing on my sore muscles. I had some serious delayed-onset muscle soreness going on

because I'd been pushing myself so hard in the gym, but this was all I had right now.

I placed my palms on the cool tiled wall, letting the water cascade over my head and down the wide expanse of my back.

I was deep in thought when my stomach growled loudly, the sound bouncing off the walls around me.

Fuck, I was hungry.

I wished I had more of Tegan's cupcakes.

The night of the wedding, I went home and thought about her while I jerked off. Thought about how gorgeous she looked in that dress, and how gorgeous she'd look with it off.

My cock stirred at the image of her naked body tangled in my sheets, her cheeks flushed pink from a nice thorough fuck.

I grabbed my cock, giving it a few rough pumps, lightly thrusting my hips.

I wondered if she could take all of me. Wolven males were different from human men. Bigger. Thicker. Primal. Feral.

Would she be able to keep up?

I wanted to find out.

Faster and faster, I fucked my fist, thinking about her tight cunt clenching my cock.

My knot started to swell.

Fuck.

She wouldn't be able to take it. Not right away at least. Even if she couldn't, I'd still fill her up and take her again and again.

Give her my cum until my balls were drained and my body was spent. Make her beg for it.

Breed her, even.

Not right away, but maybe someday if she wanted it. The idea of her carrying my babies made my spine tingle.

"Shit. Shit," I groaned as thick ropes of cum shot out of my cock, coating my fists and the shower wall in front of me.

When I finally came down from my orgasm, I realized just how out of left field the thought that sent me over the edge was.

Where the fuck did that come from?

I didn't really have a breeding kink, and that was an insane thought to have about a woman I hadn't even kissed yet.

The spray of the shower sent my cum down the drain and I splashed a few handfuls on the wall to take care of the mess I'd made.

I know, I know.

Jerking off in the shower of the gym I owned was pretty fucking gross, but I knew for a fact that I wasn't the only one to do it.

Things went on here. I wasn't blind to them. I could smell the bodily fluids and pheromones that covered this place like a thick fog. At least I employed a good cleaning staff.

After soaping up my body, I rinsed and toweled off before getting dressed for the day. I wore my standard "uniform": a Leviathan Fitness tank top and pair of mid-thigh athletic shorts that showed off my quads.

I tried to tame my fur in the mirror, but it was no use. The thick whorls of gray and black hair were determined to stick up in every direction. Sighing, I slipped my hat back on and headed down to the main floor.

—

THE AFTERNOON STRETCHED ON IN what felt like an endless stream of phone calls and greeting clients. I was starting to get hungry again. Being a weightlifting wolverine was similar to being a bottomless pit.

I took my shaker bottle out of my bag and fished around in the mini fridge I kept behind the desk for my oat milk. After splashing in a generous amount, I dumped in my protein powder and gave it a vigorous shake.

The stuff tasted like a mixture of chalk and Froot Loops, but if I wanted to maintain my physique, I had to ingest a crazy amount of protein.

I just about spit out my shake when I saw a messy bun of strawberry blonde hair bobbing through the doorway, heading right up to me at the front desk.

Shit.

It was her.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

My fucking tail just kept thwapping against everything. It couldn't seem to control itself when she was around.

Holy fuck, was she cute. Today she was dressed in tight black high-waisted leggings and a crop top that said "3rd Annual Briar Glenn Bake-Off." A band of soft skin peeked out from beneath the hem of her shirt. I wanted to lick it. Worship every inch of her body with my tongue until she couldn't take any more.

She was close, and her expression brightened when she saw me.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

My body swayed from the force of my tail.

Get it together, Atlas.

She's going to think you're a total creep.

When she got to the front desk, she looked up at me through her lashes, flashing me a smile that made my heart race.

"Hi, Atlas."

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Ten



TEGAN

“UH, HI,” ATLAS SAID IN that low, growly voice, his body swaying slightly with each wag of his tail. “I never got a chance to thank you for hanging out with me at the wedding the other day.”

I launched right into the apology I’d rehearsed in preparation for this moment. “Look, about that. I’m sorry my—”

He held his hands up, stopping me mid-apology. “It’s totally fine. If I had a sister, I’d be protective over her, too. I get it.”

“Yeah, but that’s no excuse.”

“It’s fine.” The soothing way he said it conveyed that it was, in fact, fine. It made me feel a little silly for dwelling on it so much. “I had a great time,” he added.

“I did, too.”

A beat of silence echoed between us, like we weren’t sure where to go from here.

“Is there something I can do for you today?” Atlas finally asked. “Did you need help with a cake?”

I snorted a laugh and placed my hands on the desk, leaning closer to him. “Actually, I wanted to sign up for a membership. After what happened with the cake the other day, I figured I should probably try to build some muscle.”

His eyes widened and he stood straight up, still as a statue, before speaking. “Oh, uh, sure. Yeah, I can definitely help you with that.” He crouched down behind the desk before passing two sheets of paper and a pen across the counter.

He leaned closer to me and pointed at the paperwork. “This one is the liability waiver. It basically states that if you’re injured at the gym using the weights, equipment, or facilities, we aren’t liable.”

A tantalizing aroma distracted me.

It was Atlas.

He smelled exactly like he did at the wedding—like smoked patchouli and sandalwood. He was musky and masculine in the most delicious way. In a way that made me want to rub my face all over him and purr like a contented kitten.

That, or climb him like a tree; I couldn’t be too sure.

I scribbled my signature and the date onto the paper and turned my attention to the next sheet.

“And these are the packages we offer,” he said, pointing to a table with prices and amenities. “You get a two-week free trial, then your card will be charged monthly depending on what package you pick.”

I scanned the list of options. I didn’t want to seem cheap, but who knew if this whole gym thing would even stick?

It was a well-known fact that when it came to working out, I was a quitter. Physical fitness just wasn’t my jam.

It’s who I was.

And wasn’t this really just a way for me to get closer to Atlas?

“I think I’ll start with the silver package,” I said, signing my initials. It was the second-cheapest option, and honestly, it seemed like a good deal for twenty bucks a month. “I’d like to try some classes, but I need to be sure I can make this a habit.”

His thick tail started to wag again. “Well, you know. I’m here every day. I can help keep you accountable.”

“Oh yeah? You’d do that for me?” I laughed and batted my eyelashes.

He had a team of personal trainers who worked for him. There was no way he offered this to everyone who signed up.

He confirmed it for me when he said, “For you, yes. If you have goals, I’ll help you get there.”

What if my goal was to have him on top of me? *Could we get there, Atlas?*

“I’ll keep that in mind,” I said with a smirk.

After some struggling, I pulled my bank card out of the pocket of my leggings and passed it across the counter to him.

He ran my card through the machine, passing it back to me with a copy of the agreement and my receipt. “Welcome to Leviathan Fitness, Tegan.” The sultry smile he gave me made me feel like I was going to spontaneously combust. “What size tank top do you wear? I have a few different colors. I really like the white with the neon logo. It has a real ’80s vibe.”

“Oh, I love neon. I’ll take a large.”

“Neon it is.” He smiled at me again before turning to rummage through a box of tank tops. When he did, his tail started wagging, knocking over his shaker bottle and spilling his protein shake all over the counter.

“Shit. Stupid tail,” he huffed while reaching for a roll of paper towels to clean up the mess. Even when he was irritated, he was still so cute.

“Let me help. It’s the least I can do after the whole wedding-cake debacle.” I held out my hands and motioned for him to give me a few paper towels.

“Thank you,” he said as he bent over the counter.

I leaned in to help him. As I wiped up the protein shake, my hand brushed against his.

Slowly, we looked up at each other, our gazes connecting. I could see my freckles and messy bun reflected back at me in his full-moon eyes. Our faces were so close that I could feel his warm breath against my face and I desperately wanted him to close the distance between us. Kissing him with that long muzzle of his would be interesting, but I’m sure we could make it work. There were other things we could do with our mouths.

But just like at the wedding, it was over just as quick as it began.

Atlas stood up and looked away, running his hand over his ear and along the back of his head as he puffed out a breath.

Did he feel this, too?

He shook his head, like he was shaking off what just happened.

Yeah, he felt it, too.

He cleared his throat. “Did you, uh, want a tour?”

“I’d love that. I’m really curious to see what you did with the place.” That, and I wasn’t in any particular rush to get away from him, and in even less of a rush to start my workout.

“Cool.” He set a BACK IN FIFTEEN sign on the counter and made his way around the desk.

Standing next to him made me feel butterflies all over again. I would really have to focus if I wanted to retain any of the information he was going to tell me.

“Obviously, this is the main floor,” he said, strolling out into the middle of the gym.

Instead of a traditional gym, Leviathan Fitness had more of a modern-athletic-club feel. Yes, there were rubber floors made for dropping weights, mirrors lining the walls to check your form, weightlifting benches, machines, and free weights—but it was also bright and open. A far cry from the rec center of my childhood.

“I think this used to be a basketball court?” I said, noticing the exposed-brick wall that ran along the side of the building.

“Yep. The ceilings in the old building were really high, so we added a second story for more space,” he said proudly. “Did you come here often as a kid?”

I nodded. “Summer camp. Birthday parties. It was the cheapest way to entertain kids in a small town.”

“Why do I feel like we had the same childhood? I spent a ton of time doing rec activities when I was a kid.”

The difference was that he actually stuck with the sports he tried. My parents never made me stick with anything.

“Speaking of swimming,” he said, leading me through a doorway in the back of the room. It led to a corridor with a few doors on each side. “These are the offices and locker rooms. And this,” he said, pushing open another door, “is the pool.”

It was huge. Much bigger than I remembered. The most surprising part was that it didn’t have that public-pool smell—no overwhelming sting of chlorine lingering in the air.

“It’s saltwater,” he said, like some kind of mind reader. “I can’t stand the smell of chlorine, and I have a kraken friend who needs to soak in saltwater regularly, so it seemed like the right move.”

“You have a kraken friend?” I asked in awe.

They were one of the rarest monster species, and I’d never had the opportunity to meet one before.

Atlas nodded. “He’s one of my best friends. You might see him here every once in a while.”

I stared at the shining water, imagining a kraken swimming beneath the surface. “I hope so.”

“This way,” he said, motioning for me to follow him through yet another door.

This one led to an open staircase, giving us a view of the gym floor as we climbed up to the second story.

“And up here we have the cardio machines, a few studios for classes, and another set of locker rooms.” He leaned against the railing, glancing down at the gym below.

“This place is so nice,” I said, leaning next to him so close that our arms were touching.

“Thank you. It took a lot of work but I’m happy with how things turned out.” The way he smiled when he talked about the gym told me as much.

“I hope this doesn’t come off as rude, but where did you get the money to do all this? Do you have investors or...?”

He laughed. “When I was still in college, my grandmother passed away and left me a good amount of money. My older brothers are financial advisers, and they convinced me to invest it. At the time, I didn’t think I

was making the right choice, but it paid off in the long run. Thanks to the mayor's grant program, I got the building for pretty cheap, and I used the gains I got from investing to remodel and buy all the equipment."

"Wow. That's wild." Meanwhile, I was scraping by in the hopes I could buy an industrial deep fryer to increase Selene's donut production. "Are your brothers taking on new clients?"

He chuckled, shaking his head. "I'd be afraid to introduce you to them." His body stiffened, like he couldn't believe he'd just said that. "Anyway, I should probably get back to the front desk. New clients aren't going to be able to sign up themselves."

"Okay," I said quietly.

I followed him down a different staircase, one that led right back to the entrance of the gym.

"Do you need me to show you how any of the equipment works or anything?" he asked while avoiding eye contact and focusing his golden eyes on something on the other side of the gym.

My cheeks reddened and I shook my head, refusing maybe just a little too vigorously. "Nope. I am good. I totally know what I'm doing."

"Well, uh, okay, then." He nodded his head and rubbed the back of his neck as he stretched, his tank top riding up just enough to show off his fur-covered Adonis belt.

He looked so fucking good.

And I was staring.

I had to get out of there.

"I'll see ya," I said as I quickly glanced away and hefted my gym bag onto my shoulder.

"See ya." He wiggled his claws at me as I turned on my heel and headed toward the locker room.

Why was walking away from him so hard?

Eleven



ATLAS

THANK GODS I WAS BEHIND the desk because as I watched Tegan struggle with the Smith machine from across the gym, my dick swelled in my shorts.

There was something about the little grunts she made and the way her muscles strained and quivered that did it for me. I wondered if I could wring those same noises from her body, to make her quake with pleasure.

I had to stop.

This was so unprofessional. So fucked up.

I watched as she set up the Smith machine with a weight that was way too heavy for someone just starting out. As she went to position herself with the bar resting on her back, I decided it was best for her safety to intervene.

She smiled when she saw me approach, those glittering green eyes happy to see me. “What’s up?” she asked as she pulled her earbud from her ear.

“Look, um—I don’t want to come off as a total asshole but you have quite a bit of weight on that bar for a beginner. You should be focused on form and not lifting heavy just yet. Second, a front squat is much safer on your back when using the Smith machine. I can show you—if you’d like, that is.” Gods, I sounded like a know-it-all meathead. I mean, I was a know-it-all meathead, but still. I wanted her to be safe and develop good habits.

She thought for a moment, and then her smile widened, a lighthearted laugh slipping out from between her lips. “Oh, thank goodness. Honestly, I

have no idea what I'm doing. I found some stuff on Pinterest, but I'm struggling here."

"Pinterest?" I said, shaking my head. "Let me help you, then." I took some weight off the bar and raised it up, positioning myself underneath it. "So you want your feet about shoulder width apart and you're going to rest the bar here on your chest and biceps." I pushed out my chest and flexed my biceps, noticing the way her pupils widened at the sight of my muscles.

She stepped closer to me and, like a model student, analyzed the way I held the bar.

"Next, we're going to squat down, keeping our back as straight as possible. When you do a regular weighted squat with the Smith machine, you don't have any flexibility with your spine. Lower yourself slowly, making sure your knees don't go out over your feet. You wanna get your butt as close to the floor as possible, but for someone like me with long femurs, we won't be able to get as deep. The saying is 'ass to grass,' but just do your best. Take it nice and slow. Inhale on your way down, exhale on your way up." I did a few quick squats because, let's be real, that weight was nothing for me. "Got it?" I asked.

"I think so!" She sounded more confident after my demonstration, so I lowered the bar for her to get into position.

Well, for her to *try* to get into position. She couldn't seem to get the bar exactly where it needed to be.

I chuckled. "Can I help you?"

She blushed. "Please do. I swear I'm trying."

I came up behind her and helped to move her arms into position and used my feet to push hers apart. Her ass brushed against the front of my body and I sucked in a breath at the contact. It wasn't anything different from how we'd danced at the wedding, but the tension between us had grown since then, making everything more intense.

Fuck.

This was a bad idea. A very bad idea. I mean, maybe I should pair her with someone else? I had plenty of other trainers to go around.

But the possessive part of me didn't want that.

The thought of someone else's hands all over her, then hearing her little grunts and coaching her on made anger simmer up inside of me and a growl threatened to creep out of my throat.

I was doing this.

No one else would be getting close to Tegan.

"Like this, Atlas?" Her soft, sweet voice pulled me out of my thoughts, the sound causing my tail to sway behind me.

I walked around the Smith machine and checked her form one last time. "Yep, looks great to me—" I had to cut myself off to keep from calling her *baby*.

What the fuck was wrong with me?

We weren't in a relationship, and even if we were, I didn't do pet names.

But there was something about Tegan that called to that loving, affectionate part of me. I mean, my tail lost its shit anytime she was around. She was soft and sweet. *Baby* was just so fitting.

I tried to make a quick recovery, rushing out, "Let's try it with the movement. Nice and slow. Take a deep breath in as you lower yourself to the ground, ass to grass, keep those knees from going out past your toes, exhale on your way up. Got it?"

She nodded, her bun flopping back and forth on top of her head. "Got it. I can do this."

I was throwing a lot at her at once, but her determination was adorable.

"Of course you can," I reassured her. And even if she couldn't get it this time, we would just try again.

Tegan sucked in a breath and lowered her body, naturally falling into perfect form on her first-ever front squat. Her ass was plump and round, and I admired the swell as she got it as close to the ground as she could. When she hoisted her body back up, she exhaled and let out a small groan. It appeared that my little baker was an exemplary student.

I felt like my cock was going to explode right then and there. I hadn't come in my pants since I was a pup, but she was driving me crazy. Once again confirming that this was a bad idea.

“How was that?” she asked. Her freckled cheeks were flushed the prettiest shade of pink.

“You did a great job! You just needed some coaching to feel confident. You’re a natural!” She beamed at my praise, and that got the wheels in my brain turning. “You know, I could train you.”

She rested her arms over the bar and smiled at me. “You’d do that? Don’t you have administrative stuff to do?”

I mean, I did. She was a small-business owner, too, so she knew how time-consuming running your own business could be. But for her? I’d make time.

“Well, I’m filling in for one of my trainers currently. She’s out on sick leave.” It was a half-truth.

“But what about payment? I can’t let you do this for free.” Her voice was stern. She had pride. I liked it.

“What about baked goods in exchange for training? We can meet here early in the morning when I normally work out and train together.” The last thing I needed were more sweets sitting around, but if it kept her coming back, I’d gladly take them.

She slowly nodded her head and bit her lower lip. “I could probably swing baked goods in exchange for training. How early are we talking, though?”

“Four a.m.” I raised my furry eyebrows at her.

“Ugh. You’re killing me, Atlas! That’s so early,” she groaned, and hid her face.

“What? Don’t bakers wake up early?” I gave her my best wolverine-next-door grin.

“I’m not that kind of baker!” *The cute kind was what she was.*

“Come on. It’ll be fun. Don’t you want to avoid future wedding-cake mishaps?” I cocked my head in question and stared down my muzzle at her.

“Of course I do.”

“What better way to do that than train with a five-time physique gold medalist?” It was rare that I talked about myself that way, but I *really* wanted her to agree to this.

She rolled her eyes at me, then smiled. “Well, when you put it that way, I can’t really pass up free lessons, can I? What day are we starting?”

“Tomorrow.” I pointed at her, cocking my head. “Four a.m., Tegan.”

“All right, all right. I got that part the first time you said it!” She giggled and scrunched up her little button nose in distaste.

Cute.

“We should probably exchange phone numbers. You know, so I can harass you if you don’t show up.” My muzzle curled up in a smirk.

Good thinking, Atlas. Getting to spend time with her *and* finally getting her number. I was a fucking legend. Killing this flirting shit.

She placed one hand on her wide hips and held out the other for my phone. “I promise I’ll be here,” she said as she saved her contact info. “Make sure you text me so I have your number.”

Oh yeah. *She wants it.*

I typed out a quick text.

Hi Tegan. It’s Atlas 🌐 from Leviathan Fitness 🕷️
🏋️ Be ready to hit it hard tomorrow.

Her phone vibrated and she snorted when she read my text. “You really like emojis, don’t you?”

I smiled and shrugged. “What, they’re cute. You know us muscle heads aren’t very articulate.”

She laughed again. I didn’t think I’d ever get tired of hearing that sound or seeing her smile.

“I better get back to the desk. Make sure you take it easy the rest of the evening. I don’t want you to be sore tomorrow.”

“Yes, sir!” she said, and fake-saluted me.

Sir.

My cock stirred in my pants.

This was a bad idea. Such a bad idea.

Twelve



TEGAN

I COULDN'T BELIEVE HOW EASILY things had fallen into place. I should have just put on my big-girl pants and strolled into the gym right after the wedding. It would have saved me from a lot of sulking.

I was looking forward to spending more time with Atlas, but freaking four a.m.?

I was thinking with my lady bits and not with my actual brain.

I pulled off my leggings and crop top before struggling to free my tits from the constraints of my sports bra. These things were a form of torture, but without it I'd probably give myself a black eye.

I stepped under the shower spray and lathered my body with my bath pouf, washing away the sweat from my workout.

Atlas smelled so good today. When he came up behind me to help with my form, I got another strong whiff of him. I wanted him to rub that furry face of his between my thighs, coating me with his scent as he ate my pussy.

My soapy fingers teased the pert tips of my nipples. I moaned as I wondered what it would feel like if Atlas dragged the pointed tips of his teeth along them, giving them a sharp tug.

It would hurt so good.

My hands slid lower, over my belly and down between my legs, the tips of my fingers going straight for my clit. I swirled them over the sensitive

bud, varying the pressure with each tiny circle.

“Fuck,” I groaned, the sound echoing off the tile walls.

I dipped one finger inside of me and then another, curling them in a come-hither motion against my G-spot while my thumb teased my clit.

Atlas has claws.

I wondered if he could retract them and fuck me with those long, thick fingers. Maybe if I was a good girl, he’d shove them in my mouth after the fact and force me to lick them clean.

Yeah, he would.

And I’d love every second of it.

My hips canted forward in light thrusts, driving my fingers deeper and heightening my pleasure. I could feel my orgasm creeping closer with each glide of my thumb over my clit.

“Yes. Atlas. Please. Give it to me. Please,” I begged as all my fantasies of him played out in my head.

Him pinning me against the wall, impaling me on his cock.

Me riding him while he lifted my hips with ease.

Him fucking my mouth with harsh thrusts and a clawed fist tangled in my hair.

“Gods, Atlas. Yes. Give me your cum. Give me your cum.” I wanted to taste it. Wanted him to fill my pussy with it.

That did it.

I leaned against the shower wall, moaning and riding out my orgasm as my thighs shook.

Damn. *Another one.*

Was I really this crazed over a wolven I’d literally just met?

The answer was a hard yes.

I finished my shower and toweled off, grabbing my phone from where it sat on the bathroom vanity to check for any messages.

I had a text.

From Atlas.

He was texting me now?

My hands shook as I unlocked my phone.

Atlas: Hey! Great job today. I'm so proud of your dedication to getting stronger. Glad the idea of a 4 AM workout didn't put you off 😊

I snorted and held my phone up to my chest like a giggly schoolgirl.

A wink.

HE WINKED AT ME VIA TEXT.

I stared at my phone for a few moments, my fingers lingering over the keyboard, pondering my response.

Tegan: Hey! Thank you! I had a really great teacher 😊

Shit. Was that too much?!

Flirting was hard. Just be yourself, Teg.

Oh hey, Atlas. Thanks for rubbing your wolfman dick against my ass today. I definitely don't have ulterior motives for hauling my ass out of bed at four a.m. to throw around weights.

No, no. Don't say that.

Atlas: Nah, you're a natural. Remember, four AM tomorrow. 😊

He finished that one with a really cute blushing smiley face.

It was the same face I'd seen him make at me before but, ya know, the wolf version.

Tegan: 😊 I didn't forget. Setting my alarm right now.

I hit send and waited.

Atlas: Good. See you in the morning 🧡 🚗

Holy shit.

I stared at the heart emoji for a beat.

Did he mean hearts for me? Or did he mean hearts for the gym?

I needed an outside opinion.

I scrolled through my contacts and dialed Declan's number. Luckily, he answered on the second ring.

"Dude, we have a serious emergency," I said through the line.

"Oh my gods. Has there been a development?" Dec screeched. "I'm all ears, baby. Spill that tea." He was always down for drama and gossip. I couldn't ask for a better life coach or friend.

"He texted me, Dec," I said, pacing back and forth from the bathroom to my bedroom. "I'm freaking out."

"Wait, when did he get your number? What happened at the gym?"

"Shit, okay. Yeah, I should probably start from the beginning. So I showed up at the gym and he was there working the front desk and we were being all flirty while I signed up for a membership. And then when I was doing a workout I found on Pinterest, he came up to help me because apparently I was doing my squats all wrong." I paused to catch my breath. "And then he offered to train me and he got my number because I have to meet him at freaking four a.m. to work out."

"Are you serious?" he squealed.

"Yes, I'm serious!"

"So you're meeting him at four a.m. tomorrow?"

"Yes! But he texted me tonight out of nowhere."

"So what did he say in his text?" Dec asked.

"I don't know, a bunch of things. He sent me a heart emoji, Dec. Hold on. I'm going to send you a screenshot." I took a screenshot and sent it to him.

"Tegan. Babe. He is totally flirting!" There was no mistaking the excitement in his voice. This confirmed it. This was really happening.

“I don’t know what to do!” I groaned as I threw myself down on my bed.

“What do you mean, you don’t know what to do? He almost kissed you the other day. Just work out and flirt with him, Teg. Push those titties out, sway those hips when you walk. We both know your ass looks amazing in leggings.” Dec was my forever hype man, and I loved him for it.

And my ass really did look amazing in leggings. I thought about it for a second and I could hear Declan breathing on the other end of the phone.

“Well?” he said expectantly.

This was what I wanted, what I swore I was going to make time for, and it had just fallen in my lap—or shown up on the sidewalk after a cake fell out of my arms, rather. This was my chance.

“I’m gonna go for it. He’s interested and I’m obviously interested, so I’m gonna go for it.”

Declan screamed so loud, I had to pull the phone away from my ear. “Yes, girl! I’m proud of you for taking the initiative. Text me tomorrow and let me know how it goes!”

“I will! I should probably get to bed anyway.” I looked at the time and calculated how many hours of sleep I’d be able to squeeze in before I started cursing Atlas’s name.

“Oh, and Teg, snap me a pic of his ass if you can. The website photos are great and all, but I want to check him out from the other side.”

“No way.” I laughed. I really regretted sending him the link to the gym’s website.

“Come on, Tegs—” he started.

“Good night,” I said sweetly before hanging up the phone.

I might just have to do that. My spank bank could use something other than website photos.

Thirteen



ATLAS

BEEP.

BEEP.

BEEP.

My eyes fluttered open and a smile spread across my muzzle. Four a.m. really wasn't that bad when I knew a strawberry blonde beauty would be waiting for me. Well, hopefully. She didn't seem too thrilled about the prospect of an early-morning workout, but I was thrilled at the thought of having her and the gym all to myself.

I threw off my comforter and stretched before raking my claws along my bare thighs.

Yeah, I slept in the nude. Fur was hot.

My claws tapped against the hardwood as I made my way over to my walk-in closet. Carpet was a no-go when you had claws. Too many snags.

I really didn't understand why Jade insisted I *had* to have such a large closet.

Everything I owned was essentially athletic clothing. Tank tops, compression shorts, basketball shorts, hoodies, gray sweatpants.

The necessities.

In fact, my house was pretty excessive in general. I would have been content with a smaller place, but a certain someone pressured me into this ostentatious monstrosity. She had to have the best of everything. New

countertops. A fancy walk-in shower. An outdoor kitchen. I was renovating the gym and renovating the house, feeling totally overwhelmed and displaced, and she just kept pushing me. Asking for more and more, taking everything I had to give without offering anything in return.

And now that things were over between us, I was stuck with this giant empty house that I despised because it served as a reminder of her and the person she wanted me to be.

But that was in the past. I had something new to look forward to in the form of a curvaceous baker who seemed to like me exactly how I was.

I pulled on a pair of briefs, then basketball shorts that hit right above my knees, checking to see what it looked like with my cock tucked into the waistband like I did the other day when Tegan made me pop a boner. I was pretty certain that more of the same would be happening during our training sessions together. Maybe I could wear a cup? There were some bodybuilders who put a piece of bread in their underwear to hide the outline of their cock during competitions—maybe I could do that. I'd probably need two slices, or maybe even a burrito-size tortilla.

I snorted and shook my head. Gods, what the fuck was I doing? Per usual, I put on a Leviathan Fitness tank and topped things off with a neon-green Leviathan Fitness hoodie. The morning walk to the gym was chilly and I didn't like people looking at my nipples. Ironic for someone who used to pose practically naked on a stage.

After getting dressed, I walked down to the kitchen and mixed my preworkout shake, checking my reflection in the microwave. My fur was an absolute mess but it was nothing a hat couldn't fix.

The current preworkout in my rotation tasted like those supersweet fish candies and made my skin feel like it was covered in spiders. Really got my blood flowing, but in a good way. But maybe not when I'd be around Tegan?

Speaking of Tegan. I pulled my phone out of my pocket and checked my messages. We were definitely flirting yesterday. I was glad we could pick up where we left off at the wedding. There was definitely something there between us and it made me excited.

I typed out a message to Tegan.

Atlas: Just making sure you're awake!

I took a few swigs of my preworkout and gazed down at my phone expectedly. The moment it vibrated, a wide smile turned up the corners of my muzzle.

Tegan.

Tegan: I'm awake. Barely.

A photo popped up on the screen next.

It was a picture of her dressed in black leggings with her new Leviathan Fitness tank top knotted into a crop top. The material stretched tight across her breasts and that same delicious band of skin showed above the waistband of her leggings. The strands of her strawberry blonde hair were tossed into another messy bun, her tiny pink tongue stuck out of her mouth, and with her free hand she was flipping the camera off—flipping me off!

She was so adorable. And she was flirting with me.

Shit.

Was I supposed to send her a picture back? I looked like hot garbage.

I hauled ass upstairs to my bathroom, the only room in my house with a full-length mirror long enough to capture my entire six-foot-seven frame.

Oh shit, a hat.

I ran to my bedroom and scanned my shelves for something that went with neon green. Purple would work.

I flipped the snapback on and carefully worked my ears through the holes before stroking my claws through the hair of my face and muzzle, doing whatever I could to make it look like I didn't just roll out of bed. At this rate, I'd have to jog to the gym or I'd be late, but I wanted to show off a little bit. She brought out the confident side of me, one I'd thought I'd never find again.

Standing in front of my mirror, I puffed out my chest and flexed my quads, the lines of my muscles showing through my fur. I cocked my head to the side and smirked before snapping the pic.

Perfect.

My finger hovered over the send button.

What if she thought I was being douche-y or showing off? I didn't want her to feel uncomfortable during our session together.

But she had obviously initiated this by sending me a picture of herself.

I was so out of practice with this shit, but I decided to say fuck it and hit send.

It felt like I waited forever for her to respond when in reality it was probably pretty instantaneous.

Tegan: Holy moon goddess, Atlas. 🤩

Thank gods I lived alone because I howled like a teenage wolverine.

Tegan had sent me a heart eyes emoji.

There was sexual tension between us and I was about to spend the next two hours pretty much alone with her, my body against hers while I helped her train.

I groaned and adjusted my cock from where it was already starting to swell in my shorts.

A run was desperately needed. Maybe if I expended some energy, I'd be able to keep my cool around her.

I sent her a quick text, just to let her know I was on my way, throwing my stuff in my gym bag and slinging it over my shoulder before heading out the door.

Usually I ran to music, but this morning I wanted to be alone with my thoughts. I focused on my breathing as the rough pads of my feet pounded on the pavement. The city was quiet and dark. As an apex predator, I felt at home and in my element. My nose stung from the cold morning air, but it drew my focus away from Tegan, at least temporarily.

I wondered if I'd be able to get her to come for a morning run with me at some point. Seeing those full tits bob up and down with each of her footfalls. I'd probably end up dragging her off the path and fucking her in the forest. Claiming every inch of her body while leaves and twigs got stuck in her hair and my fur. Covering her with my scent. Oh, I'd get her to come on a run, all right.

I laughed at my joke and picked up the pace, my stride turning into a full-on sprint as the gym appeared in the distance. I was so excited to get there. I needed to see her.

Even though my pace would have been excruciating for a human, it took me only a moment to catch my breath before opening the doors to the gym. I'd barely broken a sweat.

I glanced over at the front counter and that's when I saw her. She was propped over the desk playing on her phone, her plump ass popped out on full display, wiggling back and forth slightly.

I wanted to bite it.

Sitting next to her on the counter was a white box, and I smirked, knowing she'd upheld her end of the bargain.

"You beat me here!" I said a little too loudly, the boom of my voice causing her to jump.

"Shit, Atlas. You scared me!" she said as she turned around to face me.

My heart thumped loudly in my chest at the sight of her, and my annoying tail joined in, wagging back and forth at lightning speed.

"Uh, sorry. I didn't mean to." I rubbed my shoulder awkwardly and bit my lip, my canine digging into my skin.

She grabbed the box of cupcakes and smiled up at me. "It's okay. I'm just not used to someone being so chipper at four a.m., is all." She held the box out toward me. "Your payment, good sir."

So. Fucking. Cute.

She called me *sir* again. Was that a turn-on for me?

Shit.

It was definitely a turn-on.

I reached out and took the box from her, smiling so hard my cheeks hurt. “Thank you. I can’t wait to dig into these later. Lemme just put them in my office and we can get started.”

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Fourteen



TEGAN

SIR. I COULD SEE LUST spark to life in those vivid yellow eyes when I called him that.

What other names would he like?

Maybe *daddy*. I could get down with that. Especially if spanking was involved.

I felt so confident after our photo exchange this morning.

There was just something about Atlas that did it for me. He was so calm and self-assured as he walked me through the different machines and exercises we'd be doing. Part of it was probably because of how long he'd been doing this, but I also got the impression that it was just Atlas's overall demeanor. He was so attentive.

And hot.

"That sound like a plan, Tegan?" Atlas's deep growl of a voice brought me out of my thoughts as he passed me two ten-pound dumbbells.

How was I supposed to focus when his biceps kept flexing like that? For obvious reasons, he'd started my weightlifting program with arms.

"Uh, can you show me one more time?" I asked, letting the weights hang at my sides.

He picked up another dumbbell and repeated the motion. It was such a light weight that he was flying through my motions. I wasn't learning very much, but I really enjoyed watching him.

“Maybe one more time?” I teased.

He laughed, humoring me and doing it one more time. “You’re enjoying this, aren’t you?”

I almost pinched my thumb and pointer finger together. “Just a little bit.”

He set down the dumbbell and shook his head. “You’re too much. Now, go on and give it a try.”

I kept my elbows close to my body, slowly curling my arms upward. I made sure I took my time, feeling my muscles engage instead of just speeding through the movement.

“Am I doing this right?” I asked, doing another rep. I could already feel the strain on my muscles.

“You’re doing great,” he said, “but remember to breathe.”

“It’s hard.” It came out whinier than I meant it to, but I was struggling.

Atlas laughed. “It is hard, but think about how good you’re going to feel when you can lift something you couldn’t before. Or when you flex your arm and see some definition.”

“I want to be able to lift heavy things.”

“And I’m gonna make sure you get to that point. *Safely*. The key to that is having good form.”

I did another rep, remembering to exhale as I brought the weights up to my shoulders.

“That’s it. Great job,” he praised.

His enthusiasm and positivity were contagious. It made me want to try my hardest, to give this my all. He made me feel like I could. I bet people loved working with him as their trainer.

“So”—I sucked in a breath, curled my arms, and slowly exhaled while lowering the weights—“how long have you worked as a personal trainer?”

His eyes traveled up from my arms to my face, so he could look at me while we talked. “Since I was in college. I worked in a gym part-time while I was finishing my kinesiology degree. I had a scholarship but I needed some spending money. How many was that?”

For a second I was tempted to lie and say I'd done four—but what if this was some sort of test? “Three.”

“Good girl. Give me three more.”

My brain short-circuited. He couldn't just hit me with a *good girl* like that.

I was supposed to be focusing.

I took a deep breath to regain my focus and did another curl, really feeling the burn in my biceps this time. “And what made you decide to open a gym?”

He was quiet for a second, like he was thinking about how to answer this without giving too much away. “It seemed like the next rational step.”

“And you thought Briar Glenn was the perfect place.”

“Not at first, actually. I, uh, I was heading to Rock Harbor to check out a property and took the exit for Briar Glenn on a whim. Came into town, loved it, and when I found out about the revitalization grants, it seemed like the perfect place to open a gym. I even managed to talk some of my friends into moving here, too.”

I did another rep. “You convinced your friends to move here?”

“I did.”

That was some dedication. They must be close.

“What are they like?” I asked, trying to get as much information out of this training session as I could.

“Well, there's Fallon. He's this annoying ladies' man griffin. We've been friends since we were kids, and no matter how hard I try, I can't seem to get rid of him. And I already told you about Cyrus.”

“Is he the kraken?” I asked, remembering what he'd told me about the saltwater pool.

Atlas nodded. “Yep. That's him. We met in college. He shared a campus apartment with Fallon and me. At first he hated us, but eventually we won him over. Cyrus is also the reason the gym logo has a tentacle on it.”

That was supersweet. It seemed like Atlas was the type to go above and beyond for the people he cared about. I wondered if that included training me.

“It sounds like you guys are really close.”

“We are. I’m lucky to have them,” he said. “Especially since—”

I did one last rep and let my arms fall to my sides. “Since?”

“Just—since I would have been alone here.” The way he hesitated made me think there was more to the story than that. I wasn’t going to press him, but hopefully he’d tell me in time.

“And what about you, Miss Baker?” he asked.

“Well, my story isn’t nearly as interesting. My grandma owned the bakery, then my mom, and when she retired, I took over.”

“Did you go to a special pastry school or did you learn on the job?”

“I learned a lot on the job, but I completed a pastry chef program at the community college in Rock Harbor. All of those years working for my mom definitely gave me an advantage, though.”

“I worked at my family business, too. My parents own a hardware store.”

“So I take it you’re good at fixing things?” I asked. Hardware store employee to gym owner was a pretty interesting pipeline.

“I know a thing or two,” he said nonchalantly.

“Cake transporter, personal trainer, business owner, *and* handyman. That’s quite the résumé.”

He shrugged his broad shoulders. “What can I say? I’m a wolverine of many talents.”

“You know—there was something I wanted to ask you about.”

“Ask away. I’m an open book.”

“If I remember correctly, your website said you were also a bodybuilder.”

“Okay, stalker.” He laughed. “Did you dig up my social security number, too?”

“Shut up!” I giggled. “I was curious! I couldn’t help myself.”

“Yes,” he sighed. “I was a competitive bodybuilder.”

“And what was that like?” I asked.

He put his hands on his hips, shaking his head. “You know, you should be doing your next set.”

“We can take it slow,” I suggested. “I don’t want to be too sore.”

“Fine,” he relented. “Let’s take a water break and I’ll tell you about it.”

We set the weights back on the rack and headed over to where we’d set our towels and water bottles. I wiped the sweat off my forehead and took a long drink while Atlas did the same. Well, sort of the same thing. He hadn’t worked up a sweat.

“Okay, spill,” I said.

“When I was in my twenties, I competed. I was doing two to three competitions a year, and I usually placed pretty well.”

“Five-time physique gold medalist,” I added.

“Yes.” He laughed. “Five-time physique gold medalist. I enjoyed it, but it was a ton of work. Lots of time in the gym, super-strict diet, and when I was cutting for competitions, I was just constantly hungry. Food was all I could think about. Then I’d compete, go back to my normal physique, then repeat the entire process all over again.”

“And you’d do that two to three times a year?”

“Yep.”

Honestly, that sounded like a miserable existence. I was all for people chasing their goals, but there was no way I had something like that in me.

“Do you miss it?” I asked.

“Sometimes. But see”—he leaned in, almost whispering in my ear—“I met this really cute baker, and if I want her to keep hanging out with me, I have to keep eating the cupcakes she brings me.”

My breath caught in my chest. *Cute*. He called me *cute*.

Before I could come up with a response, he sauntered away, smiling at me like he knew exactly what he was doing. “Why don’t we finish with some light cardio?”

Fifteen



ATLAS

WE HAD ALREADY GONE WAY over the one-hour training session I'd planned, but I was in no rush for this to end.

Tegan crossed her arms over her chest, eyeing me warily. "It depends on what your idea of light cardio is..."

"Thirty-minute walk on the treadmill?" I asked.

"Just a walk. No running?"

I laughed. She must really hate cardio. If she was ever going to run under the full moon with me, we were going to have to work on that.

The thought caught me off guard.

Where the fuck did that come from?

"No running," I reassured her.

She let out a slow breath, making a show of checking her watch. "I think I can do thirty minutes."

An extra thirty minutes with her wasn't a lot, but I'd take anything at this point.

Tegan and I made our way back upstairs, and I chose two treadmills that overlooked the gym floor below. I didn't want to watch TV while we walked. I needed her full attention.

I explained the settings and how to adjust the speed, and we started our treadmills. Tegan set hers at a snail's pace—at least for a wolverine—while mine was much faster, more of a light jog than a walk.

“You’re making me feel bad,” she said, glaring at me as my feet pounded against the belt.

“What? I’m just walking.”

“You’re going like”—she waved her hands in the air wildly, and fuck, it was cute when she was flustered—“ten times faster than me.”

“It’s because I have a long stride!” I laughed. “I can’t help it.”

“Yeah. Yeah,” she huffed.

I slowed my treadmill to match her pace, nearly tripping over my feet in the process. Her laughter was worth it, though.

“Better?” I asked.

“Much better.”

Things were going so well between us. But soon our training session would be over. I really wanted to spend more time with her, and if I was reading her right, she wanted that, too.

Fuck.

I had her phone number. I could ask her to hang out. Or—I could ask her out on a date right now. A tight knot of anxiety formed in my stomach. I hadn’t asked someone out in over a decade. How did you even bring that up? And what if she said no?

No. I had to get that thought out of my head. There was no way she was going to say no. I had no idea what we were going to do for our date, but I’d come up with something later. I had to just go for it.

“So—I was wondering—do you have any plans this weekend?” I tried to play it cool but I’m pretty sure my voice wavered, giving away how fucking nervous I felt.

“I’m working at the bakery in the morning, but I’m free later in the afternoon once my assistant comes in.” She shot me a smug smile that made my chest feel tight. She was totally onto me. “Why?”

“If it wasn’t painfully obvious by now, I’m really into you and I was wondering if you’d like to go out on a date with me.”

“Can I tell you something?” she asked.

Not an answer, but sure. I could sweat it out. “Of course.”

“The reason I joined the gym was because I wanted to see you again. I was hoping you’d stop by the bakery, and when you didn’t, I decided to take matters into my own hands.”

She took initiative to make it happen. I loved that.

I laughed. “The reason I offered to train you was because I wanted to spend more time with you, so I guess we’re even, then.”

“After what happened at the wedding, I thought you wouldn’t want to see me again,” she said quietly.

“Why would you think that?” I asked.

“Because of how my brother acted.”

Yeah, that was awkward. But it wasn’t her fault.

“You’re not responsible for his actions,” I said. “He doesn’t have to like me. What matters is if you like me.”

“I do like you.”

Her admission made my tail wag so hard, I thought I was going to take flight. “Then let me take you out on Saturday.”

“Okay.”

“Okay?” I asked, slightly shocked at how easy this was.

She nodded, fighting back a smile. I felt like I was on top of the world.

“Text me your address and I’ll pick you up around three if that works.”

“All right.”

“Why don’t we call it quits for today? I’d hate for your legs to be tired for our date.”

She giggled, her brows drawing back. “Oh yeah?”

“Oh gods.” I ran my hands through my fur. “Sorry—I didn’t mean it like that.” But if I did—what would her response be? I’d fantasized about her so much and I wondered if she’d done the same about me. The way she looked at me made me think she had.

“I’m just teasing you,” she said, slowing the treadmill to a stop. “Thank you for today.”

“You did a great job.”

“It’s because I had a great teacher.”

Tegan hopped off the treadmill and grabbed her bag and water bottle. We walked back to the front desk and she tugged her phone out of the tight pocket of her leggings. A second later my phone chimed in my pocket.

“That’s my address,” she said. “It’s back in the woods, so call me if you have any trouble finding it. The GPS can be kind of spotty.”

“Will do.”

“I’ll see you this weekend.”

“See you then.”

“Bye.” She gave me a coy wave before she turned and walked out the door.

If I wasn’t standing in the middle of the gym—*my gym*—I would have fist-pumped and jumped in the air. It was finally happening. After dancing around Tegan for over a week, we were finally going out on a date.

I headed down the hall to my office, humming to myself. It felt like I was walking on air.

“Shit, dude! Who the fuck was that?” Fallon’s familiar squawk echoed out from my office.

Dammit.

Nosy fucking bird.

“Fallon!” I growled. “What did I tell you about watching the cameras?”

He walked out to greet me, his talons held up in front of his body submissively. “I didn’t mean anything by it! I just saw you working out with a hot girl and got curious, that’s all.”

I closed my eyes and tried to calm myself down.

“Is that the girl from the wedding?” He made the best kissy noises that his beak would allow and batted his beady little bird eyes at me.

I was going to kill him.

Without warning, I pounced and pinned Fallon against the wall, my muzzle just inches away from his face. “That hot girl is Tegan, and if I ever catch you spying on us again, I’ll chop off your wings and throw them in the air fryer for a snack. Got it, you smug fucker?”

He swallowed hard, blinking a few times. “Got it, boss.”

I took a few deep breaths and rubbed my shoulders, forcing myself to relax. I knew Fallon didn't mean anything by it, but spying on your best friend/boss and his lady friend on camera was not cool. Fucking voyeur.

"How long were you watching us?" I asked, even though I wasn't sure I wanted the answer.

"Just the cooldown. I swear on my life, dude." He shrank back from me submissively. I'd never physically fought Fallon—or anyone, for that matter—but I knew I could be intimidating.

My ears tucked back against my head and my tail swayed lightly, my body attempting to apologize for my lack of restraint. "Sorry, man. I just lost my cool for a second."

"It's all good," he said, following me into the office. "Are you training her?"

"Something like that."

"Damn, she has an ass on her." He whistled. "You didn't mention that."

A low growl crept out of my throat, my eyes narrowing.

Fallon broke into a fit of high-pitched laughter. "It's too fucking easy with you. I'm totally kidding. She's cute, though, and it seems like she's into you."

"Thanks," I muttered under my breath.

"So are you, like, dating her?" Fallon asked, cocking his head to the side questioningly.

"I mean, we're going out on a date on Saturday, so I guess?"

It had been so long since I'd last done this that I wasn't sure what the exact terminology was.

"What are you going to do with her?" He picked up the little basketball I kept on my desk, tossing it in the air while we talked.

"I was thinking of heading over to Rock Harbor."

"The cherry blossoms at the waterfront should be in bloom. I saw a bunch of posters advertising it when I was at the club last weekend."

Cherry blossoms.

I could see it now. Tegan walking along the water as the petals swirled around her.

It was the perfect first date.

I couldn't believe Fallon thought of it. Maybe he was more of a romantic and less of a womanizer than he let on.

"That's a great idea. Thanks, Fal."

"Happy to help." He paused for a second, holding the ball in one of his scaly hands. "Hey, do you know if she has any single friends?"

I grinned, showing off the sharp points of my fangs. "There's no way I'd subject one of Tegan's friends to that sort of torture."

He shrugged, throwing me the ball. "Fine. Be that way. But when I make a speech at your wedding, I'll make sure I tell everyone your first date was my idea."

Sixteen



TEGAN

A SILVER TRUCK RUMBLED DOWN the driveway, the tires crunching over the gravel. I'd be lying if I said I wasn't at the window watching—waiting—for Atlas. It felt like it had taken us ages to get to this point, the two of us dancing around each other, drifting close only to pull away again, but not anymore.

Today was our first date, and I was going to make the most of it.

I hoped what I was wearing was okay for whatever it was he had planned. Dressing casually for a date with a hot wolverine proved harder than I expected, but after a frantic FaceTime call with Selene, I'd settled on a tight-fitting pair of jeans, a low-cut bodysuit that accentuated my chest, and a cute pair of flats. I looked and felt good, and I hoped Atlas thought so, too.

The truck pulled to a stop in front of my house, and while I waited for a text message from Atlas telling me he was here or a honk of his horn—Atlas hopped out of his truck.

He was really coming up to my front door to get me.

What a gentleman.

I darted away from the window so fast, I couldn't even get a good look at him.

There was a surprisingly soft knock on the front door. I gave myself a once-over in the hall mirror, making sure my messy bun was the perfectly

curated type of messy.

I opened the door and was greeted by Atlas's smiling face. Dressed in jeans and a short-sleeve button-down, he looked just as handsome as ever.

"Hi," I said, my voice breathy.

"Hey," he replied shyly.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

There was the tail wag, his body swaying slightly from the force of it. I couldn't keep myself from grinning. It was just too damn cute.

"Um, this is for you." I hadn't even noticed the potted plant he was holding. It was a mix of pansies, violets, and violas, nicely arranged in a big pink flowerpot. It was perfect for brightening up my porch for spring.

"It's beautiful." *And so thoughtful.*

"You didn't strike me as a cut-flowers kind of girl."

I nodded. "I'd rather have something that'll last."

"Me, too. Where would you like me to put it?" he asked.

I pointed to the perfect spot. "Right there by the door would be good."

He set the pot on the porch, rotating it until he was happy with how the flowers looked. "This look good?" he asked.

"Perfect. Thank you." I wrapped my arms around him in a hug, pressing my face against his chest, inhaling his scent. He seemed taken aback at first, going rigid before he hugged me back.

"I'm glad you like it," he said, nuzzling my temple. His fur was so soft against my skin, and when he pulled away, I immediately missed the feeling of being in his arms. "You ready to get going?" he asked.

"Mhm." I walked with him over to his truck. "What do you have planned for us today?"

He opened the passenger door, holding his hand out to help me climb into the truck. *So chivalrous.*

He shrugged. "You'll just have to wait and see."

"I like surprises." It was nice to let someone else take the reins, to be a participant rather than the one in charge.

"Good. Because I'm full of them," he said slyly, closing the door before I could say anything else.

It was much easier for Atlas to get in the truck than it was for me. He pretty much stepped inside the thing, slid into the driver's seat, and we were on our merry way. To where, I didn't know, but we were definitely heading out of Briar Glenn's town limits.

"You greeting me at the door with flowers was a nice touch. Potted ones, at that," I said, grinning from ear to ear. Things were already off to a great start.

He took his eyes off the road for a second, looking over to smile at me. "You liked that?"

I nodded. "Very much."

"I'll remember that."

We'd just started dating, but why did things with Atlas feel so comfortable?

Wait.

Were we dating? I mean, we were going out on a date, but did dating imply that we were an item or we were exclusive?

I was getting ahead of myself.

He pulled the truck onto the highway, heading in the direction of Rock Harbor. It was about forty minutes away from Briar Glenn, the closest "big" city, if you could even call it that. With waterfront bars, restaurants, and nightclubs, it was a popular destination for Briar Glenn residents when they wanted a night out.

I wasn't sure how well that translated to an afternoon date, but I knew Atlas had something up his sleeve.

He parked in the parking garage for the Rock Harbor waterfront. I was excited because I hadn't been to the waterfront since college.

Atlas opened my door, holding his hand out again to help me climb out of the truck. I placed my palm in his, using him to steady myself as I climbed down, but even when my feet touched the ground—he was still holding my hand.

Sure, we'd held hands before. At the wedding I'd dragged him all over.

But this was different. Intentional on his part. It made my heart feel like it was going to leap out of my chest.

“This way,” he said, leading me toward the waterfront.

I was expecting the musty smell of the harbor but was met with a light, sweet scent instead. The cherry blossoms lining the promenade were in bloom, their cotton candy petals fluttering in the breeze.

“Wow,” I said in a daze. I knew about the cherry blossoms, most folks who lived in Briar Glenn did, but this was my first time seeing them in full bloom.

“I thought you’d like them.” Atlas stroked the back of my hand. “Wanna walk for a bit?”

“I’d love to.”

We started down the paved path that ran along the waterfront. Because it was a Saturday, there were quite a few people out enjoying the nice weather. Families picnicked beneath the trees and couples like us walked hand in hand along the harbor. The occasional cyclist rolled by, taking care not to ride too close to us or the water. It was a picture-perfect afternoon.

“Being down here—does it make you regret opening a gym in Briar Glenn instead?” I asked.

“Not at all. There’s a lot of beautiful, unexpected things in Briar Glenn. Things I never would have ever found in Rock Harbor,” he said, staring at me.

I looked away, feeling my cheeks heat because I knew *exactly* what he was referring to.

Me.

“Did you come here a lot when you were a kid?” he asked.

“When I was a teenager, I’d beg my mom to drive me to the Rock Harbor Mall on Friday nights. It was the cool thing to do.”

“You didn’t drive?”

“I had my learner’s permit, but I was too afraid to drive on the highway.” One bad merging incident had scared me away from highway driving well into adulthood.

“Okay, that is super cute.”

“No, it’s not! I was so lame!” I laughed.

He shrugged. "I would have thought it was cute. And I would have happily driven you around to wherever you wanted to go."

It was never good to make assumptions, but I was under the impression that we hung out with opposite crowds in high school. Given what his About Me section on the gym website said, Atlas was definitely a jock in high school.

"What were you like in high school?" I asked, wanting to hear it straight from the wolverine's mouth.

His furry brows drew back. "What do you think I was like?"

"I don't like making assumptions about people," I said, playfully shrugging my shoulders.

"I'm sure it's no surprise that I was a total jock. It's the reason I started driving, actually. So my parents didn't have to pick me up from practice. What about you? What were you like?"

"An emo kid."

"No. Way." The way he punctuated the words made me laugh.

"Yep. White studded belt. Checkered Vans. For a while there my parents were convinced I only had one eye." He cocked his head, obviously not getting it. "You know, the whole bangs-covering-one-eye thing?"

He laughed. "I can't picture it. You're going to have to show me some pictures."

"If you're a good boy, I'll think about it," I teased.

He nearly stumbled over his own feet.

Looks like I wasn't the only one with a praise kink.

—

WE SPENT THE BETTER PART of the afternoon walking the promenade. As the sun started to set, my feet were practically screaming. It didn't take long for Atlas to notice.

"You doing okay over there?" he asked.

"My feet are starting to hurt," I said, shifting my weight to ease some of the pressure. "I should have worn different shoes."

His ears drooped. "Shit. Sorry about that."

I gave his biceps a little squeeze. "It's okay. It's not your fault. I should have worn something more comfortable."

"There's a bench over there." He pointed to an empty park bench right underneath one of the flowering trees. "Why don't we take a break?"

"Okay."

Atlas swept away the fallen petals covering the bench, motioning for me to sit. I slipped my flats off, wiggling my toes and resting my feet on top. It felt so good to be out of those fucking shoes.

I closed my eyes and tipped my head back, soaking in our afternoon together.

"This reminds me of the night at the wedding. When we sat on the bench in the garden." I opened my eyes, looking over to find him staring at me.

"Do you know how happy I felt, running into you like that again? There I was, feeling so alone in a room full of people, and then you showed up."

It was a feeling I could empathize with, because before I met him, I'd felt alone, too.

I reached for his hand, staring into his eyes as I gave it a little squeeze. "I promise that as long as I'm around, you'll never feel alone."

A light breeze swept by, bringing a shower of cherry blossom petals with it.

One dainty little petal stuck to the tip of Atlas's shiny nose.

"You have a cherry blossom on your nose."

"I do?" His ears perked up, his golden eyes crossing as he looked down his snout. It made me giggle, which caused his tail to wag.

"Stay still," I instructed. "I'll get it."

I leaned in, bringing my face closer to his muzzle while I plucked the silky pink petal from his nose.

"There," I said, letting it flutter onto my lap between us.

I was still in his space, and neither of us pulled away.

"Do you know what cherry blossoms symbolize?" I asked, my voice a low whisper.

“No.”

“Lots of things. Beauty. Life and death.” I paused for a second, digging my teeth into my lip. “New beginnings.”

His furry brows drew back, a smile curling up one corner of his muzzle. “New beginnings?”

“Mhm.” I couldn’t believe I’d said it, and on our first date, no less, but there was something building between us. Something I couldn’t quite put my finger on. Something inexplicable.

“Tegan.” He reached out, gently cupping my face with one of his massive palms.

“Atlas,” I said, a hint of a smile in my voice.

He stared at me intently, those full-moon eyes fixed right on my lips. “I’m going to kiss you now.”

I tried to play it cool, but my heart soared with this over-the-moon feeling that hinted at just how much I liked Atlas. I’d imagined this moment countless times since our almost kiss at the wedding, and it was finally coming to fruition.

“About time.”

He chuckled softly and angled his head, bringing his lips to mine. His textured tongue brushed against mine, his soft fur tickling my face. Because of his snout, it was a shallower kiss than I was used to, which was fine because we were in public and it didn’t need to be a full-on make-out session, but I wanted to explore things with him more. See the ways we could work around our anatomy.

He eased up, smiling against my lips for a second before he finally pulled away. “That was even better than I imagined.”

“It really was,” I said breathlessly.

Atlas’s tail wagged, gently thumping against my lower back, letting me know how happy he was about what just happened. He was always so expressive, his tail or his ears giving away exactly what he was thinking or feeling. It was a type of honesty I wasn’t used to with humans.

We sat on the bench and held hands, taking in the sunset. Orange rays of light lit up the surface of the water, rippling as another cool spring breeze

blew by.

“We should probably get going,” Atlas suggested. “It’s starting to get chilly.”

“Yeah,” I said sadly, not wanting our date to end.

“I can carry you back to the car if you want.”

I snorted. “No thank you.”

“Come on,” he said, crouching slightly and holding his arms out at his sides like he was a linebacker—like he was ready for me to jump on his back.

“Atlas. What are people going to think if they see you carrying me?”

“Who cares what they think. You’re my girlfriend and I’ll carry you if I want to.”

My heart raced and my mouth hung open. I wasn’t expecting that today. I didn’t even know what to say.

He stood up straight, looking at me with soft, hopeful eyes. “I mean, I want you to be,” he said, slightly embarrassed.

I wanted that, too.

When it came to a relationship with him, I was all in.

“Crouch down again,” I instructed.

He cocked his head to the side. “Are you going to say anything or—”

“Will you just crouch down again!”

“All right, all right.” He laughed, resuming his piggyback stance.

I took a deep breath and hopped on his back, wrapping my arms around his neck while he scooped my thighs under his arms.

He hoisted me up and started to walk back to the parking garage. We didn’t get nearly as many strange looks as I thought we would, but I didn’t even care. I felt safe and secure with him holding me.

“Atlas?” I asked as the parking garage came into view.

“Yeah?”

I rested my head on his shoulder, leaning in to whisper, “I would love to be your girlfriend.”

Seventeen



ATLAS

WHAT STARTED AS A SLIP of my tongue turned into something special. Tegan was my girlfriend, and while I was absolutely giddy, there was a part of me that was already worried I was going to fuck this up.

I held her hand over the center console, fingers twined with hers as I drove us back into town.

Her phone vibrated and she slipped her hand away from mine.

“Hmm,” she said, staring down at the screen.

“Everything okay?”

“Do you have anything planned after this?” she asked, ignoring my question.

“If you count playing video games and doing laundry, then yes.”

“Are you hungry?”

“Have you seen me?” I asked, making her laugh.

“You’re right. That’s a silly question.” She paused for a second, tapping her fingers against her thigh. “Would you want to have dinner with me and my friends? I know we literally just started dating, but they really want to meet you.”

Dinner was easy enough, and if they were important to Tegan, they were important to me.

“I’d love to meet your friends,” I said, surprising myself a little bit.

“Where are we going?”

“The diner on Main Street.”

“I’ve been meaning to stop in there.” I passed by it every day on my way to the gym, saw the glow of the neon sign late at night and smelled the freshly cooked bacon wafting out of the place in the morning. The thought made my mouth water.

“My friend Declan is the owner. The food is really good.”

“Is that who we’re meeting?”

“Mhm. Him and Selene. She works with me at the bakery.”

“Ah. The one who was supposed to help with the cake?”

She laughed. “Yeah. That’s her.”

“I’ll have to thank her.”

I pulled my truck into one of the parking spaces in front of the shiny silver diner. It must have been the dinner rush, because the place was packed.

“Are you sure you want to do this?” Tegan asked as I reached for my door handle. “It’s been a long day—”

“What? You don’t want me to meet your friends?” I asked with a smile, cocking my head.

“No!” she blurted. She was cute when she was flustered. “It’s not that at all. Selene is great, but Declan can sort of be a lot.”

It made me laugh, because I was all too familiar with best friends who could be a lot.

“Wait until you meet Fallon.” I tightened my grip on her hand, hoping to steady her nerves with my touch. “Everything’s going to be fine.”

Chatter and ’80s pop music filtered out when I opened the door for Tegan. With her leading the way, we stepped inside, and I swear it was like all the air was sucked out of the room. Every conversation stopped and every set of eyes in the place was on us.

“Hey!” Tegan said awkwardly, giving a little wave to all the people staring at us.

I assumed this wasn’t the normal greeting she received when she showed up at the diner. Things were so uncomfortable because she was there with me. I was under the impression that she didn’t date much, let

alone bring someone around. That meant I was lucky, even if I didn't feel it at the moment.

"Oh my gods, they're here," someone squealed, shattering the silence. It was like they broke a spell because everyone resumed their conversations, turning their attention away from us.

Tegan noticeably brightened up, tugging me toward a booth at the back of the diner.

"This is Declan and Selene," she said, as we slid into the booth.

"Hello!" the guy—I'm assuming Declan—said, waving enthusiastically. He looked to be about our age, smiley and chipper with a bushy beard that really fit his face.

"Hi," the girl—Selene—said, with a much more subdued wave. She had to be younger than us, early twenties if I had to guess. Tall and thin with curly brown hair. There was no way I could ever introduce her to Fallon.

Tegan introduced me next. "This is my boyfriend, Atlas."

"Boyfriend!" Declan said, his brows drawing back. "That's new."

I looked at my watch. "Yep, as of an hour ago."

"I'm so happy for you guys," Selene said.

"You're so tall," Declan said, staring at me wide-eyed.

"Uh, thanks, I guess?" I rubbed my ears, feeling slightly awkward.

Selene elbowed Declan in the stomach, giving him a look.

"What?" he scoffed. "It's just an observation."

"Anyway," Selene said, cutting in. "You own the gym down the street?"

I nodded. "Yep. I bought the old rec center six months ago, and after renovations, we've been open for about three months."

"That's so cool," Selene said. "I might have to stop by and check it out."

"For sure. I can give you some passes," I told her.

"Is the pool still in there?" Declan asked.

I nodded. "Completely refinished but it's still there."

Declan brought his hand to his chest. "Tegan and I learned to swim in that pool."

"Oh, me, too," Selene chimed in.

“Is that right?” I said, smiling over at Tegan.

“We did—and I think it was pretty run down even then,” Tegan said. “I’m glad you could save the rec center. We had a lot of memories there.”

“Summer camp. Pottery class. Oh, remember that year our parents signed us up for karate?” Declan asked Tegan.

I loved this glimpse into Tegan’s past, the history of the town, and her friendships. It left me hungry for more, wanting to know everything about this woman and make my own memories with her.

“I can’t imagine you and Dec doing karate,” Selene said.

The thought of Tegan in a bright white gi, her bun flopping around on top of her head while she doled out punches and kicks, was adorable. Maybe I could get her to sign up for BJJ classes. She’d probably kick ass at it.

“Hey, I almost got my yellow belt, thank you very much,” Declan said, crossing his arms over his chest.

I don’t know why Tegan was worried. Declan was a little dramatic, but he was funny. I was having a good time.

“Yeah, and I remember you crying when you didn’t get it,” Tegan teased.

“We were five, Tegan Marie,” he said, slamming his hands down on the table.

“Tegan Marie?” I asked, amusement in my voice. Another tidbit about her I’d file away, hoarding them like I was a dragon and Tegan was the gold.

“Mhm,” Declan said. “Tegan Marie Rollins.”

“It’s a family name,” Tegan insisted. “What’s your middle name?” she asked me.

Oh man. I set myself up for that one.

“Eros. My dad’s side of the family is really into Greek mythology.”

“Atlas Eros Oberon,” Tegan said. I liked the way my name sounded rolling off her tongue. “I like it.”

Declan nodded. “Very Greek god-like.”

“Mmm. The god of love,” Selene said. She stared at me and Tegan, a smile spreading over her face. “Fitting.”

I’d never really found it fitting. Certainly not after a miserable fourteen-year relationship, but maybe the tides were turning.

“All right, what’s everyone eating?” Declan asked. He pulled a notepad and a pen out of his pocket and set them on the table. “Your usual?” he asked Selene and Tegan.

“Yep,” they answered in unison.

He scribbled their orders down on his notepad from memory. They must eat a lot of meals here together. It was comforting to see how close the three of them were. It meant that friendships were important to Tegan, and I hoped she’d be open to meeting my friends after this.

“Can you pass Atlas a menu, Tega?” Declan asked.

“Oh yeah.” Tegan reached behind the condiment caddy, passing me a sticky laminated menu. A *long* menu.

I looked the list of dishes up and down, front to back. Strawberry milkshakes. Beer-battered onion rings. *Bacon double cheeseburgers*.

Everything sounded so good.

But—I needed to stick to my meal plan.

“Um, could I just get two grilled chicken breasts with a side of brown rice?” I said, with every bit of willpower I could muster.

Declan reared back, wrinkling his nose. “You sure about that?”

“The food here is really good,” Selene reassured me, like it might make me change my mind.

Tegan looked at me knowingly, but didn’t say a word.

“Yeah.” I sighed. “I’m sure.”

“Okay, then,” Dec said. He slipped out of the booth and disappeared inside the kitchen, returning a second later. “Carl is back there tonight. He’ll have our food out next.”

“Dec! It’s packed in here tonight,” Selene said, glancing at the bustling diner around us.

He shrugged. “So?”

“Shouldn’t you take care of the paying customers first?” she asked.

He waved her off, noticeably unbothered. “They’re fine. It’s not like they’re going to take their business elsewhere.”

Selene rolled her eyes, then shifted her attention to me and Tegan. She put her elbows on the table, leaning in to ask, “So what did you two get up to today?”

“We went to see the cherry blossoms in Rock Harbor,” I said.

Selene sighed dreamily. “How romantic.”

“It was very romantic,” Tegan said. “Especially the part where Atlas carried me on his back.” She reached for my hand under the table, giving it a little squeeze.

“You carried her on your back?” Declan asked, mouth hanging open.

“Just back to the car,” I rushed out. “Her feet were hurting.”

Declan made some sort of screech, one that I’m sure would have drawn attention if we weren’t right next to the blaring jukebox. “That is so cute,” he said.

“You two are adorable together,” Selene agreed.

I glanced down at Tegan to find her gazing up at me. We were pretty cute together, weren’t we?

While we were having our moment, a waitress appeared at the table, an older woman with lines etched deep in her forehead, and prominent jowls like a bulldog. Even with the tray of delicious food she was carrying, the scent of cigarettes wafted off her, enough to make my nose want to wrinkle.

“Thanks, Connie,” Declan said sweetly.

“Yeah, yeah,” Connie said, setting the first of many plates on the table.

She served Tegan, Declan, and Selene first, obviously familiar with their orders, before she set my chicken breasts and brown rice in front of me. It looked sad and beige, especially when you compared it to the greasy goodness that graced everyone else’s plates.

I stared at Tegan’s burger, feeling my mouth water.

I should have ordered one. It wasn’t like this was a daily thing.

While Selene and Declan dug into their food, chatting happily, Tegan leaned over, whispering in my ear, “If you stare at my burger any harder, it might explode.”

I chuckled. "It looks really good."

"It's a *very* big burger," she said. "I could give you half."

A tiny, barely audible whine crept up the back of my throat. "I shouldn't."

"Come on," she urged. "It's just half of a bacon double cheeseburger. We had such a great day. Might as well finish strong."

Finish strong.

That sent my mind to devious places, dirty places that definitely did not involve bacon double cheeseburgers.

"All right," I relented, but she was already holding a knife, cutting the burger in half.

Two very unequal halves.

"There we go," she said, discreetly sliding the larger half onto my plate.

"Thank you," I whispered.

I picked up the burger, giving it a little squeeze before taking a bite. It was perfectly cooked, a juicy medium rare just how I liked it. The lettuce, bacon, and raw onion gave it the perfect amount of crunch. It was heaven on a bun. I could see why it was Tegan's favorite.

"I'm glad you came to your senses. How is it?" Declan asked, staring at me while I chewed.

"It's delicious. No wonder everyone looked at me like I had three heads when I ordered grilled chicken."

"There's nothing wrong with being health conscious, but this is your first time at the diner," Selene said. "Indulge a little bit."

Tegan nodded. "And save room for some pie. We can split a slice for dessert."

While burgers and pie weren't part of my meal plan, I wanted to enjoy myself. I wanted to live in this moment with my girlfriend and her friends.

I smiled at Tegan. "I'd love to."

—

"TODAY WAS AMAZING," TEGAN SAID as I walked her to her front door.

“It was.”

But I could think of something that would make it even better.

Bending down, I cupped her face and she leaned into my touch as I smoothed my thumb over her soft cheek. She was such a contrast to me, so small and so fragile. It felt like I held the world in the palm of my hand.

I tilted my head, bringing my mouth to her pillowy lips. Her fingers threaded into my fur, her tongue sliding into my mouth with a contented sigh that went straight to my cock.

I groaned, deepening the kiss, wanting more from her. All the things I’d fantasized about leading up to this moment flashed through my mind. I hadn’t felt desire like this in a long time.

But we’d just started dating. I didn’t want her to think that sex was all I was after.

Reluctantly, I pulled away and rested my forehead against hers while I stared into her emerald eyes.

“Good night, Tegan,” I said, stroking her cheek again. She rolled her puffy lips, looking so hungry for me, I almost changed my mind. “I’ll text you when I get home.”

“Okay. Four a.m. tomorrow?”

“Yep. Hope you didn’t think you were getting off easy now that you’re my girlfriend,” I teased.

She shook her head, smiling warmly. “Not even for a second.”

I nuzzled her face, placing one last kiss on her temple before I finally let her go.

She pulled her keys out of her bag, unlocked her front door, and gave me a little wave before she slipped inside. I stood on the porch, waiting for a light to turn on inside before heading back to my truck.

It was the best day I’d had in a long time, and I smiled the entire drive home.

Eighteen



ATLAS

“DUDE. YOU DO NOT HAVE a fucking girlfriend,” Fallon chirped.

We were hanging out in my basement, the two of us playing *Super Smash Bros.* while Cyrus sat there silently judging, contributing to the conversation when he had something important to add.

“I do,” I said, giving in to the grin that came out every time I talked about Tegan.

“Who gets out of a fourteen-year relationship and jumps right into a new one?” Fallon asked, judging me hard. “You should be living it up. Enjoying yourself.”

“I am enjoying myself,” I said matter-of-factly.

“Personally, I don’t find anything wrong with it,” Cyrus said, suddenly invested in the conversation. “Atlas isn’t the type to date around, and if he didn’t have feelings for her, he wouldn’t have asked her out to begin with.”

Fallon stared at him, blinking a few times. “You’re supposed to back me up on this.”

Cyrus blinked back. “When do I ever back you up on anything?”

“So did you fuck her yet?” Fallon asked, because of course he would. “How was it—”

I shook my head, trying to keep my temper under control. “Please don’t talk about Tegan like that.”

“Talk about her how?” Fallon asked.

“Like she’s just some hookup. Our sex life is none of your business.” It was nonexistent currently, but that was beside the point.

“So you did fuck her!” Fallon shouted.

“I didn’t, okay!” I shouted back. “I felt like she wanted me to come inside but I just kissed her good night and drove home with a raging hard-on.”

Fallon stared at the ceiling, letting out a deep breath. “A-man, if she was giving you the signs, you should have just gone for it.”

“There’s nothing wrong with taking things slow,” Cyrus said.

I sighed. “That’s the thing, though. I don’t think she wanted to take things slow.”

“Well, then, why did you?” Fallon asked.

“I don’t know! Maybe because I’ve spent the last fourteen years fucking the same person like it was an obligation.”

Fallon stared at me wide-eyed. “Wait—”

Cyrus grimaced. “I’m sorry. I didn’t realize things had gotten that bad.”

“I mean, it was fine. Just not anything mind-blowing, ya know?”

“I wish you would have told us sooner. That is a giant red flag, my friend,” Fallon said, like he was some sort of sex therapist.

“I know,” I groaned. “I know I should have done something sooner, but I thought it was going to pass. I mean, we were together for fourteen years; I thought it was normal for things to get a little stale.”

Fallon whistled. “You dodged such a fucking bullet with that one, man. I hope this new girl lets you be all feral in bed. Taking your knot while you —”

Hot, possessive anger tore through me. As usual, Fallon was taking it too far.

I growled, showing my teeth. “Don’t you fucking talk about her like that.”

Tegan taking my knot didn’t need to be the topic of the conversation. Not now. Not ever.

“Easy,” Cyrus said calmly.

I closed my eyes and took a few deep breaths, letting the tension slip out of my body. “Sorry,” I grumbled to Fallon.

“It’s all good, man. I overstepped.”

As usual.

“So”—Fallon cleared his throat—“you’ve met her friends. When do we get to meet her?”

“Soon, I guess.”

“She would be down to hang out with us?” he asked.

“Why wouldn’t she be?”

“Jade never hung out with us,” Cyrus pointed out.

Fallon nodded. “She’d always come up with some lame excuse to avoid us.”

“I really don’t think she liked us very much, which is fine because the feeling was mutual,” Cy said.

“Yeah,” Fallon agreed. “There were a lot of red flags now that I think about it.”

“Like what?” I was curious what they saw in her that took me so long to notice—or so long to accept, rather.

“When we were in college, she wouldn’t let you go to parties without her,” Cyrus said.

“Red flag,” Fallon chirped.

“When you were thinking of opening a gym, she told you it wouldn’t be successful,” Cyrus said.

“Red flag.”

“Not to mention she obliterated your self-confidence,” Cyrus said, his voice laced with hatred.

That one really stung. They’d noticed, because of course they would have. They were my best friends, and I felt almost guilty that I’d put them through that.

“See?” Fallon said. “Red. Fucking. Flag.”

“Fuck. All right already. I wish you guys would have said something to me sooner.”

“Would you have listened to us?” Cyrus asked.

“I mean—” I thought about it for a second. “No.”

“Exactly,” he said.

The straw that really broke the camel’s back was when Jade made an offhand comment about my parents, about how I narrowly avoided a life as a hardware store owner. Like she was above that. Like she was better than my parents.

I still remember how she looked when I told her to get out—like I’d slapped her.

We were together for over a decade. Everyone expected us to get married and start a family. No one tells you how hard it is to extricate yourself from a relationship of that magnitude, but I just couldn’t keep pretending to be happy. I was miserable, and deep down, Jade probably felt the same way.

“You deserve a better partner,” Cyrus said. “Someone who appreciates you and gives you the kind of relationship you deserve.”

“And who knows?” Fallon said. “Maybe this girl is your mate.”

I laughed awkwardly.

After my relationship with Jade, I didn’t think the whole fated-mates thing was in the cards for me. But now? The things I felt for Tegan made me feel like it could be a possibility. I mean, not *now*. But maybe I gave up hope a little too prematurely.

“The full moon is coming up. Are you going to spend it with your new lady friend?” Cyrus asked.

“I mean, I don’t think so. Not yet at least.”

It wasn’t that I couldn’t because Tegan was a human. It was just too soon in our relationship to introduce her to that side of me. I didn’t want to hurt her or scare her, and we hadn’t even had sex yet. Knotting and rutting were unique to wolverines, and they weren’t the sort of thing you jumped right into.

I wanted to let her get comfortable with me first.

When the time was right, we’d spend the full moon together and I’d show her just how pleasurable it could be.

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Nineteen



TEGAN

HOW WAS I SUPPOSED TO articulate to Atlas that I wanted to fuck? It had only been a few days since we started dating, but we had made time to see each other every day, even if it was only for a few moments.

The night that he first asked me to go out with him, I could feel the sexual tension rolling off him in waves. I knew he wanted it—wanted me—but I felt him pull away at the last second.

Why was that? Had it been a long time for him, too? It was obvious that he was attracted to me, but maybe he just wanted to take things slow. I mean, that was fine, right?

I didn't need sex.

Or maybe I did?

Okay, I needed sex. Like really needed it with Atlas. I'd had enough with fantasies and website photos showcasing his impressive package. I wanted the real thing.

"That sound like a plan, Tegan?" His deep growl of a voice brought me out of my thoughts as he handed me a pair of dumbbells.

Once again, I was spacing out during our training session. When you're working out with your boyfriend and sex is the only thing on your mind, you're bound to be a little bit distracted.

"Mhm. Yep. Sounds good," I said, performing what I considered a perfect curl.

“No.” He laughed, reaching for my arm. “We aren’t doing curls today. Overhead shoulder press. We’re working on triceps, chest, and shoulders today.” He stepped up behind me, his hulking frame dwarfing mine in the mirrored wall in front of us. He brought his hands up to my arms, the rough pads of his fingers guiding them to where they needed to be.

“Like this,” he said as he leaned in closer, lifting my arms up and through the motion.

His body was so close to mine that I could feel the warm puffs of his breath on my neck with each word he spoke. I did my best to concentrate on what I was doing, but I managed to stick my ass out while I did it until I was almost grinding on him.

I could feel his dick getting hard against me, and when I finished my last set, our eyes met in the mirror.

“Shit, Tegan. I am so sorry,” he said before stepping back and turning away from me, his hands cradling the back of his head.

I set the weights down and made my way over to him. It was time to lay it all out on the table. “Atlas, there’s nothing to be sorry about. I am, like, really sexually attracted to you. You know that, right?” I reached up and gave his biceps a gentle squeeze.

He turned and stared down his muzzle at me, those golden orbs blazing with desire. “I’m really attracted to you, too. And it was probably painfully obvious just now.”

Uh, yeah it was. There was no way you could ignore that thing.

And I wasn’t going to.

“Come here.” I crooked my finger, beckoning him down to my level.

Atlas didn’t hesitate. He was on me in a second, his lips crashing into mine, the short hairs on his muzzle tickling my face as he pulled my body flush against his.

I moaned, fisting his shirt, angling my head to give him better access to my mouth.

He was always so careful with me, watching his claws and his teeth, doing his best not to hurt me, but to be honest, it was sexy as fuck knowing that at any moment he could overpower me. I loved the sweet side of Atlas,

but I was excited to see what would happen if he let his control slip a little bit.

It was like he could read my mind because he tightened his grip on my hip, the tips of his claws digging into me just the slightest as his cock rubbed against my pussy. He slipped his tongue inside my mouth and its rough, textured surface dragged against my tongue. I groaned, imagining what it would feel like teasing my clit with long, slow strokes.

“Atlas,” I moaned against his mouth. “What if someone sees us?”

“It’s not even five a.m., Tegan. No one is going to catch us. And trust me,” he murmured between kisses, “there are worse things that go on here.”

“Yeah?” I asked, my interest piqued. “Like what?”

His dark laugh against my lips sent a wave of need through me, one that intensified when he said, “Like me jerking off in the locker room while thinking of you.”

It was nice having confirmation that he’d fantasized about me like I’d fantasized about him. I didn’t feel nearly as bad about making myself squirt to his competition photo now.

If other things went on in the gym...

I grabbed his hand, leading him over to one of the weight benches.

“Sit down.” My voice was breathy, and I was sure my face was red from kissing him.

I expected some half-assed protest, but he adjusted his boner and sat down on the bench.

Leaning in, I gave him a quick peck on the lips before lowering to my knees in front of him. “Pull out your cock.”

“Baby, you don’t have to do this,” he said, his brow furrowed with concern.

Baby. Atlas called *me* “baby.”

“Please,” I said. “I need it.” I didn’t even recognize the sound of my own voice. Who was this lusty sex goddess?

The corner of Atlas’s muzzle curled up into a mischievous smile as he slipped down his shorts and underwear, letting his cock spring free.

Holy fuck.

Hung like a horse was nothing compared to hung like a wolverine.

His cock was enormous, long and thick with a few prominent veins running along the underside. A light dusting of gray fur covered his heavy balls, but the shaft was smooth and hairless, the skin the same gray color as his fur.

But the tip—the head of his cock—was a bright, vibrant red.

A bead of precum was already collecting along the slit and it made my mouth water. I wanted to taste it.

I ran my fingers through the fur of Atlas's thighs, and he shuddered.

"Do you want me to suck your cock, Atlas?" I asked, glancing up at him through my lashes.

"Fuck, please," he growled, the tips of his claws piercing the weight bench with an iron grip.

I licked my lips and leaned forward, opening my mouth and taking the tip of his cock inside. The taste of his precum hit my tongue, making me hum. It was sweeter than a human's. None of that salty, bleach-like taste that I was used to from my previous partners. I'd happily swallow for him any day.

"Unf, Tegan," he groaned, and slid his hands into my hair, tangling his fingers in the strands but not forcing me down onto his cock.

I was thankful for that because he was so big, I was worried I'd gag. Throwing up on someone's dick the first time you blow them isn't a good look.

I relaxed my throat, taking him deeper and deeper with every shallow bob of my head. It certainly wouldn't happen today, but I was determined to deep-throat him someday.

Look at me, already making plans to do this again.

Atlas started thrusting his hips lightly, his measured breaths turning into desperate pants. "Yes, baby. Look at you taking my cock as deep as you can. You're doing so well. Feels so fucking good."

I hummed and sucked harder, my lips tingling from the stretch and from the suction, but I slowed when I ran into something.

Bringing my hand up to Atlas's shaft, I gripped near the base and felt a thickened ring of tissue circling his cock.

"Ahh, fuck," he groaned. "Ha, I see you found my knot. Do you think you can take it, Tegan?" I looked up, my eyes meeting his gaze while I kept on sucking. "When I fuck your tight pussy, we'll find out."

Fuck.

I knew about knots, but I'd never been with someone who had one.

Not only did he want to put his gigantic cock inside of me, but that thick-ass knot was supposed to fit inside of me, too? That was fucking hot.

Atlas gripped my head a little tighter and pistoned his hips in light thrusts. "That's right. You like this monster cock, don't you, sweet thing? Yeah, just like that."

I worked my mouth over his cock with fast bobs of my head, my spit mixing with precum, dribbling down my chin and onto Atlas's balls.

My fingers clenched around his knot and Atlas sucked in a breath, his hands tightening in my hair once again.

"Yes, baby. Fuck! I'm gonna come." His voice was a deep growl, low and desperate to finish.

Again, I plunged his cock into the back of my throat as far as I could, my tongue cupping the veins on the underside of his dick until I felt it start to pulse, filling my mouth with his cum.

Eventually, his body stilled and his grip on my head loosened. I pulled off his cock with a wet *pop* and a small stream of cum trickled out onto my chin. Before I could wipe it away, Atlas's thumb was there. Ever so gently, he swiped it away and popped the rough pad of his finger into my mouth. I groaned and sucked his finger, careful to avoid his claw. I looked up at Atlas—his yellow eyes were slightly hooded, and he had a contented grin on his face.

"Good girl," he said with a sigh as he tucked his cock back into his shorts. "That was amazing."

Holding out his hand, he pulled me to my feet, then onto his lap.

I buried my face in the thick fur on his neck, letting out a deep sigh.

Even though I wasn't the one who just got off, I felt relaxed and content cuddled up against him. Like this was where I was supposed to be.

Atlas nuzzled his snout along my temple before gently nipping my earlobe with his teeth. "Say something, Tegan. You're making me worried." His voice was a quiet whisper.

I reached up and ran my fingers through the soft fur of his cheek, bringing his face closer to mine. "I just sucked your dick in the gym." I snorted a laugh, feeling my cheeks redden.

Warm, rumbling laughter erupted from Atlas's chest, and he rubbed the damp tip of his nose against mine affectionately. "You did. And it was hot as fuck."

Twenty



ATLAS

WAS THIS SERIOUSLY HAPPENING TO me? Did the girl of my dreams really suck my dick in my gym?

Fuck yeah, she did.

I was fairly confident she sucked my soul right out through my cock.

She had me so far gone for her that it was sad. I might as well have her name tattooed on my balls.

I held her like that for a few more minutes, just savoring the feeling of her body pressed against mine, basking in postorgasm bliss.

“We should probably finish our workout, I guess, right?” she whispered while rubbing her face into the ruff of fur along my neck.

“Yeah, you’re probably right.” I sighed and set her on her feet before rising next to her.

For the rest of our session, we exchanged giggles and furtive glances, with Tegan’s cheeks flushing each time my body brushed up against hers.

I worked her through some stretches for her cooldown and decided it was time to address the elephant in the room.

“So, uh, what are you doing tonight?” Goddess help me. I had no game. It wasn’t like I could just say, *Come over to my house so we can finally fuck.*

She smirked and bent over in front of me to touch her toes, her entire ass filling my field of view. “I don’t have any plans just yet,” she said coyly.

What a tease! She was going to kill me.

“Would you want to come over for dinner at my place? I, um, we could continue—”

She cut me off before I could finish digging myself into a self-deprecating hole. “I’d love to come over for dinner, Atlas Oberon. I’ll bring dessert.”

“Well, well, well,” Fallon chirped, strolling over to us. “What do we have here?”

Oh gods. Was this really happening?

My girlfriend just sucked my dick in the gym, and now my best friend was going to meet her for the first time.

I groaned. “Tegan, this is my friend Fallon.”

“Best friend Fallon,” he corrected.

“Nice to meet you, best friend Fallon,” she said, her voice all bubbly.

“What were the two of you doing here so early?” Fallon looked between Tegan and me—almost like he knew that something went on between us this morning. If I found out he was watching the cameras again...

“Just getting our workout in,” Tegan said, beaming at him. She was acting totally normal. Definitely not like she’d just sucked my cock thirty minutes ago.

“That’s great,” Fallon said, affectionately shaking my shoulder until I shrugged him off. “Atlas is an amazing trainer.”

It was nice of him to hype me up.

Tegan looked at me, rolling her lips with a mischievous sparkle in her emerald eyes. “He is.”

“We should all hang out sometime,” Fallon suggested. “Maybe you could come to our next game night.” It seemed like he was determined to make sure Tegan wasn’t like Jade. Which she wasn’t. Not even a little bit.

“That would be great,” she said excitedly. “I love board games.”

I laughed at the image of me, Fallon, Cyrus, and Kael crouched around a table playing The Game of Life. “He means video games.”

“Ah,” Tegan said, nodding slowly. “I should have known. I’m not the best at those, but I’d love to come hang out.”

“Cool. I’ll make sure Atlas brings you with him next time,” Fallon said.

Tegan glanced at the time on her phone. “Shoot. I need to go get some cakes in the oven.” She quickly gathered her things and stepped close to me. “Text me the time and your address. I’ll see you later. Thanks for the workout.” She stood on her tiptoes, placing a light kiss on my nose, which made my tail wag. “It was nice to meet you, Fallon,” she said before rushing out the door.

I stood there for a moment in a daze.

There was no way this was happening to me.

An awful breakup and then I literally stumble upon the girl of my dreams?

I was waiting for the other shoe to drop.

“I really like her,” Fallon said.

I figured he would, but it was still a relief. Even if he plucked my last nerve, I still cared what he thought, especially after everything with Jade.

“I’m glad but I swear, if you were watching us on the cameras—”

“Relax.” He laughed. “I didn’t see anything. But from your reaction I can tell that *something* definitely went on between you two.”

I puffed out a breath. “Things have finally reached the tipping point.”

His eyes widened. “Oh yeah?”

I nodded. “She’s coming over tonight ‘for dinner.’ ”

“Gonna feed her that dick, I see.”

It was too funny for me to even be mad.

“Maybe I already did,” I said, shrugging nonchalantly. “Who’s to say?”

“Yo!” Fallon shouted, shaking my shoulder again. He was so excited, I couldn’t bring myself to shove him off me. “My fucking guy! I knew you two were up to something.”

I walked back to my office with Fallon in tow. I was going to have to check his client logs, because it felt like he didn’t do any actual work here.

I sat down at my desk and Fallon plopped down in the seat across from me.

“I’m so proud that my little wolf daddy is finally going to get laid. I wonder what she’s going to say about your McMansion,” he said, ruffling his feathers. He knew how much I hated that house.

“I can’t help it that I live in a fucking mansion, Fal. I’m sort of stuck with it at this point.”

“I’m just saying that I wouldn’t mention you bought it with your ex-fiancée, is all.”

I sucked in a tight breath, that little detail feeling like a heavy weight on my chest. “I have to at some point.”

“At *some point*. Not right before you fuck her.”

“Please shut up.”

He laughed awkwardly, a high-pitched chuffing sound. “Sorry, man. I just want this to go well for you.”

I could hear the sincerity in his voice. I don’t think I would have made it through those first few months of my breakup if it wasn’t for Fallon. We had hung out practically every day and I was thankful as fuck for him.

“Thanks, my guy,” I said. “I want it to go well, too.”

“Now, I know you’ve been out of the game for a while, so if you need any tips—”

I cut him off. “Nope. I’m good, thanks. Now if you could get out so I can get some work done, that would be great. I want to leave on time today.”

He slowly rose out of his chair. “Good luck tonight, wolf daddy. Make me proud.” He slipped out of the office, his laughter trailing off as he walked down the hall.

Twenty-One



TEGAN

“OKAY, SO I GOT ALL the cupcake preorders finished. You’re working on the retirement party cake, and then you’re going to teach me how to make the kolaches, right?” Selene asked, staring at her notepad.

We were running through our to-do list, making sure none of the orders or duties for the day were missed. She was doing a great job, keeping everything organized and making sure we were fully stocked with bakery essentials like butter, sugar, and flour. It was so nice to have her help, especially in the areas where I was lacking. My life would have been so much easier if I had given her more responsibilities sooner.

“Yep.” I rotated the cake I was working on, making sure the icing was smooth and level on the sides and top. “They’re pretty simple.”

“So. You seem like you’re in a particularly good mood today. Did anything happen this morning?”

I could feel the heat rushing to my cheeks. How was she so good at reading me? “I, um, I might have given Atlas a blow job at the gym this morning,” I mumbled.

She gasped. “Tegan Marie Rollins. You did not.”

I nodded, keeping my eyes laser focused on the cake. “I did.”

“I don’t even know who you are anymore.” She nudged my shoulder, and thank gods I wasn’t actually working on the cake anymore because I

totally would have messed up. “That’s huge. How did it even happen?” she asked.

I puffed out a breath, turning around to face her. “I was tired of waiting for him to make the first move. He was helping me with this one workout and his cock kept brushing against my ass, so I just sort of went for it.”

“Right in the middle of the gym?” she asked, like it was the most scandalous thing she’d ever heard. Maybe it was. It was definitely the most brazen thing I’d ever done.

“We were tucked back in a corner, and it was super early in the morning. No one was there,” I assured her.

“Still. You’re wild.” She paused for a second, then asked, “How was his cock?”

“Huge. Intimidating. I don’t even know what to think about his knot.”

“Have you ever been with anyone with a knot before?” she asked.

Selene knew some of my previous dating history, about my ex-girlfriend and the issues surrounding the bakery that led to our breakup, but I hadn’t given her a full rundown of my sexual escapades.

I shook my head. “No. I’ve played with some toys that had one but, like, never had one inside me. I know it’s possible, though.”

I knew porn wasn’t an accurate depiction of how things were in real life, but between that and this morning’s internet deep dive into wolverine and human pairings, it confirmed that knotting was possible. Painful at first, but possible. I looked at it as an exciting challenge.

My phone vibrated and I pulled it out of my pocket.

Selene’s full lips quirked up in a sly smile. “Oh damn, I wonder if it’s Atlas.”

“Stop it,” I snorted.

“Can I peek?” she asked before I unlocked my phone.

“Ugh. Get over here.”

Selene shimmied next to me, peeking at my phone as I typed in the passcode.

Her brown eyes twinkled as she looked at the screen. “Tegan! You stalker! You made his contact photo the picture from his website?”

My cheeks flushed. “Don’t judge me! I don’t have any pictures of him yet!”

“You have got it bad. I’ve never seen you like this!”

I bit back a grin and held out the phone so we could read his text.

Atlas: I had a lot of fun this morning. What do you want to have for dinner? What are you bringing me for dessert? 😊

“He sent you a wink face!” She shrieked out the last part.

This was a mistake. I should have just waited to read the text myself like a normal person.

Shit.

“What do I say?” Now it was my turn to shriek.

“Oh my gosh, you are so adorable! Just tell him what your favorite meal is! I know you love shrimp scampi, so just say that. And don’t think I’m letting the wink face go. He definitely plans on having you for dessert.” She threw her head back and cackled as I pulled the phone away from her to type out a reply.

Tegan: I had a lot of fun too. I really like shrimp scampi! But if you have a seafood allergy, we can have something else! And I’ll handle dessert 😊

Selene read the message from over my shoulder as I hit send. “Look at you, ya flirt. You better *be* dessert after this morning’s gym stunt. We don’t like men who receive but don’t give.”

She was 100 percent correct in that. I didn’t have time for a partner who wasn’t interested in going down on me. I had the feeling that I’d actually have the opposite problem with Atlas. He’d probably apply that same

practiced perfectionism to cunnilingus as he did to working out and sculpting his body.

We stood in silence for a few seconds, staring wide-eyed at my phone. Yeah, I was making Selene a part of this. She was invested.

I almost dropped my phone when it vibrated.

Atlas: Shrimp scampi it is. What you want, you'll get. Especially after this morning 😊 I owe you one, baby.

"Baby!" Selene screamed in my ear. "Since when does he call you 'baby,' Tegan!?" She covered her face with her forearm in a fake swoon.

"Well, it definitely sounds like he's down to reciprocate." I chuckled under my breath and bit down on my lower lip to fight back a smile.

"This is a big deal, Teg. What time are you meeting him?" she asked.

"Shit. I didn't ask. I need his address, too," I said, typing out another text to Atlas.

Tegan: I almost forgot! What time and what's your address?

It only took a second for him to respond.

Atlas: How's 6pm? I usually eat at 5 because I'm a grandpa, but I'll have a snack before I start dinner. My address is 317 Briar Lakes Drive. See ya then 😊

Selene's mouth was hanging open. "Oh, Tegan. Briar Lakes? Isn't that the gated development where the mayor lives?"

Panic welled up inside of my chest. "Fuck. It is, isn't it?"

Selene grimaced and nodded her head in confirmation.

“I mean, it’s fine. He seems like a perfectly normal guy. So what if he lives in a really fancy house in a really fancy neighborhood, right?”

She schooled her expression and wiped a streak of icing from my cheek. “Yeah, it’ll be totally fine. He didn’t give off rich-asshole vibes.”

If Selene or Dec felt like anything was off with Atlas, they would have told me.

“Yeah, it’ll be fine,” I repeated, trying to reassure myself. “I’m freaking out over nothing.”

“What are you going to wear?” Selene asked.

“A dress probably?” Something that looked good but was easy to take off.

Selene pulled out her phone, her nails tapping against the screen. “That’ll be cute.” Her phone vibrated and she smiled to herself.

“Who’s got you smiling like that?” I asked.

“You’re just going to have to see.” She typed out another message and slipped her phone back into her pocket. “Now, let’s get these kolaches finished so we can get out of here on time.”

That was right. *The fucking kolaches*. It wasn’t like Brian needed them right away...

“You know—why don’t I just text Brian and tell him that we’ll have the kolaches for him later this week. We can close a little bit early today. Is that okay with you?” I asked, knowing Selene usually took all the hours she could get.

She grinned. “That works out perfect, actually.”

—

A CHOCOLATE COCONUT CAKE AND two piping bags full of icing sat in a box on my kitchen counter, just waiting for me to take them to Atlas’s. The only thing left to do was figure out what I was going to wear.

Dressed in my best lingerie—a light pink lace bra with a matching thong—I stared at the two dresses I’d laid out on my bed. Option number one was a green velvet wrap dress. Pretty, but very similar to the dress I

wore to the wedding. Option number two was a satiny blue dress with spaghetti straps. It was cute, but the bra I was wearing wouldn't work with it, and I didn't like the way the material clung to my belly.

Fuck.

I went back to my closet, flipping through the rows of hangers in the hopes that something else might catch my eye, when the doorbell rang.

"Who the fuck could that be," I huffed, pulling on my robe when the doorbell rang again. "Coming," I shouted, stomping down the hall to the front door.

I yanked it open to find Dec and Selene standing on my front porch.

"Surprise!" they said in unison.

"What are you guys doing here?" I asked, clutching my robe tight to my chest.

Selene held up a garment bag. "We wanted to bring you something to make tonight extra special."

"It isn't every day that our bestie gets dicked down," Dec said.

I laughed, but I also wanted to cry. They really were the best.

"Aw, you guys. Come on, get in here," I said, holding the door open for them.

They followed me down the hall to my bedroom, and Selene tossed the garment bag on top of the rejected dresses.

"I think you're going to love it," she said.

Dec and I stood on either side of her as she slowly unzipped the bag.

A light pink gingham swing dress with wide shoulder straps was inside. The perfect cutesy, retro dress of my dreams.

"Oh my gosh," I said, "it's adorable."

"I knew you'd love it. It's from the same boutique as the dress you wore to the wedding," Selene said.

The boutique she was referring to was all the way in Rock Harbor, a whole forty-five minutes away from Briar Glenn. *So that was why she was okay with closing the shop early.*

"Isn't that place a little pricey for a gift?" I asked, considering I'd had a hard time buying the other one when it was on clearance. Neither of them

was independently wealthy, and I hated the thought of them spending their hard-earned money on me.

“Relax,” Selene said, gently placing her hand on my arm. “Dec pitched in, so it really wasn’t bad at all.”

Dec nodded. “We wanted you to look like a knockout tonight, even if the dress is just going to end up on Atlas’s floor.”

I snorted. I mean, that *was* the plan.

Selene laughed her signature raspy chuckle and pulled the dress out of the bag, holding it out to me. “Go. Try it on.”

I headed straight for the bathroom, closing the door with a loud *thud* behind me.

“Make sure you come out and let us see it! Even if you don’t like it!” Selene shouted from the other side of the door.

“We mean it, Tegan!” Declan added.

I untied my robe and let the fuzzy piece of material fall to the floor. I caught a glimpse of my body in the mirror before pulling on my dress. My breasts were substantial, with light pink nipples and delicate streaks of white stretch marks. My waist was soft and round and widened to thick thighs, which rubbed together when I walked—also complete with bands of stretch marks.

It wasn’t a perfect body, not by conventional beauty standards, but I loved and appreciated it. Loved and appreciated all the things it allowed me to do. It was strong, healthy, and it obviously called to the desires of an attractive wolverine.

I stepped into the gingham beauty and gently shimmied it over my hips.
Please, goddess, fit.

I was sure that we could figure something else out, but I really wanted to wear this damn dress and live out my cottagecore queen fantasies.

When the zipper clicked into place at the base of my shoulder blades, I could have cried tears of joy.

I stared at myself in the mirror for a moment, admiring how the dress accentuated every curve of my body, defining my breasts and waist before flaring out at the bottom.

Atlas was going to be foaming at the mouth over the sight of me in this dress.

I looked like an absolute snack.

“Are you ready?” I yelled out to my best friends in a singsong voice.

“Duh. I’m freaking dying out here, Teg.” Declan groaned the last part for emphasis.

I took a deep breath and smiled before turning the knob. When I stepped out into the bedroom, I grabbed the hem and did a little twirl for them, the dress billowing around me.

Dec clapped his hands together. “Absolutely stunning.”

“You look amazing,” Selene said before wrapping me in a tight hug.

I knew Atlas was going to think so, too.

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Twenty-Two



ATLAS

WHAT THE FUCK DID ONE wear on a dinner date when you were an absolute gym bro? I'd had a hard enough time finding something to wear for our first date, and I didn't want to repeat any outfits just yet. I was pretty sure gray sweatpants didn't count for date attire other than Netflix and chill—which I would totally be down for with Tegan—but that wasn't what this was.

We'd both made our expectations for the evening pretty clear. I wanted to dress the part.

I rummaged through my closet hoping I could find another pair of dinner date-appropriate pants that would fit over the twin barrels I called my thighs.

"Aha," I yelled to myself when I pulled a pair of khakis off the very top shelf of my closet. Tugging at the material, I was shocked that it had a slight stretch to it. *These might actually work.*

I kicked off my sweats and wriggled the khakis up my calves and then by some miracle they made it over my thighs. When my tail was worked through the specially made hole in the back, they buttoned with no problem and sat low on my waist, just below the V of my hips.

Perfect.

Now what shirt was I going to wear?

I flicked through the rows of hangers, past the shirt I wore on our last date and all the Leviathan Fitness T-shirts and tank tops I owned.

There had to be something dressier in here.

My eyes caught on a light pink button-down shirt. It reminded me of the color of Tegan's cheeks when she blushed.

I snatched it from the hanger and lumbered over to the mirror.

"Come on, fit. Please fit," I mumbled under my breath as I pulled on the thin piece of material, taking extra care not to snag it with my claws.

I slipped my arms in and shrugged it over my shoulders, holding my breath while I did so.

"Yes!" I shouted as I fumbled with the buttons. Big hands made buttons difficult enough, and when you paired those with claws, it was a tedious task.

I stepped back and admired myself in the mirror, my tail swaying from side to side behind me.

The fur on top of my head curled wildly and I did my best to tame it, but it was a losing battle. Tegan would just get a chance to see me in all my furry glory.

Buzz.

My phone vibrated in my pocket and I pulled it out to turn off my alarm.

5:40 p.m.

She should be arriving soon.

I'd prepped all the ingredients for dinner earlier, so I just had to throw everything together, and we'd be good to go.

As I bolted down the stairs to the kitchen, I shook my head.

I still couldn't believe Tegan sucked me off this morning in the gym.

I figured my knot would be new and my size might be intimidating, but she seemed so turned on by it, giving it everything she had.

Holding her in my lap afterward felt so normal.

So right.

I couldn't wait to take my time with her tonight. I wanted to show her just how fun a wolverine's textured tongue could be.

I did one last sweep of the kitchen, making sure everything was ready. I'd set us up to eat at the island because it felt cozier than the formal dining

room. To be honest, I hated that fucking thing. Most useless room in this entire fucking house.

In fact, a lot of these rooms were fucking useless.

Maybe I should just take the loss and sell the place.

I was worried this stupid McMansion would give Tegan the wrong impression of me.

Sure, I had some money now, but that didn't change who I was—and it never would.

That was one of Jade's biggest gripes about me. But Tegan was different.

I could tell from the way she looked at me. The way she laughed. The pride she had in herself. The love she had for her friends.

There was no faking those sorts of things.

Just as I was about to plop my ass onto one of the stools surrounding the island, the in-home intercom system dinged to life.

"Mr. Oberon, a Ms. Tegan Rollins is here to see you. Would you like us to let her in?" Ken, the security guard who worked the front gate, asked.

Fucking gated communities. I was a wolverine. An apex predator. Why the fuck did I need to live in a gated community?

"Yes, Ken. Go ahead and let her in, thanks. In fact, add her to my priority guest list. She's welcome at any time," I said with a smile.

"Will do, sir. Have a lovely evening," he said, and with a click, the intercom shut off.

Any moment now Tegan would pull up to my house. She was going to be here, in my home, having dinner with me.

My security system alerted me to movement in the driveway and I made my way to the front door just as Tegan rang the bell.

When I opened the door, the sight of her took my breath away. She looked gorgeous.

Her hair was styled in loose waves and her dress—sweet goddess, her dress. The light pink color matched my shirt and clung to every inch of her body, the low-cut neckline putting her perfect breasts on full display. I

mean, I hadn't seen them yet, but I was confident they were perfect, just like the rest of her.

My ears perked up and my tail shifted from side to side rapidly. I had to fight to keep my tongue from lolling out of my mouth. I was just so damn excited to see her.

"Hi there," Tegan said with a giggle. "Are you going to keep staring or did you want to invite me inside?"

Haha, shit. That sassy little attitude made me want to spank her ass until it was bright red.

I scratched my ear and smiled. "Oh, uh, yeah. Come on in. Glad to see you found the place okay."

Glad to see you found the place okay? The fuck, Atlas? You live in the most exclusive neighborhood in town. Of course she found it okay. Idiot. Any game I had went down the drain when it came to Tegan. She reduced me to a bumbling simp.

And the truth was, I had no problem with it.

I held the door open and gestured for her to come inside, admiring the way her dress fluttered with each of her steps.

"So, this is my house. Yes, I know it's a little ridiculous for one person, but for the time being I'm sort of stuck with it." I figured it was best to address the whole mansion thing sooner rather than later.

Tegan's bright green eyes widened as she took in the sleek white surfaces and modern decor. "I really like it, actually. And your shirt, too. We match."

Like the stupid love-drunk puppy I was, my tail wagged even harder. "You do?"

"Yes, silly." She nudged my shoulder playfully. "Where can I put this?" Tegan held up a white box that I assumed was our dessert.

"Oh, the kitchen's through here." I grabbed her hand, leading her down the hall to the kitchen.

"Atlas. Are you serious?" she mumbled as she looked around the kitchen.

"What?" I asked as I took the box from her and set it on the counter.

“This kitchen! This is like a full chef’s kitchen.” The excitement in her voice was cute.

“Well, I like to cook, so—” I shrugged and scrubbed my claws along the back of my neck. I guess I never thought much of it because I saw it every day, but it was my favorite part of the house.

“You’ll have to give me lessons,” Tegan said as she sat down at the island. “I’m hopeless when it comes to cooking.”

“Wait, wait, wait. Your job involves cooking.” I leaned over the island and stared at her, just marveling at the sight of Tegan, *here*, in my house. On another date with *me*.

“I went to school to become a *pastry* chef. That isn’t the same as being a regular chef.” She giggled and rolled her eyes at me before tucking a loose piece of hair behind her ear.

“Well, my apologies, Ms. Rollins. But I’d love to teach you to cook. And it just so happens that tonight you’ll be having your first lesson.”

“My first lesson?” she asked, her brows drawing back.

With everything prepped, I figured it would be more fun having her help rather than just sitting there watching while I did all the cooking. I even had something to keep her dress clean.

“Yep.” I went inside the pantry, pulling two aprons off the hook hanging by the door. “We have the classic ‘Kiss the Cook’ *or* the one that looks like you’re wearing a bikini. Which one would you like?” I asked, holding up an apron in each hand.

It didn’t take her long to decide. “Definitely the ‘Kiss the Cook.’ You in a bikini is too good to pass up.”

“I mean, you’ve already seen my competition pictures. Isn’t that pretty much the same thing?”

“Shhh.” She put her finger to my lips, hushing me. “Don’t ruin the fantasy for me.”

Once we put on our aprons and washed our hands, I laid out all the ingredients and had Tegan stand next to me at the counter.

“All right,” she said, rubbing her hands together. “What are we doing here?”

Her enthusiasm was adorable.

I had Tegan boil the noodles while I worked on the garlic bread. When that was done, I'd sauté the shrimp and mix everything together.

"So where did you learn to cook?" she asked, stirring the noodles.

Because the last thing I wanted to do tonight was slice my finger open, I finished cutting the garlic bread in half before I answered. "My dad taught me everything I know."

"Huh."

I cocked my head. "Is that surprising?"

"No. I mean, I just never saw my dad in the kitchen when I was growing up. My mom cooked all our meals."

"My dad really enjoys cooking, and he likes to take whatever he can off my mom's plate."

She hummed. "So that's what it's like to be part of a healthy, functional family."

If that's what she considered a healthy and functional family, her bar was pretty low. To me, that was the bare minimum.

"You don't have a good relationship with your family?" I asked.

"Things between me and my mom are great, but things with my brother and I have been weird since my dad passed away last year."

Tegan had mentioned her mom and her brother, but she'd never talked about her dad.

"I'm sorry." It wasn't an empty apology, either. I meant it. Losing someone was hard. "I had no idea."

She forced a smile and it made my heart ache for her. "It's okay."

"Were you guys close?" I asked. I hoped I wasn't pushing too hard on a painful topic, but family was important to me, and I wanted to learn more about hers.

"We were. I really loved my dad, but it's hard reconciling the version of him I knew with how other people perceived him. I think my mom and my brother carry a lot of resentment toward him. Sometimes I feel bad that I don't."

“I know it’s easier said than done, but you shouldn’t feel bad. It’s okay to love your dad even if he wasn’t always the perfect father or perfect husband. Being a parent and a partner is hard, and we’re all just living our life for the first time, figuring things out as we go.”

The noodles started to boil over, and Tegan jumped back from the stove.

“Shit, sorry,” she said, as I reached for the knob to turn off the heat.

“It’s all good,” I reassured her. I moved the pot to another burner, using a slotted spoon to fish out a noodle. After blowing on it a few times, I held the spoon out to Tegan, and she eagerly slurped up the noodle.

“Done?” I asked.

“Mhm,” she mumbled.

I drained the pasta, stirring in some olive oil so the noodles wouldn’t stick together. “All right, let me just finish the shrimp and we’ll be ready to eat.” I flicked on the burner, heating up olive oil, butter, and garlic in a stainless steel pan.

A minute later the scent of fresh garlic filled the kitchen, and I tossed in the shrimp with a dash of white wine. Tegan watched intently as I shimmied the pan to flip the shrimp.

“That is so sexy,” she said, her voice husky.

If she kept talking like that, we weren’t going to make it through dinner without me hauling her off to bed.

“What? This?” I asked, tossing the shrimp again.

“Yes. Watching your partner confidently cook a meal for you is so hot.”

I grinned. “This is just the first of many.”

Twenty-Three



TEGAN

“WHY DON’T YOU HAVE A seat and I’ll take care of the rest?” Atlas said, stirring the shrimp and noodles together.

“Are you sure?” I asked. “I don’t mind—”

“Tegan.” The stern way he said it was sexy—making me want to comply.

“Yes, sir.” I took off my apron and sat at the island.

Atlas looked at me over his shoulder and smiled. “That’s right. Now, what would you like to drink? I have sparkling water, blood orange soda—”

“Oh, I love blood orange. One of those, please.”

I watched in awe as Atlas popped the tab on the soda can with the sharp black tip of his claw.

“Would you like me to pour it in a glass?” He cocked his head to the side, one of his ears drooping slightly in question.

Fuck. He was so freaking cute.

“The can is fine! No need to dirty a glass.” I smiled as he set the can down in front of me.

I watched him as he moved around the kitchen, slipping on a pair of heavy-duty oven mitts and pulling the garlic bread out of the oven. He hummed as he plated two generous servings of scampi and placed the basket of garlic bread between us on the island.

Leaning over me, he set my plate down and whispered against the shell of my ear, “The fruits of our labor.” The cold tip of his nose sent a shiver down my spine and had warmth pooling between my legs.

So effortlessly sexy.

“Thank you,” I said as I spread my napkin over my lap.

The delicious aroma of garlic and parsley filled my nostrils as it wafted off the pasta. Atlas watched me, his yellow eyes glowing expectantly.

I picked up my fork and twirled a hefty bite around the prongs before popping it into my mouth.

“Mmm,” I groaned as the rich, buttery flavor hit my taste buds. Not only was he hot, but he was an amazing chef.

This was it. He was never getting rid of me now.

“Good?” he asked with a smile, and finally picked up his own fork.

“It’s freaking delicious,” I said while trying to cover my full mouth with my free hand. I wasn’t being very ladylike, but Atlas seemed to preen over the compliment and finally dug into his own plate of pasta.

“So, the whole mansion in Briar Lakes was unexpected,” I said after swallowing a bite of food.

“I, uh, I moved here with my ex.” He raised his brows and took a swig of his sparkling water.

“Ah, I see. I’m assuming the mansion was her idea?” I didn’t want to push him to bring up his personal life with me too soon, but I was genuinely curious. I wanted to know why he hated this house. I wanted to know more about him period.

“Absolutely,” he said with a deep laugh that did things for me. “I’d prefer a little cottage in the woods.”

“You say that now, but you haven’t seen the inside yet.”

Atlas set his fork down and folded his hands, placing his head on them to stare at me intently. “Not yet. But I want to.”

—

WHEN HE WAS FINISHED EATING, Atlas pushed his plate away and puffed out his cheeks with a deep groan.

“You all right over there?” I asked.

“I always eat too much when I have pasta.” There was a whiny edge to his otherwise deep voice.

“We can always skip dessert if you want.”

He scoffed and hoisted himself to his feet to collect our dishes. “There’s always room for dessert.”

Given his history, it felt like a win.

Atlas placed our dishes in the sink before coming up behind me. He nuzzled his snout in my hair, his nostrils flaring and sending little puffs of warm air out over my neck.

“You smell so good, Tegan.” His voice was so gravelly, I could feel his chest vibrating against my back.

I sighed, leaning into him as he kissed and licked along the column of my neck, trailing his lips and his tongue from my jawline to my collarbone.

“Shit,” I gasped as one of Atlas’s clawed fingertips drew a line up my thigh. It was gentle enough not to draw blood, and the sensation sent a shiver down my spine.

“So soft. So sweet,” Atlas said as his hand continued to explore beneath my dress, his fingers creeping closer toward the heat of my pussy.

“Please,” I asked, eliciting a dark chuckle from Atlas.

He stepped away from me and I fought back a whine at the abrupt loss of contact.

I wanted him.

I needed him.

He was being a total fucking tease.

But in a way, I liked it.

The evidence being how wet I was and how tightly I clenched my thighs together, doing whatever I could to create some friction.

Atlas stepped toward the box I brought and flicked it open with the tip of his finger.

“What’s this?” he asked as he pulled out the piping bags full of icing.

My cheeks reddened.

“I—I thought maybe we could have some fun with icing. If—if you’re into that sort of thing.”

I already knew the answer. He’d be down.

Before I knew what was happening, Atlas was thrusting the piping bags into my hands and lifting me up off my stool.

“Wrap your legs around my waist,” he instructed.

I did as I was told, feeling the substantial bulge of his erection straining against his khakis. With each of his steps it rubbed against my pussy, driving my arousal even higher.

I had no idea how it was going to fit, but we were going to make this work.

One thing was for sure.

I was going to fuck Atlas Oberon.

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Twenty-Four



ATLAS

EACH STEP UP TO MY room felt like agony, with Tegan's pussy pressed tight against my cock. I could feel the warmth radiating off her through my pants, and I had to fight to stifle the groans that threatened to slip out of my mouth.

Tegan diligently held on to the bags of icing, her green eyes scanning the staircase, then the hall leading to my bedroom.

I kicked open the door and carried her like the queen she was to the four-poster king-size bed in the middle of the room.

Tegan looked at the white duvet with a grimace and carefully placed the piping bags of chocolate icing on the nightstand.

"Atlas," she said, running her fingers over the fabric. "This is a really nice duvet. What if we get icing all over it?"

It was cute that in the heat of the moment she cared about my comforter, when in reality I couldn't give two shits about that thing. I'd buy a new one. A hundred new ones.

I pressed a button on my phone that closed the automatic blinds.

"I don't care about the blankets, Tegan. And trust me, I don't plan on wasting a single bite of that icing." I unbuttoned my shirt slowly, watching her heated gaze roam up and down my chest appreciatively.

It was rare that I felt confident, but the way she praised my body rather than criticizing it made me feel like I was on top of the world.

Without warning, I pounced, jumping on the bed and slowly crawling over to her.

“Atlas,” she moaned as my lips crashed into hers, my muzzle and her face colliding as intimately as they could.

Tegan’s hands explored my body as her tongue explored my mouth. Her delicate fingers traced over the hard planes of my muscular chest before circling around the pointed tips of my nipples.

“That tickles,” I chuckled against her soft lips.

“Take your clothes off,” she asked, her chest heaving with heavy breaths.

“Oh yeah, you wanna get me naked, Ms. Rollins?” I growled as I trailed a pointed claw down her neck to the valley between her breasts.

I wanted to draw constellations with the freckles dotting her chest. Memorize their locations and kiss every single one.

“Yes. Please.” She asked so nicely, I had to comply.

“Anything for you, baby.” I gave her a quick peck on the lips before hopping off the bed. There was no way I was going to awkwardly shimmy out of these pants up there with her. If she wanted a show, she’d get one.

I didn’t spend all those years on a stage flexing for nothing.

The lights dimmed when I tapped a button on my phone, and Tegan propped herself up with pillows, watching each of my movements intently.

I shrugged off my shirt before fumbling with my pants. They unbuttoned without any issues, but I struggled to work them down over my thighs.

Shit, they were tight.

I hopped on one foot and tried to pull from the bottom of the leg, but it was no use. I threw my body onto the ground and lifted my hips, rolling the pants down over my ass, then my thighs and calves.

The whole time Tegan laughed wildly, her enjoyment of the entire situation overriding any embarrassment I felt.

I was just happy I could make her smile. Even if it was at my expense.

When I was finally down to my boxer briefs, I stood at the foot of the bed and looked up at Tegan. She stopped laughing and dug her teeth into

her full lower lip.

“Fuck, you’re hot,” she said, her voice barely a whisper.

I rubbed my neck and smiled, sure that if my cheeks weren’t covered in fur, I’d be blushing.

“You are, too.” I got back up on the bed and slowly began to climb over top of her, taking my time to kiss whatever I could on my way up.

Stopping at her waist, I looked at her perfect body and debated all the wicked things I wanted to do to this woman.

One of my hands found its way to her pussy and rubbed her through the material of the dress. She groaned and arched her hips to meet my palm.

“Is this what you want,” I growled. “Me touching this pretty little pussy?”

“Gods, yes. Please, Atlas.” She sounded so desperate to have me. For the first time in a long time, I felt genuinely sexy. Genuinely wanted. No, not just wanted, *needed*.

I spread her legs to accommodate my large body and slowly hiked up her dress, marveling at the way her smooth skin pebbled under my touch. My heart beat rapidly as her panties came into view, the delicate piece of pink lace just barely covering her pussy.

“Fuck, Tegan,” I said. “You smell so fucking good.”

My snout pressed tight against her cunt, my nostrils flaring wildly to inhale as much of her as I could. I had to fight the urge to rub my face against her pussy. I wanted to mark myself with her scent.

She brought me back to reality. “Atlas, please touch me. Taste me. Something.”

My girl needed me and I felt a primal sense of satisfaction over that. I’d always provide for her. But I wasn’t in a rush. I planned to take my time with her. Draw this out as much as I could. Wring every ounce of pleasure out of her until she had nothing left to give.

Sticking out my tongue, I flattened it along the lace of her panties, licking her up and down, dragging the rough material over her cunt. I could taste her through the holes in the lace, her sweet musky flavor making me hum.

“Please,” she begged. “I need more.”

With shaky hands, I curled the tips of my claws under the waistband of her panties and pulled them over the expanse of her thick thighs. Silvery stretch marks streaked across her hips, and I kissed and nuzzled them gently as I slid her panties down to her ankles so she could kick them off.

“Fuck,” I moaned, admiring the perfectly manicured landing strip that led straight to her pussy. She was glistening, wet and slick from her arousal mixed with my spit.

My hands wrapped around the backs of her thighs, forcing her legs wider as I brought my muzzle closer to her cunt. Her breath hitched as my tongue grazed her folds before circling around her clit.

“Shit, Atlas,” Tegan said, thrusting her hips forward, pushing her delicious pussy against my face.

“Mmm,” I groaned, taking another slow lick. “So tasty. So sweet.”

I dragged my tongue against her clit repeatedly, working her up with each slow pass over the sensitive bud. I wanted to savor this. To eat Tegan like I was a starving wolf and she was my last meal.

Her body writhed beneath me, and little moans, along with my name, tumbled out of her mouth. I increased the pressure, rubbing the textured surface of my tongue roughly against her clit. Tegan’s thighs quivered and the wetness from her pussy coated my face. With her scent covering me, I was in heaven.

“Yes, Atlas,” she moaned from the mountain of pillows at the top of the bed.

“That’s right, baby. Come for me,” I growled against her pussy before flicking the tip of my tongue against her clit. My eyes focused on her face, and with her full lips parted in a moan of pleasure, she came undone against my tongue.

My tail wagged the entire time.

Twenty-Five



TEGAN

I LAY THERE FOR A minute, unable to move or even think straight as Atlas joined me at the head of the bed. I'm pretty sure he had just given me an out-of-body experience. He'd charmed my pussy like no one else had ever done before.

Atlas wiped his face on his arm before placing a few gentle kisses along my shoulder. "You okay, baby?" he asked quietly, the gravelly bass in his voice sending shivers down my body.

"I'm more than okay." I sighed dreamily and ran my fingers through the slightly damp fur of his cheeks before pulling his face to mine.

My tongue slipped inside his mouth without hesitation. I had no problem making out with him and tasting myself on his lips. The hard length of his cock pressed against my leg, and he groaned as I pushed my body tight to his.

"Do you want to fuck? Maybe play with the icing?" I suggested as Atlas nipped at my neck playfully.

"Fuck yes. I've been fantasizing about licking icing off your naked body since the moment we met." He rolled his hips into my thigh, forcing a moan out of me before helping me into a sitting position.

"Can you just get my zipper started for me?" I asked shyly as I swept my hair to the front of my chest.

“Sure thing, baby,” he said with a lazy smile. I didn’t think I’d ever get tired of hearing him call me that.

With expert precision, Atlas pinched the zipper between his claws. He slowly lowered it to the middle of my back before kissing along my spine, the soft fur of his muzzle tickling my bare skin.

I stepped off the bed and watched as Atlas propped himself against the headboard, his yellow eyes watching my every move.

One hand slipped behind my back, and I slowly lowered the zipper the rest of the way, holding the dress up against my chest with my free hand. Atlas’s tongue darted out to lick his lips as he palmed the stiff length of his cock through his briefs. I was reminded again of how large he was. How his cock had stretched my mouth and tested the limits of my gag reflex. And his knot. Oh goddess, that round, thick knot. Just the thought of it going inside of me made my pussy throb.

“Show me,” Atlas growled, and slid his boxer briefs down his thighs. His cock sprang free and slapped against his abs, the tip already a glistening ruby red.

“Yes, sir.” My voice was heavy with lust as I dropped my arm and wiggled my hips, exposing my pink lace bra.

“Goddess,” he groaned, giving his cock a slow pump.

And to be honest, I felt like one. Being the center of this sexy wolverine’s attention felt amazing. Almost as amazing as that orgasm. *Almost.*

I dropped my dress, and a deep, rumbling sound resonated out of Atlas’s chest.

Was that a purr?

He was purring at the sight of me.

His eyes widened and he placed a hand over his chest while he stroked himself with the other. “Well, that’s never happened.”

“I’ll take it as a compliment, then,” I said as I unhooked my bra. My breasts bounced free, the cool air of the bedroom pebbling my nipples.

“Fuck,” he grunted, thrusting his cock into his hand.

A bead of precum dripped from the red tip of his head, and all I could think about was how good it would taste.

I joined him on the bed and grabbed a bag of chocolate icing before straddling his legs.

“I want to taste you first,” I told him as I took his cock in my free hand, giving his knot a squeeze.

“Shit, yes,” he hissed, arching into my touch. I loved how sensitive his knot was. “You can do whatever you want, sweet thing.”

I circled his knot with the piping bag, coating it with a thick layer of icing. It would be a nice reward for me when my mouth reached it.

Lowering my lips down to his cock, I stuck out my tongue and swirled it around his head, the sweet flavor of his precum blooming along my tastebuds.

“Yes,” he moaned as I slowly worked him deeper, my mouth and my gag reflex pushed to their limits as I bobbed closer to his knot.

I hummed when the taste of the icing filled my mouth and Atlas’s cock tickled the back of my throat. The mixture of his precum and the icing was intoxicating. Using my free hand, I cupped his tight balls, gently massaging them.

“Tegan, fuck,” he groaned. “You’re gonna make me come if you keep working me over like this.” I moved up his length then back down, caressing his knot with my lips, and he sucked in a tight breath. “And I’d rather come inside of you,” he murmured.

I pulled off his cock and licked the icing from my lips. “You—want to come inside of me?”

He gave me a shy smile. “I mean, I’d like to, yeah.”

“I have an IUD and I tested negative for any STIs during my last physical,” I said, laying it all out on the table.

“I wasn’t worried about that. Wolven are immune to STIs and most illnesses. But I’m not sure if regular birth control pills would work if I came inside of you.” He scrubbed a hand over his ear. “From what I read, an IUD is the best way to prevent pregnancy.”

I hadn’t considered any of those things, but apparently Atlas had enough forethought to research it. He was responsible, and it made him that much hotter.

I thanked the goddess that I'd opted for an IUD instead of birth control pills because the thought of him filling me with his cum turned me the fuck on.

"Fuck, okay," I said, and licked around his knot until it was free from any icing. One thing was for sure, I didn't want a UTI in addition to whatever else his cock was going to inflict on my pussy.

"Lie down," he instructed with a bossy edge to his voice.

Atlas rose to his knees, and I lay on my back next to him, anxious for him to touch my body.

"So perfect. So mine," he whispered gruffly.

He took the piping bag in his hands, dotting my nipples with fluffy rosettes of icing before drawing a line over the swell of my stomach and down to just above my pussy.

"The most delicious treat," he growled, and circled his tongue around my nipple, making me moan and clutch the fur at the back of his head.

Atlas took my nipple in his mouth, licking and sucking it, letting his teeth graze my skin.

It felt good, so fucking good, but I wanted more. Wanted his teeth digging into me.

"Atlas," I moaned. "Bite me. P-please."

He looked up at me with his bright twin-moon eyes, flashing me a feral grin. It was like my request had unlocked some primal part of him.

With a snarl, he sank his teeth into me, giving my nipple a rough tug that I was sure would leave a bruise. I let out a yelp, only to be silenced when his fingers found my already-sensitive clit, rubbing it in a single tight circle that tipped me over the edge.

Blinding pleasure tore through me, an intense orgasm that made my thighs quake and my breath stutter in my chest. And when I could finally breathe again, I cried out Atlas's name, gripping tight fistfuls of his fur as I rode out my orgasm.

The pleasure. The pain.

He was everything I'd wanted but had never been able to find.

As I trembled beneath him, Atlas licked my other nipple clean before dragging his tongue along the line of icing down my stomach.

“Such a good girl, coming for me like that,” he praised. “Such a little slut for my sharp teeth.”

A moan slipped past my parted lips at his dirty words. The mouth on this wolverine.

“You like that, don’t you?” he asked, his words a soft caress against my skin. “You like when I talk about what a needy girl you are?”

“Mhm,” I mumbled, struggling to pull the words from my orgasm-clouded brain. “It’s hot.”

The corner of his muzzle curled up in a wolfish smile before he grazed his teeth against the soft skin of my inner thigh. I thrust my hips upward, toward his face, and he chuckled.

“Easy, baby.” Another deep laugh rumbled out of him. “I’ll give you what you need.”

Atlas got on his knees, carefully maneuvering himself between my legs. I watched in awe as he stroked the impressive length of his cock, the knot already thick and swollen, the red tip glistening with precum once again.

How in the hell was that thing going to fit inside me?

I was wet and slick, primed and ready, but it was going to be a *stretch*.

Atlas teased my pussy with the head of his cock. “We’re gonna take it slow, okay?”

I nodded. “Okay.”

“Tell me if you need me to stop.”

Another nod.

“Fuck, you’re so wet,” he said, running his cock up and down a few more times before notching himself at my entrance. “You ready, sweet thing? Gonna fuck you with this monster cock now.”

“Ready.” I took a deep breath, trying to force some of the tension out of my body.

On my exhale, Atlas started to gently ease inside. “Fuck,” he hissed, “you are so tight.”

Uh, yeah. And if anyone was aware of that, it was me.

The burning sensation was so intense, I felt like I was being split in two, but I wanted this, so I closed my eyes and bit my lip, my fists white-knuckling the sheets as I stretched around him.

Atlas paused and I felt the warm puffs of his breath on my face.

“Tegan. Look at me, baby,” he instructed gruffly.

My eyes flicked open, and I gazed into Atlas’s golden irises.

“We can stop,” he said as he stroked my jawline with his thumb. Concern and indecision were written all over his face. It was clear he wanted me but didn’t want to hurt me.

“N—no.” I gulped down a breath. “No. I want this. I—I just need a second.”

Atlas leaned closer, nuzzling the cool tip of his nose into my neck. “Take all the time you need. I could stay like this forever.”

He kissed my neck and traced his claw around my nipple, the skin of my breast pebbling with his touch. It was a welcome distraction, and the white-hot pain I felt faded to a dull throb.

“I think I’m okay now.” I grabbed Atlas’s hips, encouraging him to keep going.

“That’s it,” he growled in my ear as he filled me with his cock. “Open up for me.”

“Atlas,” I moaned.

He pushed deeper until his knot grazed my entrance, teasing my clit with each of his light thrusts.

“More.” My words were a plea as my hands drifted over Atlas’s muscular thighs and settled on the furry globes of his ass. I gripped tightly and he increased his pace, forcing himself deep with each rough snap of his hips.

“Tegan,” he grunted. “So tight. So perfect for me.”

“You feel so good,” I breathed, moving my hips to match his pace.

“So do you.”

He started to pound into me then, and the friction of his knot on my clit had me climbing toward an orgasm at an alarming rate, especially considering he’d already gotten me off twice.

I wondered what it would feel like to have his knot inside of me and that delicious friction right against my G-spot.

Fuck.

“C’mere,” Atlas grunted, and grabbed my thighs before rising onto his knees with his cock still buried deep inside of me. I wrapped my legs around his waist and moaned as he picked up speed, this new angle hitting just right.

“Atlas—I’m gonna come,” I said, feeling the tension in my belly build.

“Be a good girl for me and come on my cock, Tegan. I’m so close. Come on my cock like a good little slut and I’ll fill you with my cum.” His voice was deeper than usual, with a predatory edge to it that I’d never heard from him before. Those twin moons narrowed into something sharper and more sinister as the pointed tips of his claws pierced my thighs ever so slightly.

I pinched the sensitive peaks of my nipples, screaming out, “Fuck, Atlas!”

“Yes, baby. Yes,” he rasped, low and thick.

He slammed his cock inside of me, stroking and teasing my clit with the rough pad of his thumb until he coaxed another intense orgasm out of me. My hips jolted, and he tightened his grip, pinning me in place.

He fucked me through it, until his cock throbbed inside of me, filling me with spurt after spurt of cum.

“Shit,” he groaned, trembling over me.

My chest heaved, my body trying to catch my breath and bring me back to reality after such a world-shattering orgasm.

Atlas gave me a lazy smile as he pulled out, and I could feel his cum trickling out of me. His hair was mussed from sex, and his golden eyes twinkled as his gaze raked over my flushed body. With a soft touch, he rubbed at the indents his nails had dug into my thighs before lightly kissing the marks.

In more ways than one, I was so incredibly fucked.

Twenty-Six



ATLAS

I WIPE THE SWEAT OFF my brow and watched with rapt attention as my cum dribbled out of Tegan's sweet cunt. It took everything in me not to drag a finger through it and push it back inside, but with the current state of my claws, there was no way they'd be going inside of her pussy anytime soon.

"Let me clean you up, baby," I said before clambering off the bed.

Her eyes were hooded—likely from repeated orgasms—and she didn't say anything. She simply bobbed her head in agreement.

I grabbed an empty cup from my nightstand and padded over to the bathroom. Tegan could probably use some water after our little marathon. As I filled up the cup, I thought about how sore she was going to be tomorrow. I should probably get her some pain relievers, too.

Fuck.

She'd felt so tight on my cock that I thought I was going to split her in two. There was no way that she'd be able to take my knot anytime soon.

That didn't matter to me, though.

For me, sex was something meaningful. I couldn't just have random hookups like Fallon did. No judgment, but I had to have a connection.

And I had that with Tegan.

I'd had that since the moment we met.

My body—specifically my freaking tail—had told me as much.

Speaking of my tail, the fucking thing wagged behind me as I snatched a washcloth from the linen closet and wet it under the tap.

I draped the damp cloth over my arm and popped two nonsteroidal anti-inflammatories into my hand before heading back to the bedroom with the water in my free hand.

“I come bearing gifts. Hold out your hand.” Tegan cupped her hand, and I dropped the medication into her palm. “Pain meds. I’m worried tonight was too much for you.”

“Thank you. You’re so sweet.” She smiled and took the cup of water, knocking back the pills and taking a long drink.

“I told you I’d take care of you.” I set the cup on her nightstand before climbing onto the bed. “Now spread those legs for me so I can clean you up.”

She complied and I slid between her thighs, using the damp washcloth to gently wipe away my cum as it leaked out of her. Her pussy looked red and slightly puffy.

Shit.

I hoped she wouldn’t hurt too bad tomorrow.

I’d feel like trash if she did.

“Thank you,” Tegan said as I rolled out of bed to put the washcloth in the hamper.

“It’s no problem,” I mumbled. I slid into bed beside her. “Come here.”

Tegan shimmied closer to me, and I wrapped an arm around her, pulling her tight against my chest.

“This is nice,” I said. “Actually, everything about tonight has been amazing.”

I kissed her head, taking a deep inhale of her hair. She smelled like flowers.

“It has been amazing, hasn’t it?” Her fingers absentmindedly played with my chest hair, and I felt her breathing slow. “Tell me more about yourself. I want to know more.”

“Like what?” I asked with a laugh.

“What happened with your ex? Why do you hate this house so much?”

Woof.

She was going right for the difficult questions.

I took a deep breath and watched Tegan's head rise and fall with my chest. I couldn't tell her that Jade and I were engaged, at least not yet, but I *could* tell her why I ended things.

"She just—we—we were too different. She was putting a lot of pressure on me and I—I just wasn't feeling it. It wasn't the commitment that scared me. It was her."

Tegan tilted her head to look up at me, obviously waiting for me to keep going.

"Have you ever been with someone where it just feels like you're going through the motions? You're in so deep that it feels hopeless. Like you're trapped and there's no way out?" I took a deep breath. "That's how I felt with her. And one day, I was just tired of it. I told her it was over and that she needed to leave. She made a huge scene. Talked shit about me to all her friends. It was a really low point in my life. I had never felt so alone."

"Atlas." She snuggled closer to me, the physical connection I had with her spurring me to continue.

"Fallon and Cyrus stuck by me the entire time. We hung out every day for months. I threw myself back into training, and that's about all I've been doing since." I gripped Tegan's hand. "And then I met you and my stupid fucking tail hasn't stopped wagging since."

Tegan giggled and propped herself up on her elbow, putting her face-to-face with me. "Well, I'm glad you chose what was best for you, Atlas Oberon. And I happen to like that stupid fucking tail of yours. Very much."

Gods, she was everything.

Here we were, lying in bed after having sex for the first time, and I was already unloading my emotional baggage on her. The exact opposite of what Fallon told me to do. But Tegan took it in stride, like she did with everything else.

I leaned forward and pressed the cold tip of my nose against hers. "A moment of discomfort is nothing compared to a lifetime of unhappiness. Knowing that it led me to you, I'd make that choice again and again."

Fuck.

I couldn't believe those words just came out of my mouth. She was going to think I was a total creep. I might as well have said that I was in love with her.

Truth be told, I think I was.

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Twenty-Seven



TEGAN

THE FULL MOON CRESTED THE night sky, bathing the field in bright white light. Tall grass swayed around me, the light breeze pebbling my bare skin. Off in the distance I could hear something—the faint rustling of footsteps—slowly moving closer.

My heart kick-started, beating so fast I could feel my pulse pounding in my ears. The rustling moved closer, making the hair on the back of my neck stand up. Fear overwhelmed me. My instincts took control, and I started to run.

My feet pounded against the earth and my lungs screamed, but whatever it was that was following me—hunting me—slowly closed in. It leapt out of the grass, the moonlight catching the silver fur spanning across its broad back.

Instead of slamming into the ground, I was gently lowered, wrapped in a strong pair of arms. A cool nose pressed against my neck, a purr resonating out of its chest and into mine—as if it was trying to soothe me. I inhaled deeply, fighting to catch my breath, only to be met by a familiar scent. Atlas’s familiar scent.

“Tegan,” he said, my name rumbling out of him like thunder.

I dug my hands into his fur, baring my neck to him.

Almost like I was asking for something.

He trailed his tongue over my skin, paying special attention to the place where my neck met my collarbone, before he sank his teeth into my neck, sending searing pain radiating through my body that—

BEEP.

BEEP.

BEEP.

I bolted upright and whipped my head from side to side. The dark room and unfamiliar surroundings made me feel disoriented.

“Tegan,” Atlas mumbled, his already-deep voice more gravelly from sleep. “It’s just my alarm. Do you feel up to going to the gym? We can swing by your house and grab your workout clothes.”

Shit.

That was right. I’d spent the night with Atlas.

I’d fucked Atlas Oberon and stayed over at his house.

Slept cuddled next to him in his bed.

I thought it was a dream.

But the slight discomfort I felt between my legs confirmed that it was, in fact, not a dream.

Atlas had wrecked me last night, wringing orgasm after orgasm from my body.

I’d never had a partner who was so attentive when it came to pleasuring me. Not to mention how thorough he was with aftercare.

“Would it be a big deal if we skipped the gym today?” I bit my lip and focused on Atlas as best I could in the dim lighting.

“Uh...” The indecision in his voice was obvious.

“Do you ever miss a day?” I asked. I tilted my face closer so I could gauge his reaction.

“I mean...I do. Sometimes...” He trailed off and scrubbed a hand over his ear. “I, um, I have some issues. When it comes to my body image and exercising. Just stuff left over from my childhood and from my ex.”

Anger flared up inside of me. I knew he had issues with his body image and anxiety surrounding his diet, but I didn’t know she’d played a part in it.

How the fuck dare she.

For a long time I struggled with my body, but I'd learned to love it. Every stretch mark and cellulite dimple.

I wanted that for Atlas, too.

"Hey," I said, and grabbed his hand. "It's okay. I used to have some of those issues, too, and I think I can help you work through them." I kissed the back of his hand, the soft fur tickling my nose and lips. "Let's go to the gym today, but if you'll let me, we can work on this together, okay?"

He smiled and nodded his head in agreement. "I'm just dropping all of my emotional baggage on you."

It was my turn to smile. "I'm here to help you carry it." I leaned in and kissed him. Just a peck, positive I was rocking some serious morning breath. "Come on. I have my workout clothes in my car."

"I'll get dressed and go grab them for you. Maybe on the way to the gym we can grab a coffee. How does that sound?"

Yeah, he did have some baggage. But didn't we all?

It didn't make me any less enamored with him.

Not only was he handsome as sin, but he was one of the sweetest people I'd ever met in my entire life.

"That sounds perfect."

"Great," he said, and rolled out of bed with a groan. He stretched his naked body, his muscles rippling with each of his movements while his massive cock hung limp between his legs.

How the fuck had that thing fit inside me?

I was tempted to lift up the blankets and check on my pussy, but I'd have time to do that later when Atlas wasn't watching. You know, just to make sure everything was still intact.

He turned his back to me and walked toward the closet, giving me a perfect view of his ass. And holy shit, was it perfect. I was correct in my earlier assessment that you could bounce a quarter off that thing.

Atlas returned to the side of the bed dressed in a pair of basketball shorts that hung low on his hips, with a white tank top draped over his shoulder.

I stared at the muscular build of his body and clenched my thighs together tightly. I couldn't possibly be getting turned on after the pounding I'd taken the night before. It should be illegal for one wolven to be so good at handing out orgasms.

"I'll be right back," he said as he bent over and placed a delicate kiss on my forehead.

"My keys are in my bag on the island," I said when he pulled away, his body swaying as his tail wagged happily behind him. A smile spread over my face. That fucking tail got me every time. "Thank you."

"Anything for you, sweet thing." Atlas pulled on his tank top before turning on his heel and walking out of the room. I stifled a whine at the thought of him having to wear actual clothing in my presence. He was sheer perfection, and I didn't think I'd ever get tired of ogling him.

As I hoisted myself to my feet and headed toward the bathroom, I was reminded of our conversation last night. I hated the fact that the opinions of one stupid ex could do so much damage to such a sweet guy. Atlas was something special. He deserved to be cherished and valued for who he was, not for the wolven someone else wanted him to be. His flaws, his imperfections—those were the things that made him unique.

I'd just finished washing my hands when Atlas snuck up behind me in the bathroom, making me jump. I hadn't heard him coming.

"Atlas!" I gasped as I tried to catch my breath. "You scared the shit out of me." Super stealth must be a wolven talent or something.

He grabbed my hips, leaning over me until the fuzzy gray fur of his face tickled my ear. "I could look at your naked body all day long."

My cheeks flushed as I glanced at our reflections in the mirror. We were so different, but there was something about us that fit. Something that worked.

Atlas trailed a claw down my side, stopping at the pinprick indents left on my hip the night before. "Did I hurt you, Tegan?" His warm breath tickled my neck, and his voice lowered an octave. "Did you like it?"

I moaned and leaned into him, not caring that every roll and imperfection was bared in the mirror for him to see. "Y-yes. I—I liked it."

His dark chuckle sent shivers down my spine, and he tilted my head so that I was looking into his golden eyes. “Good.”

Atlas pressed his lips against mine and I opened for him, our tongues fluttering against each other, obviously unconcerned about morning breath.

“Shit,” he groaned as he pulled away. “The gym is looking less and less appealing by the minute.”

I laughed and reached for my workout clothes. “No way, buddy. You got me up and out of bed. We’re going to the gym. *And*,” I added, “I believe I was promised a coffee.”

But the fact that he’d even be tempted to skip the gym for me meant that he was open to change and undoing the damage his ex had done to him.

Sure, he could work out and focus on his diet. But it had to be on his terms. In a healthy way that wasn’t obsessive or overly restrictive. In a way that didn’t make him feel guilty.

We stood side by side at the double vanity and brushed our teeth. I caught Atlas sneaking glances at me every chance he got, his fluffy tail wagging from side to side.

We were so into each other that it was almost sickening. Yeah, it was soon. But sometimes fate intervenes in the form of ruined wedding cakes, and you just have to listen.

“The Busy Bean okay for coffee?” Atlas asked when we were loaded in his truck.

I grimaced slightly. “I mean, we can stop there, but expect Brian to mean mug the fuck out of you.”

He chuckled. “Why is that?”

“After the wedding, he stopped by the bakery and asked me if we were dating, and we weren’t yet so I told him no. He took that as an opportunity to ask me to go out with him sometime, and because I was interested in you, I told him I was too busy with the bakery to date.”

“Damn. He’s going to spit in my coffee, isn’t he? I didn’t know you were the most eligible bachelorette in Briar Glenn.”

“I absolutely am not. And even if I was, it doesn’t matter now because I’m with you.”

Atlas pulled into one of the parking spots in front of the Busy Bean. We hopped out of the truck, and when I opened the door to the coffee shop, Brian's head snapped up.

"Hey, Tegan. What are you—" Brian started, but his voice tapered off the second Atlas stepped inside behind me. "Oh," he said, staring at Atlas and me.

"Morning, Brian," Atlas said. He grabbed my hand, twining our fingers together. "I promised Tegan a coffee before we started our workout this morning. She needed a little energy boost. Didn't you?"

I could feel the heat rushing from my chest up to my cheeks, because he did not just say that to Brian. "Yep," I croaked, giving his hand a very aggressive squeeze, which probably didn't bother him because he was a hulking wolverine.

"Uh, cool," Brian said flatly. "The usual for you, Tegan?"

I nodded. "Please."

"And I'll have a double americano. Iced, please," Atlas added.

Brian aggressively tapped on the tablet in front of him, flipping it around to face us when he had the total.

I went to grab my card from my phone case, but Atlas beat me to it, adding a *very* generous tip before tapping his card on the reader.

Was he trying to add insult to injury?

We shuffled to the end of the counter and grabbed our drinks when they were ready.

I chose a table that was as far away from the counter as we could get. "You should have just peed on me in front of him," I huffed. "Really marked your territory, ya know."

Atlas sat across from me. "I mean, if that's what you're into, I'll try anything once—" He shrugged.

I almost choked on my coffee. "Atlas."

He started laughing his head off, and out of the corner of my eye I could see Brian staring daggers at him. I hoped Atlas wasn't a big fan of coffee, because he was definitely making an enemy here.

“I’m sorry. I just couldn’t help myself,” he said when he finally regained his composure. “Listen,” he said, his expression turning serious. “There’s something I wanted to talk to you about.”

“I hope you’re not breaking up with me in a public place right after we had sex for the first time,” I joked, trying to ease the knot forming in my stomach. Usually when someone said they needed to talk to you like that, it wasn’t about something good.

He shook his head aggressively, holding out his hands. “Oh my gods, no. It’s nothing like that. It’s just—woven things.”

“What kind of woven things?” I asked.

“Do you remember what the moon looked like the night of the wedding?”

“It was some type of crescent, I think? I can’t remember which. It’s been a long time since I took earth science, so you’ll have to cut me some slack.”

“It was a waning crescent, and now it’s almost time for a full moon.”

“Ahhh,” I drawled.

“We won’t be able to hang out that night.”

“Why?”

“Woven are different under the full moon. It’s just—I don’t know if I can trust some of my baser instincts around you, Tegan. Do you get where I’m going with this?”

“Baser instincts?”

“I don’t think I would ever hurt you, but I don’t want to do anything that makes you scared or uncomfortable.”

“Does that mean we’ll never be able to be together when there’s a full moon?” I asked. I mean, it was one night a month. But I still didn’t quite understand.

“It’s an important part of my life, and I’d like to include you in it sometime. If I can do it safely.”

“What do you do?”

“Run through the woods. Howl at the moon. Have sex.”

Well, that piqued my interest. I leaned over the table and whispered, “Like outside?”

He nodded. “Yeah.”

“Honestly, that sounds like an amazing time.”

Atlas gave me a soft smile—like my response was a huge weight off his shoulders. “It is. And one day, when we’re ready, I want to do it with you.”

My dream came to mind. It was almost eerie how my subconscious had conjured up that exact scenario.

“I’d like that. I really appreciate you talking to me about this.”

“Well, I wasn’t just going to go radio silent without explaining things first. For obvious reasons, I leave my phone at home when I go out.”

“If I was a wolverine, you wouldn’t have to worry about any of this, would you?”

His ears dropped, giving me my answer.

“It’s okay,” I blurted. “I get it.”

As common as mixed-species relationships were, there was still a learning curve. This was a first for Atlas and me, but I was glad we were having an open conversation about it instead of shoving it under the rug. He could have just made up some lie about being out with friends and I would have been none the wiser. I appreciated his honesty.

He reached across the table, holding both of my hands in his while his golden eyes stared into mine. “Thank you for understanding.”

“And it’s just one night, right?”

“One night,” he said, holding up a clawed finger. “Do you think you can live without me?”

“I’ll do my best.” As much as I enjoyed spending time with Atlas, I felt like I’d been neglecting my friends a little bit since I started my relationship with him. The full moon would be the perfect time to make plans with them.

“If you can’t, there’s always Brian,” Atlas teased.

“Don’t you dare joke like that.”

“What? He’s not a bad-looking guy.”

“He isn’t, but that’s not the problem,” I said, folding my arms over my chest.

Atlas grinned. “Then what *is* the problem?”

I answered honestly. “He isn’t you.”

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Twenty-Eight



TEGAN

THE DAYS LEADING UP TO the full moon seemed to fly by. Atlas kept me busy with early-morning workouts, and in the evenings, I'd go over to his place and we'd cook dinner together. Selene was doing a great job taking on more responsibilities at the bakery. I was so happy with how things were going that I might be able to take a vacation this summer and leave things in her capable hands. That was a big step for a control-freak workaholic like me.

Tonight, while Atlas had his monthly full moon run, I was having a movie night to catch up with my friends. Dec and Selene were snuggled on the couch, buried under throw blankets, and I was busy in the kitchen getting everything together. In preparation for movie night, I'd bought a ton of snacks and made a pitcher of alcoholic margaritas for the two of them to drink while I sipped on a nonalcoholic version.

"Thank you guys for coming over," I said, setting a big bowl of popcorn on the table.

"I was worried you forgot about me." Dec pouted.

I put my hands on my hips and stared him down. "I could never forget about you."

I'd been eating at the diner less, and I knew he missed me coming by. I made a mental note to carve more time for him out of my schedule.

"See how she is, Selene," Dec said. "She gets a boyfriend and completely abandons us."

Selene flicked a piece of popcorn at him. “Stop being jealous. I’m happy for Tegan. Atlas is a great guy.”

“You’re just happy you get to work more hours at the bakery,” he huffed, plucking the piece of popcorn off his blanket and popping it into his mouth.

“Oh, speaking of the bakery. I have something for you, Selene.” I hopped off the couch and went to the hall closet. I pulled out a gift bag and handed it to Selene. To thank her for all of her help and encouragement, I’d gotten her a little gift.

She reached inside the bag, pulling out a brand-new apron I’d had embroidered with her name. Even if she didn’t continue working with me at the bakery, she could still use it at home.

“Tegan!” Selene said, holding the apron out in front of her. “I love it.”

“That is so cute,” Dec said. I was shocked he didn’t ask me where his gift was, but I was thankful he was letting Selene have her moment. She deserved it.

“It even has my name on it,” she said, running her fingers over the embroidery. “Thank you so much.”

“I just wanted to show you how much I appreciate your help with the bakery. It’s been nice to step back a little bit.”

“It’s no problem,” she said. “You know how much I love it there.”

“I don’t know what I’m going to do when you go back to school in the fall.” Her body went rigid. “You are going back, aren’t you?” I asked.

“Oof, Tegs. This is a sensitive subject,” Dec said. He raised his brows and took a sip of his margarita.

Selene groaned. “I don’t know what I’m going to do.”

“I mean, fall semester is pretty far away,” I said. “You’ve got time.”

“I get the impression that Mama and Papa Jimenez wouldn’t be too keen on the idea of their future engineer dropping out of college,” Dec said.

Selene’s parents were accomplished. Her mother was a pediatrician, and her father was a veterinarian. They had high expectations for their children, and they’d already expressed disappointment in her brother’s degree in

forestry. Their daughter dropping out of engineering school to work in a bakery would be another devastating blow. But this was Selene's life.

I shot Dec a look. "I think you should do whatever makes you happy. There's always the pastry school in Rock Harbor," I suggested.

"Yeah, you're right," Selene said, sounding more upbeat. "Maybe I'll go check it out."

I hoped that she would. I'd even go with her to show her around campus.

"All right, that's enough heavy talk for today," Dec said, reading the room. "When are we going to talk about you and Atlas?"

I grinned, just like I did every time I thought about Atlas. "Everything is going great."

It really was. We'd just started dating, but everything between us felt so easy. So natural.

"Have you met his friends yet?" Selene asked.

"I've met one in passing. He works at the gym as a personal trainer," I said. "They want me to come over for game night."

"Oh, you love board games. That's perfect," Selene said.

I laughed and shook my head. "Not board games. *Video games*."

"Maybe they'll play *Mario Kart*." Dec grinned into his glass.

If that was the case, Atlas's friends were going to be in for a real surprise.

"If he's inviting you to something like that, it's a good sign," Selene said. "It means he's serious."

"I'd say things were already pretty serious if he agreed to meet us at the diner right after their first official date," Dec said.

"They also became official after their first date," Selene added.

"Do you think that was weird?" I asked. I couldn't even remember when I introduced my ex to my friends, or when we made things exclusive, but it definitely wasn't right after our first date.

"Tegan, I hate to break it to you, babe, but you aren't in your twenties anymore, and neither is he," Dec said. "We're getting to that age where you

take things seriously if you want to find someone. There's no point in wasting time with someone if you don't see them as forever material."

"Agreed," Selene said.

Forever material was what I wanted, and even with Atlas's recent breakup, I felt like that was what he wanted, too.

"But you know, we can't talk about forever if we don't talk about how he is in bed. Is it good?" Dec asked, wiggling his eyebrows.

He was ridiculous.

"It's good," I admitted. "Like, really good."

Dec slapped his knee, nearly spilling his margarita all over my couch.

"I knew it! He looks like he can fuck. Those slightly awkward hot guys who don't know they're hot are always the best in bed."

I snorted. He wasn't wrong.

"I'm super curious about the whole knotting thing," Selene said.

"Me, too."

I'd been curious since the moment I saw it, and having sex with Atlas had intensified my curiosity.

"You're just going to have to work up to it," Dec said nonchalantly.

Selene and I snapped our focus onto him.

"Excuse me," I said. "Do you have experience with knotting and you've been holding out on us?"

He shrugged, casually adding, "Not with a wolverine."

My mouth hung open. "And I thought I knew everything about you."

"I don't kiss and tell," he said, tipping his nose up.

I laughed, almost spitting out my drink. "You most definitely kiss and tell."

"Seriously, though," he said. "Just let Atlas work his magic and you'll get there."

Yeah, Dec and I were talking about knotting in two very different places, but with lube and the right prep, I wanted to think anything was possible.

"As much as I'm enjoying talking about the stretching abilities of the human body, are we going to watch this movie or not?" Selene asked. "I

had a long day and I'm just barely hanging in here."

"Yes," I said. "Let me top off everyone's drinks before we get started."

They held out their glasses and I grabbed them on my way to the kitchen.

Warm orange light streamed through the window behind the kitchen sink, drawing my attention. I set the glasses on the counter and stared outside, watching the sun sink behind the forest. As soon as the moon appeared in the sky, Atlas would be out there somewhere, running through the woods and doing whatever it was that wolverines did during the full moon.

I understood his reasons, but I wanted to experience the other side of him. Wild and unrestrained, like how he was in my dream.

A thrill ran through me at the thought.

"Tegan," Dec shouted. "The drinks? We're about to lose Selene over here."

"Coming," I said, snapping out of it.

I took one last glance out the window before I filled their glasses and joined them in the living room. Someone, likely Dec, had already queued up the movie. A recently released rom-com that wasn't on streaming services yet, so I'd have to cough up \$5.99 to rent it.

"About time," Dec said when I passed them their drinks.

I replied by flipping him off, making him burst into a fit of laughter that seemed to momentarily rouse Selene.

She yawned, murmuring a sleepy "Thank you."

We really were losing her. If I had to guess, she'd be asleep in the next fifteen minutes.

"You're welcome. As in you, *Selene*. Not you," I said, giving Dec a look.

I plopped down on the couch, tugging my blanket onto my lap and making sure my phone was within reach—just in case I received a last-minute text from Atlas.

We started the movie, and while I was thankful for my friends and their company, there was no way I was going to be able to concentrate. Not with a certain wolverine running through the woods and through my mind.

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Twenty-Nine



ATLAS

"HI, MOM!" I SAID, STARING into the tiny phone screen. Every evening on the night of the full moon, I had a video call with my parents just to catch up on what had been going on in our lives. Sometimes my brothers joined us, but tonight they had plans with some other wolven in the city. A sort of makeshift pack that they'd run with. As the only wolven in Briar Glenn, I longed for something like that.

"Hi, honey!" My mom waved back. My dad wasn't in frame; all I could see was the flannel shirt covering his broad chest.

"Down here, Zeus," she said, giving Dad's arm a tug, pulling him down to where I could see him.

Both of my parents were starting to show their age. Their dark gray fur was streaked with tiny threads of silver, and their eyes were starting to look less vibrant. My brothers and I had been trying for years to convince them to retire and sell off the hardware store, but they showed no signs of slowing down. As much as I loved the hardware store, I wanted to take a different path in life. It was never expected that one of us would take over the family business. Our parents had always encouraged us to follow our passions, and I was thankful for that because it had landed me here in Briar Glenn. It had brought me to Tegan.

"Happy full moon, son," Dad said, his voice gravelly and deep.

"Happy full moon to you, too, Dad."

“Running by yourself again, sweetie?” my mom asked, a hint of sadness—or was it sympathy?—in her voice.

“Yep.”

“You know, you can always come visit and run with your father and me,” she suggested. “We can get your brothers to join. It’ll be just like it was when you were pups.”

“I might come visit soon. I’m just really busy with work—” I paused for a second, wondering if I should mention Tegan. I know they didn’t have any animosity about my breakup with Jade—they were my parents, after all—but it was sort of fast, I guessed. Ultimately, I decided to tell them. “And I, uh, I started seeing someone.”

“You’re seeing someone?” Mom gasped. Her eyes lit up, her excitement making me smile. “Since when?”

“It’s pretty new,” I said shyly.

“Why don’t you have her run with you?” she asked.

“Well—” I hesitated. Mixed-species relationships were common, and there was never any expectation that I would settle down with another wolven...

My dad understood immediately. “She’s human.”

I nodded.

“What’s she like?” Mom asked, leaning in. “Is she cute?”

My dad gave her a playful nudge, pushing his way back onto the screen. “Of course she’s cute, Alice. Look at him. He’s a handsome kid.”

I didn’t even correct my dad, because to him, I would always be a kid.

“She’s really cute. Beautiful, actually.” The most gorgeous woman I’d ever seen.

“You know, lots of wolven have human mates,” she said expectantly.

I winced at the word. There was no way that Tegan and I were mates.

“Uh, I think it’s a little too soon to tell, Mom.” Even though I had intense feelings for Tegan, I was just coming off a failed engagement. Mating was the last thing on my mind.

“When are you going to bring her to visit?” she asked.

“She owns a bakery in town so she’s pretty busy, but maybe we can come visit soon,” I said, just to pacify my mother. Tegan and I had just started dating. There was no way I was taking her to meet my parents yet.

“We would love that,” Dad said.

Mom gripped his arm, nodding aggressively. “We really would. I could set up the guest room, and your father could cook a nice dinner—”

I cut her off with a laugh. “I’m sure she would love that, Mom.”

She was getting ahead of herself, but I couldn’t remember her ever being excited about Jade visiting like that.

Was everyone trying to point me toward the red flags, but I’d been too complacent to notice them?

Mom peered around the tablet—I assumed out the window that sat behind the kitchen table. “Oh, the sun is starting to set, sweetie. We better get going.”

“Alice,” Dad said, “let me have a minute alone with Atlas, please.”

Mom gave him a questioning look. Some sort of fated mate “we’ve been married forever” understanding must have passed between them before she turned back to the screen and said, “I love you, Atlas. Have a good full moon and we’ll talk to you soon. Oh! And tell your girlfriend we said hello.”

“I will, Mom. Love you, too.”

She waved goodbye and slipped out of the room.

My dad turned around, making sure she was out of earshot before he launched into whatever it was he had to say. “I just wanted to tell you how proud of you we are. It takes a lot of guts to admit that something isn’t working out. Jade wasn’t right for you, and we know that. We’re not upset that you called off the engagement. As long as you’re happy, we’re happy.”

“Thanks, Dad.” I knew they weren’t disappointed I didn’t follow through with the engagement, but hearing it put me at ease.

“Enjoy yourself tonight, son.”

“You, too.”

Before I hung up, I heard my dad yell for my mother.

“Alice—how the hell do I shut this thing off?”

I chuckled, hitting the button to end the call.

It had been a while since I'd last been home, but every time I talked to my parents, I was reminded of how happy they were together. To me, they were the gold standard for a healthy relationship, and when Jade and I first started dating, I'd hoped to grow into something like that. Even when things felt wrong or uncomfortable, I forced myself to stay. Convinced myself that she was what I wanted—what I deserved. In reality, we couldn't have been more wrong for each other.

Being with Tegan was opening my eyes to what a healthy relationship could be. There was an undeniable sexual chemistry between us, but more than that, there was communication and respect.

My past made me realize just how lucky I was in the present.

How lucky I was to have Tegan in my life.

I decided to send her a text before I headed out for the night.

Atlas: Just wanted to send you a quick text
before I head out 🦊🌕🏃

She was typing, those three tiny bubbles bouncing in the text box until her message came through.

Tegan: Have fun tonight! 😊🦊

A picture came through next, of her, Declan, and Selene, smushed together and smiling for a selfie. It was cute.

Atlas: It looks like you're having a great time. I
really like your friends.

The three of them reminded me a lot of Cyrus, Fallon, and me. I wanted to introduce them to one another soon.

Tegan: Good. Because they like you too.

That was a huge win. If I learned anything from my relationship with Jade, it was the fact that your friends' approval of your partner was important. I could have saved myself a lot of misery had I just listened to Fallon back in college. *Never thought I'd say that.*

Atlas: I'll text you tomorrow morning. Night baby. 🐼

Tegan: Goodnight! 🐼

I set my phone on the kitchen counter and tugged my shirt over my head, leaving me in a loose pair of basketball shorts. I would have preferred to run in the nude, but within the town limits, I felt obligated to keep up some sense of modesty.

The bluish-gray haze of dusk settled in, and I darted out the back door, bolting toward the woods at the edge of the development. My feet pounded against the ground, two at first, then all four carrying me over sticks, rocks, and fallen leaves. The scent of moss and decay wafted up my nostrils, but there was a lingering aroma that pulled me in. Sugary sweet with notes of violets and vanilla.

Tegan.

I broke through the trees, into the overgrown open field I frequented each full moon. The moon was already making its ascent, bathing everything in bright light. I stretched, feeling that familiar tightness in my skin, a restlessness deep in my bones.

"Fuck," I growled, craning my neck.

The call of the moon was becoming unbearable, pulling the primal parts of me to the surface. I threw back my head in surrender, letting out a long howl from deep inside my chest that echoed up toward the night sky.

Could Tegan hear me?

I hoped she was warm and safe inside her house.

I felt compelled to check for myself.

My tongue lolled out of my mouth, dribbling drool over the forest floor as I closed in on her cottage.

I watched from a distance, staying hidden in the woods. A warm glow filtered through one of the windows and a soft silhouette passed in front of it.

She was home and she was safe.

This was as far as I could go.

I looked from her house back toward the trail that led to the field, an indecisive whimper working its way out of my throat.

For now, this was close enough.

—

AS USUAL, I WOKE UP alone in the field. I rolled onto my back, staring up at the sun as swaths of soft grass swayed around me. The sun was so bright I had to shield my sensitive eyes. My body ached like I'd been hit by a freight train.

Last night I'd felt restless. Running back and forth between the field and Tegan's house. When the moon faded and the predawn haze lit up the horizon, I finally collapsed from exhaustion. No matter how hard I tried to stop myself, my instincts kept pulling me back to her over and over again.

"What the fuck was that about?" I murmured as I hauled my ass back to my house.

Undoubtedly, Tegan's evening was better than mine.

Do I tell her about what happened last night, or do I keep that to myself? Not wanting to scare her, I decided to keep it to myself.

There was never a point where I felt like she was in danger. No threat of me breaking through her window and rutting her to death. Just an overwhelming sense of concern, a need to be near her.

In all the years and all the full moons I'd spent with Jade, I'd never felt anything remotely close to that about her. If anything, I was more likely to

run *from* her rather than *with* her.

Interesting.

I grabbed my phone from where I'd left it on the counter, typing a message out to Tegan while I climbed the stairs.

Atlas: Good morning, beautiful. How did you sleep?

Tegan: I slept like a baby. How was the full moon?

I laughed, because of course she did.

Atlas: Exhausting.

I strolled into the bathroom and shucked off my shorts, laughing when I caught a glimpse of myself in the mirror. My fur was an absolute mess, caked with mud, sticks, and leaves. I was the wolven equivalent of a bird's nest. Tegan would probably find it funny.

I stepped closer to the vanity, making sure my dick was covered by the counter before I snapped a picture.

A video call came in a second later.

"Oh my gods." She laughed. "What happened to you?"

She was still in bed, propped against her headboard with a very floppy messy bun.

I laughed, plucking a stray bramble out of my fur. "I'd say this is pretty standard post full moon."

She squinted her green eyes, moving closer to the phone. "Are you naked?"

"Yeah, I was about to take a shower."

"Can I watch?" she asked, her voice breathy.

I paused, acting like I was thinking about it, because of fucking course she could watch. “I guess so,” I said, teasing.

She bit her lip, eyes lighting up. If I had known she was into something like this, I would have initiated it sooner. At least sent her a few dirty texts or something.

I moved around the bathroom, turning on all the lights and making sure the phone was angled toward the shower, hoping like hell it was the perfect view.

“That look good?” I asked, slowly backing away.

Tegan’s eyes were glued to the screen. “Yep.”

I turned away from my phone, clenching my ass as I walked to the shower, really showing off my glutes. For the first time since the remodel, I was thankful Jade had pressured me into getting an open shower. There wasn’t any glass to fog up, giving Tegan a clear view of me in the shower.

“Can you see me?” I asked, turning on the water.

“Yeah. I can see you,” she said. Good, it meant she could hear me, too.

I stepped under the showerhead, letting the warm water cascade over my body. Angling myself toward Tegan, I ran my hands through the fur on the back of my head, flexing my muscles for her.

“You are so sexy,” she said, her voice tight.

“Am I?” I reached down and gripped my cock, giving it a slow stroke just for her.

“Yes.” I could just barely make out her heavy breathing over the spray of the shower. “Do you know how many times I fantasized about you?”

“Tell me about them.” Another slow jerk of my cock. “Your fantasies about me.”

She hummed. “Let’s see. The day you helped me with the cake, I masturbated to the picture of you from your website.”

I let out a shocked laugh. I wasn’t expecting that.

“The headshot?” I asked.

“No—the competition pic.” She was quiet for a second. Lowering her voice, she said, “I made myself squirt thinking about all the things you’d do to me.”

“Fuck. That’s hot,” I said, even though I was slightly disappointed I hadn’t made her squirt—*yet*.

“Yeah?”

“Mhm,” I hummed. “What else?” I was pretty confident this wasn’t a onetime thing...

“Another time—” She let out a shuddering breath that was like music to my ears. I couldn’t see her, but she was obviously touching herself. “I rubbed my body with my bath pouf, wishing it was you rubbing your face between my legs.”

“Is that all you did?” I asked.

“Then,” she gasped, “then I fucked myself with my fingers, imagining all the ways you’d fuck me.”

I was really jerking off now, my balls feeling tight and my knot starting to swell. With each stroke, my fist bumped up against it, reminding me of how it felt to rub against Tegan’s cunt.

“Shit, Tegan. You’re gonna make me come.”

“Atlas,” she whined. “I want to see it.”

“You want to see me come, baby? Shoot my load on the shower wall just like I’d come all over your tits?”

“Fuck,” she rasped. “Please.”

I leaned on my forearm facing the wall, stroking my cock with a tight grip, imagining it was her cunt taking every inch of me. Tegan was panting now. With the echo from the tiled room, it felt like she was right here, moaning in my ear, telling me how bad she wanted me. How bad she wanted my cum.

Heat spread down my spine, tightening my balls, and I gripped my knot, really squeezing it just like her pussy would, until I came hard, shooting ropes of cum onto the tile, wishing it was her.

Tegan cried out and my hips jolted, working my knot through the last of my orgasm while she came undone over the phone.

When she finally quieted down, I let go of my cock, catching my breath before I rinsed off the wall.

“Doing okay over there?” I asked, glancing over at the phone.

“Barely,” Tegan said, her voice weak. I couldn’t see her, but I could picture her. Eyes all hooded, a postorgasm flush on her cheeks.

Beautiful.

“I miss you,” I told her honestly. I opened my body wash and lathered up, actually starting to shower now.

“I miss you, too.” It warmed my heart to know she felt the same.

“Do you want to get breakfast?” I asked, hoping she’d say yes.

I usually took the morning after the full moon off from the gym, and I couldn’t think of a better way to spend it than by eating something greasy at the diner with her.

“Absolutely,” she replied.

“Go get ready and I’ll be there in ten.”

“Okay.” I could hear the smile in her voice. “I’ll see you then.”

“I—” It almost slipped out. It was right there on the tip of my tongue, and it would have been so easy to say it because that’s how I felt. But I forced it down and said, “I’ll see you then.”

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Thirty



TEGAN

"AM I GOING TO LEARN all of your deepest, darkest secrets tonight?" I asked Atlas.

He grimaced, tightening his grip on the steering wheel. "Knowing Fallon, probably."

We were on our way to the highly anticipated game night with his friends. I'd already met Fallon, and I grew up with Kael, but Cyrus was who I was really looking forward to meeting.

Atlas pulled the truck into the parking lot of the Foundry. It was another product of the mayor's revitalization initiative, an old manufacturing facility that was converted into a swanky apartment building last year.

"I didn't know anyone actually lives here," I said, remembering the decrepit building of my childhood.

"I think it's Cyrus and Fallon and a few other big-city transplants." He paused for a second, obviously thinking before he asked, "Does it ever bother you that more people are moving to Briar Glenn?"

I shook my head. "Not at all. It's been good for business, and I love seeing new faces around town. In fact, there's one face I particularly enjoy."

He leaned over the center console, his lips twitching with a smile. "Oh, yeah?"

"Mhm," I said, reaching out to him.

I ran my fingers through the soft fur on his face, giving it a gentle tug to pull him closer to me. The cool tip of his nose touched mine and we angled our faces, pressing our lips together in a series of slow kisses that made my heart pound in my ears.

“Tegan.” He said my name in a growl that rattled right through me.

I pulled away to stare into his full-moon eyes, placing a soft kiss on his nose before letting him go.

“Ready?” I asked, flipping down the visor to check my makeup.

“Well, I was,” he grumbled, shifting in his seat. “But we have to wait a few seconds now.”

That got my attention.

I flipped the visor back up, my gaze traveling down his body to the tented area of his gym shorts. “You’re going to have to wait until later for that.”

“Is that a promise?” he asked, ears perking up.

I shrugged. “Maybe.”

Which was a code word for *definitely*.

While we were waiting for Atlas’s not-so-little problem to resolve itself, I peered out the window.

“It looks fancy,” I said, taking in the sleek black balconies enclosed with frosted glass and the sprawling sea of ivy creeping up the brick wall.

“Wait until you see the inside. It’s really nice.” Atlas shifted in his seat again. “All right, I think I’m good now.”

Before I even had my seat belt unbuckled, he was out of the truck and opening the passenger door, holding a massive hand out to me.

“You don’t need to keep doing this,” I said, grabbing hold of his hand, hopping out of the truck. “I’m perfectly capable of getting out myself.”

“I know you are, but I *want* to do this for you.” Still holding my hand, he tugged me to him, making my breath hitch. “So let me do it,” he whispered.

“Okay.” It came out soft and compliant, because that’s what I wanted, wasn’t it? Someone to take control. To do things for me without having to ask.

That was what I had with Atlas.

Staring down at me, he threaded his fingers through mine, bringing our joined hands to his lips.

Atlas gave me one last smile before leading me toward the entrance of the apartment building. He pressed a button on the intercom labeled RIDGEWING/JENNINGS.

There was a beat of static before a high-pitched whistle sounded from the speaker.

“Who is this absolute cutie standing on my doorstep?” Fallon said.

Assuming he meant me, I looked up at the tiny camera next to the doorframe, giving it a friendly wave. “Hi, Fallon. How are you?”

“Better now,” he chirped. I laughed, imagining he was winking one of his beady bird eyes when he said it. He was over-the-top, corny, and bro-ish, but he was cute in a way. I’d never admit it to Atlas, though.

Speaking of Atlas. “Can you let us in already?” he growled.

“On it,” Fallon said.

A tiny beep sounded, followed by the whirl of the automatic lock. Atlas opened the door and ushered us inside.

The interior of the building was just as nice as the outside, modern and industrial, with Edison bulbs and exposed ductwork. A brick wall ran along one side of the foyer, and an old-fashioned metal-frame freight elevator was on the other. It had to be original to the building.

“Maybe we should take the stairs—” I suggested. I wasn’t afraid of elevators, but this wasn’t a normal elevator.

“Come on,” Atlas said, softly tugging me along. “It’s refurbished. It’s safe.”

“You swear?” I asked skeptically.

“I swear. I would *never* let anything happen to you,” he whispered. He nuzzled my temple, placing a reassuring kiss there. “Do you want to press the button?” he asked like I was five.

“Yes,” I replied, because of course I wanted to push it.

I hit the P button and a second later the metal door clanked open.

I didn't even have time to second-guess my life choices before Atlas pulled me inside. With one hand preoccupied with my death grip, he used the other to press the up button.

As the metal doors clinked shut, he pulled me in front of him, wrapping his arms around me tight. "Feel any safer?" he asked, his breath tickling the shell of my ear as he curled himself around me.

"A lot, actually." I gripped his forearms, grounding myself with his touch. It was like being wrapped in a weighted blanket—a giant, furry weighted blanket.

"Good." The word rumbled out of his chest and into mine, distracting me from the fact that we were riding an antiquated deathtrap to the top floor of the apartment building. Correction—*almost distracting me*.

The elevator lurched to a stop, the doors clanking open.

"We made it out alive," Atlas said, leading me off the elevator.

"This time," I grumbled.

It was obvious that Cyrus and Fallon had some sort of penthouse, because there was only one door on this floor. Without knocking, Atlas walked inside the apartment, and I followed behind him.

Just like Atlas said, the apartment was gorgeous. Bright and modern with an exposed brick wall on one side—just like the foyer. Several paintings hung in the hallway, breathtaking landscapes that transported you right into the scene.

Atlas noticed me staring at them. "Do you like the paintings?" he asked.

"Yes. They're gorgeous."

"Cyrus painted those."

"All of them?" I asked.

"All of them."

"He's really talented." One painting in particular caught my eye. It was a lighthouse on a craggy cliff weathering a dark storm. Painted with rough, textured strokes, the foamy waves almost leapt off the canvas. I fought the urge to reach out and run my fingers over them. Touching ridiculously expensive paintings was probably frowned upon. Not exactly the type of first impression I wanted to make.

“Was really talented,” a suave British accent chimed in from the end of the hall. “I’ve been experiencing a bit of a creative block as of late.”

“This is Cyrus,” Atlas said, gesturing to his friend.

Cyrus shuffled down the hall toward us, his tentacles sucking and popping as they propelled him across the tile floor. His muscular chest was uncovered, tapering to a waist of six tentacles. Eight, if I counted the ones wrapped around his arms. His head was long and pointed—almost like a squid’s—and delicate translucent fins lined both sides of his neck.

He was a beautiful light blue color, with darker blue-green tiger stripes running across his body and his tentacles. I did my best not to stare, but Cyrus was the first kraken I’d ever met. In a society where monsters and humans were the norm, there were still certain species that were rare. Krakens were one of them.

Cyrus blinked his wide alien eyes and smiled, showing off two perfect rows of piranha-sharp teeth. “Lovely to meet you, Tegan,” he said, extending a webbed hand out to me.

I took it, giving it a gentle shake. His palm was soft and cool, not at all like what I expected.

“Nice to meet you, too,” I said, grinning at him.

We followed Cyrus down the hall to the open kitchen and living area. Wide windows stretched across the walls, giving us a beautiful view of the sun setting over Briar Glenn.

Fallon and Kael were in the living room, sitting in plush recliners on either side of the sectional couch. In front of them was the biggest TV I’d ever seen.

“You already know Fallon and Kael,” Atlas said.

“Hey, Tegan,” Kael said, tipping his head.

He was a big orc, tall and muscular just like Atlas. It made sense that he’d work out at a place like Leviathan Fitness. I’d known Kael since we were kids, and while we weren’t exactly close, we hung around with the same crowd back in high school.

“Tegan!” Fallon hopped out of his chair, wrapping me in a friendly hug. “Thank you so much for coming over.” His lionlike tail flicked back and

forth excitedly. It was cute, but not nearly as cute as Atlas's tail wags.

"Thank you for having me!"

"It's our pleasure," Cyrus said. "Have a seat."

Atlas, Cyrus, and I sat on the couch while Fallon plucked through a stack of video game cases sitting on the TV stand.

"Tegan said she's not very good at video games, so I was thinking we could start out with something beginner friendly like *Mario Kart*," Fallon suggested.

Kael opened his mouth to say something, but I shot him a look.

He knew my secret, and until I had a little fun, I wanted to keep it that way.

When I told Fallon I wasn't good at video games, I meant first-person shooters, or whatever it was that people played these days. I was *not* referring to *Mario Kart*.

I'd cut my teeth on *Mario Kart 64*, spending my summers locked in front of the TV, racing my brother and his friends. Kael had seen me come in first place race after race, year after year. It got to a point with our friend group where I wouldn't be acknowledged as the winner, second place was.

But these guys had no idea what they were in for.

I picked my usual character, Princess Daisy, and when the countdown ended, we were off. All of us were laser focused on the massive TV screen, clenching our controllers and leaning into the turns. I didn't give it my all right out of the gate, letting myself fall behind before pushing Atlas out from first for the win.

"Damn, baby," Atlas said. "That was impressive." He held out his hand for a high five and I clapped my palm against his.

"Beginner's luck, I guess. Want to play again?"

They nodded and we started another race.

It was closer this time, with Fallon and me vying for first place, but with some perfectly aimed spiny shells, I came out on top once again.

"Wow, Tegan. You caught on quick," Fallon chirped, blinking his beady eyes in shock.

Atlas set his controller down, giving me a sideways glance. “You’re playing us, aren’t you?”

Kael snorted and took a swig of his beer.

Atlas glared at him, his mouth hanging open. “And you knew about it, didn’t you?”

“Dude, I have seen her make a grown man so mad, he threw a controller at his own TV,” Kael said.

And that was the last party I went to at Mark McGinnis’s place. His fragile masculinity was a giant red flag.

Atlas nudged me with his shoulder. “I’m impressed, baby.”

“Thank you. I think I’m done playing for now if you guys want to play something else,” I said, sitting my controller on the coffee table.

“Are you sure?” Atlas asked quietly. It was sweet that he wanted me to feel included, but I could only whip so much ass in *Mario Kart* in one day.

“Yeah, I’m sure.”

Fallon hopped out of his recliner and started messing around with a few of the consoles in the entertainment center. “Okay, are we thinking *Call of Duty* or *Helldivers*?”

There was a unanimous agreement on *Helldivers*, and for the next thirty minutes or so, Cyrus and I watched the three of them fight for their lives on an alien planet. It was actually pretty entertaining—not enough to make me want to try it, though.

Cyrus sighed and stood up. “I’m going to get started on some snacks,” he said, shuffling toward the kitchen.

“Do you need any help?” I asked, already following behind him.

He’d been quiet for most of the evening, a silent observer rather than a participant in game night, and I wanted to get to know him better.

“Oh, that would be lovely. This lot never helps.” He quickly corrected himself. “Except for Atlas, that is.”

“I could see that.”

“I was thinking of putting together a charcuterie tray. Is that all right with you?” he asked. “Atlas didn’t mention any dietary restrictions, but it

could have slipped his mind. I'd hate to serve a vegan a platter of salted meat."

I laughed. "I'm not a vegan so we're all good on that front."

He opened one of the kitchen cabinets, using his tentacles to pull a large wooden serving tray off the top shelf.

"They're so handy," I said in awe. I regretted it the moment I said it, worried it might come off as offensive.

"They are quite handy. You know, for when my hands are otherwise occupied."

I laughed again. Cyrus didn't say much, but when he did, he was pretty funny.

He opened the fridge, grabbing packages of meat and cheese with his hands and tentacles. "Would you like to start arranging these and I'll set to work on the fruit, crackers, and spreads?"

"Sure. I think I can handle that. No guarantee it'll look fancy, though."

"You've seen those three in there, right? It'll be gone before anyone can even worry about how it looks." He paused for a second, thinking. "In fact, you better make yourself a plate right now. They're like a ravenous pack of hyenas."

"That's probably a good idea."

After I set aside a plate for myself, Cyrus and I worked in companionable silence while we assembled the board.

"Atlas seems quite taken with you," he said out of nowhere, taking me by surprise.

"Does he?" I asked. I knew Atlas was into me. He'd made that pretty clear, but hearing it from one of his friends really drove the point home.

"Indeed," Cyrus said. He folded a piece of prosciutto into a rose and placed it on the tray. *And here I thought we weren't concerned with how it looked.* "I haven't seen him this happy in a long time," he continued. "Maybe since I've known him."

"Really?" It came out as a shocked squeak.

"Do you always need this much reassurance or are you just fishing for compliments?" he asked. I was speechless for a second, but then he flashed

me a giant sharp-toothed grin. “Oh, you absolute sweetheart. I’m joking.” He patted my arm with one of his tentacles.

I laughed awkwardly. “You scared me there for a second.”

“I mean it, though. I’m not sure how much he’s told you, but Atlas went through a lot in his last relationship.”

“He’s said a few things, but it’s mainly what he *hasn’t* said, what I’ve noticed, that’s concerned me.” The distorted body image, lack of confidence. All of those were scars left over from his ex.

Fucking bitch.

“She was awful,” Cyrus said. “Royally fucked his self-esteem, and she never wanted to spend any time around us—his closest friends. For a wolverine who demanded everything from him, she didn’t give him shit in return. I’ll tell you—” He paused for a second. “Shit. I’m sorry. It wasn’t my place to share any of that with you.”

“It’s okay. I mean, I figured as much.”

“It’s just so bloody nice to know that he’s found someone who meets him where he is. You like him for him, and not what he can do for you. He’s the salt of the earth, that one. A real catch.”

“I think so, too,” I agreed. He was sweet and silly. Considerate. Handsome. He was an absolute catch, and I was lucky to have him.

“Everything all right in here?” Atlas asked, sliding his palm along the small of my back. I loved that he was checking in, but I was more than okay. Atlas’s friends were so easy to be around—Fallon included.

“Everything’s great,” I said. “I was just helping Cyrus with the charcuterie board.”

“Was Cyrus telling you what an insufferable idiot I was in college?” he asked.

“All he did was sing your praises, actually.”

“Aw, Cy,” Atlas said, looking at Cyrus with puppy-dog eyes. “You really do love me.”

“How could you not?” I said it like loving Atlas was second nature, then quickly snapped my mouth shut once I realized what just came out of it.

Heat rushed to my cheeks, and Cyrus gave me a knowing grin.

“Yeah,” he said slyly. “How could you not?”

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Thirty-One



ATLAS

"I HAD A LOT OF fun tonight," Tegan said when I pulled the truck to a stop in front of her home.

"I'm glad you had a good time."

I was ecstatic that my friends liked her, and it seemed mutual on her end.

"Are you coming inside?" she asked, staring at me expectantly.

I swallowed hard, remembering our conversation from earlier. "I'd love to."

Tegan was already out of the truck by the time I scrambled over to her side. We stepped onto her front porch, and I held the screen door open for her while she unlocked the front door.

She flicked on a light in the foyer, and I followed her inside.

The interior of the cottage was just as cute as the outside, warm and cozy with mismatched furniture. It was clear it hadn't been updated, but I loved the lived-in feel rather than the coldness of my new construction. The cottage had character. Good bones.

"Make yourself at home," she said, setting her keys and purse on the coffee table. "Would you like something to drink?"

"Some water would be great."

While she grabbed me something to drink, I poked around the living room, checking out the bookshelves lining the walls. They were filled with

romance novels, a few popular manga titles I recognized, and of course, books on baking.

“I didn’t know you were such a big reader,” I called out to her. I pulled one of the books off the shelf and flipped it over, reading the back cover to learn it was some sort of romance novel about aliens on an ice planet.

“I got it from my mom,” she said, rattling around in the kitchen. “I started sneaking her romance books when I was a tween and never looked back. Do you read?”

“No reading.” I slipped the book back onto the shelf and made my way over to the couch. “Just video games.”

“So, you’d be down to just chill in the same room as me,” she said, popping back into the living room. “You could play video games and I could read?”

“Sounds like heaven to me,” I said as she passed me my drink.

She sat on the couch, patting the cushion next to her. “Have a seat.”

I took a sip of my water and set it on the coffee table—making sure I used one of her flower coasters underneath it.

When I sat down next to her, I felt the couch strain under my weight. Gods, I hoped I didn’t break it. If we were going to hang out at her house more, I’d have to make some updates to her furniture—or replace it with something sturdier if she’d let me.

Tegan’s shoulder was pressed against mine, and we sat there in tense silence, like we weren’t sure who should make the first move. The need I had for her earlier bubbled up to the surface until I couldn’t take it anymore. She had to be closer. I wanted to touch her, and taste her, and fuck her. Feel the warmth and the weight of her body.

“Come here,” I growled, gravelly and low, reaching for her. I gripped her hips and shifted on the couch, lying back and pulling her on top of me. She was rigid at first, but after a few moments in my arms, I felt her relax.

I brushed her hair to one side, kissing the exposed column of her neck, paying special attention to the place where her neck met her collarbone. Her skin was so soft and smooth, and she smelled so fucking good.

“Atlas,” she groaned, arching her body from the sensation.

My name coming out of her like that, all throaty and rough, spurred me on.

I pushed my knee between her legs, propping it up slightly to press against her pussy. She was wearing a dress with a pair of bike shorts underneath, and I could feel the heat—the need—radiating off her.

She started to rock her hips, grinding against my thigh, letting out some of the sweetest moans I'd ever heard.

"That's it," I purred. I tugged her earlobe between my teeth, and she sucked in a breath, bucking against me. "Use me, baby. Use me to make yourself come."

"There's no way I can get off like this." She said it confidently, but I took it as a challenge.

"Want to bet?" I grabbed her hips, taking control of her movements, sliding her up and down my thigh.

She dug her fingers into my fur, grabbing tight fistfuls to steady herself while she rode my leg.

"Atlas—I—I can't," she protested, panting hard.

"Yes, you can."

She shook her head, burying her face in my neck.

A laugh rumbled out of me. She was just too fucking cute.

I released her hips, bringing my hands down to grab her ass, increasing the pressure and really driving her pussy down onto my leg.

"Do you want to hear about all the ways I want to fuck you?" I whispered in her ear. "Will that help?"

She nodded, like her mind was too preoccupied to form a verbal response.

"First, you're gonna dry-hump me until you get off," I rasped. "I want your pussy slick and sensitive, and your body all nice and relaxed for me."

Her breathing picked up, so I increased the pace, really reading her body.

"Then I'm going to take you into your bedroom and toss you onto your bed. I'm going to rip off your clothes and feast on your pussy. Lick you from top to bottom until you're a squirming mess, begging me to get you

off again. Then I'm going to swirl my tongue over your clit. Tease you until you come all over my face. Tease you until you beg me to fuck you."

I sucked on her neck, and she moaned my name, spurring me on.

"Then I'm going to flip you onto your belly, pull out my cock, and fill you up with one thrust. Bury my cock in that tight little cunt over and over again, until you scream out my name."

"Fuck, I want that," she moaned, her movements growing frantic.

"You have to get off first."

I wanted her to come. Needed her to come like it was my life's mission to bring her pleasure.

My cock was rock hard, and it was like we were fucking through our clothes, hips moving and hands gripping, a heated tangle of bodies testing the very limits of her couch.

I was close. So fucking close. I wanted us to take that leap together, even if it meant coming in my pants like a pup.

"Come for me, Tegan," I growled, licking her throat, raking my teeth over her pounding pulse.

Her grip tightened in my fur, her thighs clamping around mine as she came with a high-pitched moan.

I reached for her chin, tipping her head back slightly so I could stare at her pink cheeks and hooded eyes, see the sweet sounds of her pleasure tumbling past her lips. That did it. My spine tingled and my balls tightened, and I gripped her chin, watching the way her eyes widened when I came with a loud groan.

Tegan rode my thigh for a few more beats, her body quivering as she chased every bit of her orgasm she could.

When she finished, she rose up on shaky knees, planting her hands on my chest to stare down at me. "Did you just—"

"Yeah," I said awkwardly. I was only slightly embarrassed. Between the noises Tegan was making and how good it felt to have her riding my thigh, I just couldn't help myself.

She bit her lip, grinning. "Fuck, that's hot."

"Really?" I asked, propping myself up on my elbows.

She nodded. “The fact that I got you off without touching you? Hell yeah.”

I leaned forward, burying my claws into the hair at the nape of her neck, pulling her in for a slow kiss.

“So,” she said, when she finally pulled away. “There were some things I was promised.”

“Oh yes.”

I bolted upright, hiking her under my arm like she was a tote bag, and she let out a little shriek.

“Atlas,” she protested—weakly, I might add.

“Which way is your room?” I asked.

“Down the hallway, first room on the right.”

I followed her instructions, carrying her down the hall toward her room.

“Why do you always manhandle me?” she giggled.

“Because I can,” I grunted, nudging her bedroom door open. “Do you have a problem with that?”

Thirty-Two



TEGAN

BEFORE I COULD ANSWER, ATLAS tossed me onto the bed, and I bounced slightly.

I propped myself up on my elbows, my chest heaving. “Nope.”

He stood at the foot of the bed, staring at me for a second before he pulled his shirt over his head. “Good.”

He shucked off his joggers next, revealing navy blue boxer briefs with a dark spot right over the crotch. It shouldn’t have been nearly as hot as it was, but I couldn’t help feeling victorious that I made him come without laying a finger on his cock.

“Come here,” I hummed, crawling to the edge of the bed.

“Why?” he asked, palming himself.

“I want to taste you.”

He palmed himself again, his cock already straining against his underwear. “I don’t remember telling you we were doing that.”

“I want you to fuck my mouth.”

“Yeah?” he asked.

I nodded.

He slid his underwear down his legs, letting his cock free. He gave it one slow jerk, making a shiny bead of precum gather on the tip.

I moved to a sitting position on the edge of the bed, spreading my legs wide. Atlas stepped between them, bringing his cock a breath’s width from

my face.

“Is this what you want?” he asked, giving his cock another slow pump.

I nodded, running my hands along the backs of his thighs. “Please.”

One of his hands fisted my hair, holding me in place while he rubbed the slick tip of his cock across my lips, coating them with precum.

My tongue darted out, eagerly lapping at his head before he slid his cock inside my mouth.

“Tegan,” he grunted, canting his hips, forcing his cock into the back of my throat.

He fucked my face until my lips tingled and my cheeks hurt. Spit dribbled down my chin and tears clouded my vision. It was rough and messy, and I loved every second of it. He was taking control. Using me for his pleasure.

And then he stopped.

Atlas yanked me off his cock, staring down at me with his hand still buried in my hair. “Did you really think I was going to come in your mouth when your pussy is there, waiting to be filled up?” he asked.

He manhandled me again, flipping me over so my belly was against the duvet and my ass was up in the air. Atlas joined me on the bed, the mattress dipping under his weight. I wasn’t sure my bed frame could handle him fucking me, but we were about to find out.

He threw my dress over my back, tugging down the shorts I was wearing underneath to give him access to my pussy.

“Look at you,” he said, smoothing his palms over my ass. “The most perfect fucking body.”

One of his hands cracked down on my cheek, making me yelp and sending a wave of heat through me.

“Someone likes to be spanked.” He turned his attention to my pussy, rubbing two fingers along the seam. “You’re fucking soaked.”

I rocked my hips into his hand, begging him to touch me.

“Ah. Ah,” he tsked, pulling his fingers away.

I let out a little frustrated sigh at the loss, making him laugh.

“Be patient.” He wiped his wet fingertips across my ass before giving it another rough smack that felt like a bolt of lightning straight to my clit, making me cry out again. “I’m gonna take care of you, baby,” he said, skimming his hand over my cheek to soothe away the sting.

I hadn’t seen him like this before. More dominant. More aggressive.

I liked it.

I felt the tip of his cock brush against my ass, and I arched my back, really pressing myself against him. He let out a throaty groan of approval and gripped one of my hips, his claws digging into my skin while he held me in place. The slick tip of his cock slid across my pussy, up and down a few times before he notched himself at my entrance, driving himself home in one thrust, just like he’d promised.

I cried out his name from the stretch, the burning sensation of being so utterly full fading to a pleasurable warmth that I’d only ever experienced with him.

“That’s my girl,” he cooed. “Taking me like you were made for me.”

He leaned over me, tenderly cupping my jaw with one hand while the other cupped my breast, lifting me up until I was on my knees with my back pressed to his chest.

“This okay?” he whispered.

“Yeah—ahh.” He pinched my nipple, making the last part of the word stretch out on a moan. I could feel him everywhere. His gentle grip on my jaw, his rough palm on my breast, his fur tickling my back, and of course the steady thrusts of his cock.

I pushed my ass into him, forcing him deeper, until the thick swell of his knot rubbed against my pussy. It teased my entrance with each of his thrusts, bumping and grinding, the friction driving me wild.

Fuck, I wanted to take it. Feel it pop inside of me, locking us together and sealing in his cum.

“I—I want your knot,” I whined.

“Fuck,” he groaned, moving his hips in a circle to *really* tease me with his knot. “I wish I could give it to you, baby. I want to feel your pussy strangling my knot.”

“Please,” I begged, even though it was irrational. There was no way it was happening today, but a girl could dream.

“You want my knot plugging your pussy while I fill you with my cum?” he asked. “Keeping it all inside of you?”

I nodded against his hand. “Fuck. Yes.”

He moved faster, tightening his grip on my jaw, rolling my nipple between his fingertips until it was too much. It was all too much.

“Gonna come,” I panted, feeling the tension building in my belly.

“Me, too, but I don’t want to,” he rasped. “Not yet.”

“Why?” I breathed. “We have all night.”

That spurred Atlas on, his thrusts growing erratic. Again and again he pounded into me until I shattered around him.

I cried out his name, bracing myself on one arm, reaching behind me with the other to bury my hand in his fur. He pressed his snout against my temple, fucking me through my orgasm until I felt him go rigid against me, his cock jolting inside me as he pumped me full of his cum.

He slid his hand down the column of my neck, crossing his arms over my chest to support my limp body, holding me against his chest with his cock still buried inside me.

I sighed contentedly, leaning into him. Hoping he’d never let me go.

—

AFTER ANOTHER ROUND, I WAS an absolute mess. Sweat and a mixture of our body fluids coated my skin, and my brain had that fuzzy dreamlike feeling that came with back-to-back-*to-back* orgasms.

“Do you want to take a shower?” I asked before thinking about the logistics of the two of us fitting in my shower. It was your standard-size bathtub, nothing fancy like at Atlas’s house, but I was confident we could make it work.

“I would love to.”

I slipped out of bed, doing a little stretch to show off my body while Atlas’s eyes were glued on me. He mumbled something along the lines of

You're going to kill me under his breath, and I smirked.

"We won't be able to take a long one," I said. "My water heater needs to be replaced."

He sat on the edge of the bed, running his claws through the fur on the back of his neck. "Gas or electric?" he asked.

The question took me by surprise. Why did he need to know something like that?

"Electric," I said, slipping inside my closet to grab a towel for him. He was a big guy, so I pulled two off the shelf. "They didn't run gas lines out here."

"I can replace it for you."

I tossed the towels on the bed and stepped between his legs, shivering when he ran his hands along my sides.

"I couldn't ask you to do that," I said, burying my fingers in the thick ruff of fur covering his neck.

"If it was gas, I would have told you to hire a professional, but an electric water heater is easy enough. The next day you're free, we'll go get one and I'll install it for you."

"Are you sure you don't mind?"

"Mhm. What's the point of having a boyfriend who's handy if he doesn't fix things around the house? Besides—" He placed a series of barely there kisses along my chest. It was almost like he was kissing my freckles—the big ones, at least. "I want us to have plenty of warm water when I shower here."

"Or—we could just shower at your house," I suggested. "There would be more room."

He nuzzled my chest, his soft fur giving me goose bumps. "I like it here."

"Why?" I asked, my voice tight.

He leaned back, his golden eyes staring at me so intensely I almost wanted to look away. "It's homey. It's you. And I like you."

"I like you, too." That's what I said, but the things that I felt for Atlas were starting to feel deeper than that. The *other* four-letter L-word.

I gave him one last kiss before I slipped away, grabbing the towels and carrying them into the bathroom.

While the cottage was small, it did have two bathrooms. My nana had updated the hallway half bath at some point during my life, but the en suite was terribly outdated. As soon as I fell into some money, it was first on the list for renovations.

Atlas squeezed into the bathroom with me, leaning against the counter and looking around.

“What?” I asked.

“You know, while I’m on a roll with the water heater, we could remodel the bathroom,” he suggested, like it was no big deal.

I scoffed. “There’s no way I could let you do that.”

“But I—”

“No,” I said firmly.

Even if he had the know-how, there was no way I could afford it. And I certainly wasn’t letting him pay for it.

“Fine.” He sighed. “But let me know if you ever change your mind.”

“I promise I will.” *When I have the money to pay him to do it.*

I bent over and started the tap, giving the water a chance to warm up and giving Atlas another perfect view of my ass. Not one to waste an opportunity, he gave it a playful swat that made it jiggle.

“Will you stop it?” I giggled. “It’s sore because someone kept spanking it.”

He came up behind me, nuzzling my neck. “I just can’t help myself.”

“Well, you’re going to have to because I can’t go another round. Not tonight,” I said, climbing into the shower now that the water was finally warm enough.

He chuckled. “Fair enough.”

“Sorry it’s so tiny,” I said, watching his massive frame squeeze into the shower with me. We were going to have to take turns under the showerhead.

“Tegan,” he said, moving into my space. “It’s fine.” He did that sexy-arm thing, leaning over me, caging me against the wall with his body.

The water trickled over his fur, along his muzzle, and off the tip of his nose, dripping onto me while I stared up at him. He looked so incredibly sexy, this jacked, handsome wolven, looking at me like he wanted to eat me alive.

Atlas cupped my neck with his free hand, leaning down to give me a slow sensual kiss that was over way too soon.

“What’s this?” he said, reaching for something behind me.

“What’s what?”

“Is this *the* bath puff?” he asked, dangling the pouf from his claws.

I really regretted telling him that story. Was it gross I hadn’t replaced it?

“Yes. That is *the* pouf.”

He picked up my body wash, squirted a significant amount on the pouf, and proceeded to scrub himself with it.

“What are you doing?” I asked with a laugh. The sight of him lathering up with a bright pink bath pouf was hilarious.

“When I’m at work tomorrow, I want to smell like you.” He cocked his head, his wet ears flopping to the side. *Adorable*. “Is that a problem?”

“No.” I mean, my pouf was going to become a giant hairball, but at this point in my relationship with Atlas, I’d accepted all the fur that came with being in a relationship with him. It would be a lifetime of lint rolling, clogged drains, and—

Wait.

A lifetime?

It shook me up how naturally that thought crept in there.

“Good,” he said. “Switch with me.”

I shimmied around him, which was incredibly difficult in my tiny bathtub, letting him rinse under the spray of the shower. The water trickled down his body as he tilted his head toward the showerhead, running his hands through his fur to make sure he rinsed out all the soap. Suds trailed down his chest, over his abs, dripping off the tip of his soft cock as it hung between his legs.

“Tegan,” he said, making me jump.

“Yeah,” I said in a daze.

He tugged me to him, wrapping his arms around me and holding me under the warm water.

“Were you checking me out?” he asked, his voice a rumble against my chest.

“Maybe,” I stammered.

“If you keep staring at me like that, I might just have to take you again.” He grabbed my breast, giving my already-sensitive nipple a little tweak that made my pussy throb.

I reached down for his cock, making a frustrated noise in the back of my throat when he pulled his hips away.

“I thought you said you couldn’t go another round?” He hummed.

“I lied.” I shut off the tap and ripped the shower curtain back. “Now take me to bed.”

He hoisted me into his arms, handling my slick body with ease. “Yes, ma’am.”

I had a feeling it was going to be a long night.

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Thirty-Three



ATLAS

“DO YOU THINK YOU’LL BE able to fit?” Tegan asked with a giggle as I stood beside her crossover SUV. I was so distracted when I grabbed her bag this morning that I hadn’t considered the logistics of my enormous body fitting inside of her car.

I walked around the sleek black vehicle, ducking down to peer inside the compact cabin.

“It’s gonna be tight, but I think I can manage. It’s not a very long ride anyway.”

Yeah, I could fit, but it was going to be uncomfortable as fuck. I’d rather die than admit that to her, though. Just like I’d rather die than suggest we take separate vehicles. There was already a possessive part of me that couldn’t bear to be away from her. I knew that those wolverine instincts would kick in eventually, but I hadn’t anticipated having such strong feelings this soon.

Plus, if I was dragging Tegan to go work out this early in the morning after our sexual escapades last night, I could at least make sure she had her car. She hadn’t complained, but I could tell she was slightly tender.

Gods, she had looked so good coming undone against my thigh. And the noises she made when I spanked her.

I had to adjust my cock in my pants as we turned into the gym parking lot. Not that me popping a boner around Tegan was anything new, but it was

later in the morning than when we normally worked out and the parking lot was full. I didn't want to chance one of my clients getting an eyeful of wolverine dick.

"Wow, it's packed this morning," Tegan said as she flung her workout bag over her shoulder.

As we walked through the front door of Leviathan Fitness, Chai called out to us from behind the desk.

"Hey there, boss man. Aren't you going to introduce me?" she said with a smile and a tilt of her horned head.

Chai was one of the most attractive minotaurs I had ever seen, with deep brown eyes and light brown fur dotted with white patches. As a trainer, she kept herself in great shape, but she'd been dealing with some mystery illness for a while now. She didn't tell me the details, so I didn't pry, but I was happy to see her looking like her normal bubbly self.

"Hey, Chai." I offered her a slight wave as I ushered Tegan toward the front desk with my palm pressed against the small of her back. "This is my girlfriend, Tegan."

Chai grinned knowingly, showing off her perfectly straight ruminant teeth. "Ah! It's so nice to finally meet you," she said as she looked at Tegan, then me. "I've heard so much about you from Atlas and Fallon."

"It's nice to meet you, too."

"If Atlas isn't around and you need help with anything, just let me know," Chai said. I could already tell that she liked Tegan.

"I will."

"Well, we better get started on our workout," I said, checking the time.

"Have a good workout!" Chai said cheerfully.

"Nice to meet you!" Tegan yelled over her shoulder as I steered her away.

We headed upstairs so I could stretch out Tegan's sore muscles before our workout. After last night, I wanted to take it easy on her today.

I was in the middle of teaching her morning glories when I heard a high-pitched whistle.

Fuck.

“Hey there, wolf daddy,” Fallon said, strolling up to us.

Tegan looked at me, her lips pursed together holding back her laughter. “Wolf daddy?” she finally managed to grate out.

“I told you not to call me that,” I barked at Fallon.

“I kind of like it,” Tegan said, making him laugh.

“See,” Fallon chirped. “It’s a good nickname.”

I shook my head. “Did you need something, or did you just feel like harassing us?”

“I just wanted to shoot the shit,” he said. “See how Tegan felt about game night.”

“I had a great time,” she said.

Fallon ruffled his feathers. “I didn’t know you were, like, a *Mario Kart* prodigy.”

“Yeah. That really threw me for a loop, too,” I said, smiling at her.

Teagan was full of surprises. I wanted to uncover them all.

Our conversation was interrupted by yelling coming from downstairs.

“You can’t just walk in here and act like you own the place anymore,” Chai bellowed, her voice laced with anger.

Footsteps stomped up the staircase. The click of nails and the familiar clack of Chai’s hooves.

And that’s when I saw her.

Jade.

By wolverine standards, my ex was a knockout. Her body was toned and thin, leanly muscled with long legs and big tits. She had silvery-white fur and bright yellow-green eyes, but beneath that attractive exterior was an ugly side. Her tongue was vicious. She knew exactly what to say to cut you down and make you feel small. Insignificant. Imperfect.

A shiver raced down my spine as she stormed over to us.

“Hello, Atlas,” she said with a sharp smile.

“Jade,” I replied, my voice low.

“You look like you’ve put on weight,” Jade said as her gaze passed over my body.

As soon as the words left her mouth, I instinctively dropped my shoulders and tugged my tank top away from my stomach, doing what I could to disguise my body.

I had put on weight, but it wasn't anything noticeable.

And even if it was, I was the happiest I'd felt in a long time.

Tegan didn't judge me. I felt safe with her, and it was helping to heal my relationship with food and with my body. But the damage Jade had done to me over the course of our relationship was hard to repair.

"You can't be here." Fallon stepped closer to her, his feline tail thrashing from side to side in agitation.

Jade held a hand up to silence him, and her red-painted claws glistened under the fluorescent lighting. "Shut it, bird brain. The last time I checked, this wasn't your gym." She noticed Tegan and her eyes narrowed, her sharp stare raking over Tegan's body. "You must be my downgrade." She sneered at Tegan, the bridge of her muzzle wrinkling in disgust.

"I'm Tegan." Tegan's voice was calm and confident. She puffed out her chest and smirked up at Jade. She wasn't intimidated in the slightest, and it made my heart swell with pride to see her standing her ground.

Jade glared daggers at me, and her mouth twisted into a devious smile. "Does she have any idea who I am, Atlas? Hmm?" She examined her nails, awaiting my response.

"Tegan." I sighed. "Jade is my ex."

"Ex-fiancée," Jade corrected.

Tegan didn't seem bothered by what she said, but I hated that I wasn't the one to tell her about my engagement to Jade.

My ears flattened and my tail sagged behind me, the fluffy tip kissing the ground. Just being around her sickened me. Made me feel small.

Jade and Tegan were polar opposites. Jade was callous and cold. Tegan was warm, caring, and supportive.

Knowing that I'd wasted so many years of my life with someone so horrid made me feel even worse. Was my self-esteem really so low that I'd allowed myself to be treated that way? I guessed it was.

“I wish that I could say it’s a pleasure, but from what Atlas has told me, you were a truly awful partner.” Tegan grabbed my hand in hers and squeezed tightly. “He deserves better.”

A low growl slithered out of Jade’s mouth. “And you think that’s you?” she snarled at Tegan before taking a step closer to me. “Does she know about wolveren, Atlas? Really know? The full moon is only a few weeks away. Are you planning to spend it with her?”

I swallowed hard, not answering her.

Jade’s malicious grin widened. “Has she taken your knot yet? How’s she going to fare when you go into rut?” Jade reached a sharp claw out toward Tegan’s body and trailed it along her cheek. “Do you know what rut is, Tegan? Or did Atlas leave out that little detail?”

Tegan slapped her hand away, her chest heaving and her body shaking. I could feel the anger radiating off her in waves.

“Poor, poor Atlas. You’re really scraping the bottom of the barrel here. I came back to offer to spend the full moon with you. Don’t you think that would work things out between us? A good fuck under the light of the moon?” Jade clutched my tank top and stared up at me through her lashes, batting her deep green eyes at me.

I was frozen in place and a whine slipped out of me before I could control it. Within seconds, Tegan had positioned herself between Jade and me.

“Listen—I don’t care what happens to wolveren during the full moon, and I don’t know what rut is. But what I do know is that Atlas is my partner now, and if you ever show your face in this gym, hell, even in this town ever again, we’re going to have a real problem.” Tegan’s face was flushed red, her fists clenching and unclenching at her sides.

I’d never seen her like this before, all alpha and protective. It made me adore her even more.

Jade looked as if Tegan had slapped her, her mouth gaping open, not uttering a single word. With a *hmpf*, she turned on her heel and stormed down the staircase.

“I’ll follow her and make sure she leaves,” Fallon said before trailing off behind her.

I squeezed Tegan’s hand and pulled her into a tight hug, planting kisses all over the top of her head. “Thank you for that, baby,” I mumbled into her hair between kisses.

“I meant what I said, Atlas. You deserve better.” Her voice was strangled, as if she was fighting back tears.

“And I found that in you, sweet thing.” I tilted her head up, forcing her to look at me.

Her bright green eyes were rimmed red and her lower lip quivered. It reminded me of the day I found her scooping cake off the sidewalk. Things were moving fast, but I was so enthralled with this woman. Her ferocity. Her kindness. Her loving heart. There was no way I would ever let her go.

But it was time.

Time I told her everything.

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Thirty-Four



TEGAN

“SIT DOWN RIGHT HERE, BABY,” Atlas said. He supported my arm as I lowered my shaking body into the chair across from his desk.

I wasn’t shaking because I was upset, though. I was shaking from adrenaline and anger.

I didn’t know what rut was, and yeah, the whole ex-fiancée thing was a bit of a surprise—but those details were something that Atlas should have been able to tell me in his own time. Not another thing for Jade to weaponize.

Atlas sat down behind his desk and handed me a box of tissues. “Tegan, I—I’m sorry. I should have told you Jade and I were engaged before I ended things, and I should have told you more about wolveren. About what we’re like when—”

I cut him off. “Atlas. Stop. You would have told me when you were ready, but Jade had to show up and put you in this position.” I blew my nose loudly, and it made the corner of Atlas’s muzzle turn up ever so slightly. “I saw how you reacted to being around her. You were terrified.”

His ears drooped and he let out a low whine. “I, uh. Yeah. I am terrified of her. She made me miserable, Tegan.” His voice was softer and meeker than I had ever heard it before. That bitch had really done a number on him.

“Well, she’s never going to bother you again. I can promise you that.” I smiled and dabbed at the corner of my eyes with another tissue.

His expression brightened and I heard the telltale *thump, thump, thump* of his tail smacking against the wall behind his chair. The next thing I knew, he was leaning forward, pressing his lips to mine as his claws dug into the wood of the desk to steady his burly body.

“I’m so lucky to have you in my life, sweet thing,” Atlas mumbled between kisses. He nipped my lip playfully before pulling away, and I let out a small moan.

“Shit, Tegan. Don’t do that,” he groaned, adjusting himself. “We can’t right now.”

I bit my lip and eyed him hungrily. I didn’t even know how I had a sex drive after last night. “I know we can’t, but a girl can dream.”

Atlas chuckled and sat back down in his chair. This time, he leaned over the desk, resting his head in his palms as he gazed into my eyes.

“I should probably explain a few more things about the full moon.” His tone was somber, and again his ears drooped on either side of his head.

“You don’t have to share anything with me if you’re not ready.”

“No. I want to share this with you. I want you to know this part of me.” He took a deep breath, and his muscular pecs strained against his tank top. “When there’s a full moon, wolverines get”—he paused, trying hard to find the right word—“feral. We revert to some of our base instincts. We hunt for prey, chase each other through the woods, and, well, fuck under the light of the moon. Male wolverines fall into something called rut. The sex is primal, uncontrolled, rough, and, uh, it can last for hours. It’s how our kind connect with nature and with our partners. And if we’re lucky”—another pause and Atlas looked at me thoughtfully—“that’s how we connect with our mates.”

Confusion must have passed over my face.

“Wolverines are drawn to their mate by an unknown force. For some it happens instantaneously, but for others it takes time for the urge to mate with their partner to form. That’s what I thought would happen with Jade, and it just never did. She wasn’t my fated mate.” He bit his lip and scrubbed his hand over the back of his head. “I know this is probably overwhelming...” He trailed off and looked away, his brows furrowed with concern.

Mates?

Was he implying what I thought he was implying?

Did Atlas think that we were mates?

“W-what happens? When you find your mate?” I whispered, my voice wavering just the slightest as my heart beat a rapid rhythm in my chest.

“Well, for wolverines, one partner will bite the other and claim them. Then they’re connected.” He paused a beat before speaking. “Forever.”

My dream came to mind and heat pooled low in my belly at the thought of Atlas sinking his teeth into my skin. Claiming me. Bonding me to him forever. Things were still so early on in our relationship that the very idea of being bonded with him for the rest of my life should have made my skin crawl, but it didn’t.

It excited me.

“I understand if this is too much for you.” His voice was heavy with distress, his eyes wide and pleading, obviously hoping that it wasn’t too much for me.

There was so much about this that was new, different even, but it wasn’t going to deter me from pursuing something with Atlas, but that’s when I remembered.

“It isn’t. But, um, during rut, would I be safe? With you?” I hated asking, but I honestly didn’t know if Atlas would be able to control himself around me when he was in that state.

Before I knew what was happening, Atlas bolted upright, his computer chair toppling to the floor with a loud crash as he made his way around the desk. He held me to his chest, his muscular arms wrapping me in a tight hug.

“Tegan, I—I would never—” His voice was strained. “I would never hurt you. At least not in a way you didn’t like,” he mumbled as he rubbed the soft fur of his face along the column of my neck. “I promise.”

I draped my arms around his scruff, reveling in the warmth of his body and the certainty of his words. I knew deep in my heart it was the truth. Just like I knew that he wouldn’t be spending another full moon with anyone else but me.

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Thirty-Five



ATLAS

“AS MUCH AS I’M ENJOYING this, don’t you have to get ready for work, baby?” I peppered kisses along her jawline and flared my nostrils, inhaling as much of her scent as I could.

“Yeah, you’re probably right,” she said as she buried her face in the fluffy hair of my ruff. “But you’re just so warm.” She let out a small sigh and I could have died from cuteness overload.

This was everything I had wanted for so long.

“Come on. That’s a good girl,” I said as she peeled herself away from my body and rose to her feet. “Let me help you get your stuff to your car. I’m sorry for even dragging you here in the first place.”

I reached for her bag, but Tegan grabbed it before I could get to it. “It’s okay. I got it.” She ran her fingers through the fur of my arm. “I can walk myself out. I’m sure you have work to do.” She tilted her head toward the stack of papers gracing the corner of my desk. Unpaid invoices, time sheets, and promotional proofs all awaited my approval.

“Are you sure?” I whined, and nuzzled her softly.

“Positive. I’ll text you later.” She stood on her tiptoes and placed a light kiss on my snout.

When she pulled away, I let out a groan, which had her smiling. I didn’t want her to go, but we were adults with lives and responsibilities. It wasn’t like I was never going to see her again.

“Bye,” she said, clutching the doorframe of my office.

“Bye, baby.” I watched her walk away, staring after her like an idiot for a moment before sitting down at my computer.

I puffed out a breath and ran my fingers through my fur.

Of all the times for Jade to show her face around here, it had to be when Tegan was with me. In a way, it had worked out, though.

Tegan and I needed to have this discussion.

I hated it, but some of the things Jade brought up made sense. Woven were different during the full moon. Would I be able to control myself around Tegan? Sure, I told her *now* that I wouldn't hurt her, but what if I was too rough with her during rut?

What if I tried to mate her?

I'd had my suspicions since the last full moon, but it was becoming increasingly obvious that Tegan was more to me than just my girlfriend. Admitting it felt scary.

I'd spent so long with Jade, sticking things out in the hopes that the mating bond would fall into place, that things would click and I'd feel the urge to claim her, but it never did.

That's because there was someone else the goddess had chosen for me.

Tegan was my mate.

Because my parents were great, we'd had plenty of talks about mating when I was growing up. I could have done a simple internet search as a refresher, but I wanted to talk to a couple who had experience with this sort of thing, even if my parents were both wovens.

Gods, my mom was going to absolutely lose her shit when she found out I had a mate.

I started the video chat, staring at myself on the screen while I waited for my parents to pick up.

My dad answered, shifting what I assumed was the tablet my brothers and I got them for Christmas last year upward, until I could see his face.

“Hey, son. We weren't expecting a call from you today.”

I puffed out a tight breath. “Yeah, I, uh, I have something I want to talk to you and Mom about.”

His bushy brows furrowed. The last time I called them like this was when I broke things off with Jade. “Give me a second to grab your mother. She’s out in the garden.”

He set the tablet on the kitchen table, giving me a perfect view of their recently remodeled kitchen. Bit by bit they’d been renovating the old farmhouse I grew up in. It was strange seeing everything new and pristine, but my parents worked hard. They deserved a nice, updated home.

Tegan did, too.

“Give us one second, sweetheart,” Mom said, walking into the kitchen. She had her big sun hat on and her favorite pair of yard work overalls. “I was weeding the garden. Getting it ready for spring.”

She loved to garden. She and Tegan would have that in common.

Mom washed her hands, then she and Dad sat down in front of the tablet.

“What did you want to talk to us about?” she asked, giving me her full attention. “Is everything okay?”

I was lucky to have such amazing parents. They made me feel so loved.

“Um—” Gods, it was hard to even bring this up. It was wild that my mom mentioned mating the last time we talked about Tegan and here we were. It must have been some weird mom sixth sense.

They stared intently, waiting for me to continue.

“I think Tegan is my mate,” I murmured.

My mom gasped. “See, Zeus.” She shook Dad’s arm frantically. “I told you. I just knew.”

“How did you know?” I asked, my ears perking up.

“Atlas.” She laughed, staring down her muzzle at me. “I’m your mother. I could see it in your eyes when you talked about her.”

“How—how do I know for sure?”

“Well, how did the last full moon go?” Dad asked.

“I kept going to her house. Running back and forth all night long until I passed out. I couldn’t keep myself away from her.”

My dad nodded, a wide grin on his face. “Sounds about right.”

I ran my hand along the back of my neck. “It’s just really unexpected. It’s throwing me off a little bit.”

“It’s normal to feel that way,” my mom reassured me. “It’s a lot of emotions hitting you all at once.”

“You feel a little out of control,” Dad said. He hit the nail right on the head.

“Yes. And that’s what I’m worried about. What if I accidentally hurt her?”

“Atlas.” His voice was soft—sympathetic. “We obviously aren’t humans, but I don’t think you have to worry about harming her.”

“There are so many wolverine-human mated pairs. We’re extremely compatible,” Mom said, and Dad nodded in agreement.

“Have you talked to her about it yet?” he asked.

“No. I mean, I mentioned mates and the full moon, but I didn’t tell her that I think *she*’s my mate.” I let out another deep breath. “I’m just not sure how to bring it up without freaking her out. I don’t want it to seem like I’m pressuring her into it or moving too fast.”

“You need to remember that you aren’t the only one who’s affected by this,” he said. “She must be feeling it, too, but without the knowledge to know exactly what’s happening. There’s still some time before the next full moon. You should talk to her about it and see how she feels.”

“Yeah,” I said. “You’re right.” Just like they always were.

“The worst that could happen is that she wants to take it slow,” he added. “Spend a few more full moons away from you and slowly ease into it—or she’ll be gung-ho and ready to embrace the mating bond. For some pairs, it’s one of those ‘when you know, you know’ type of situations. There’s no point in dragging it out.”

I wondered what type Tegan would be. We had only been together a short time, but if I knew her like I think I did, she would be the jump-headfirst-into-it type.

“I really appreciate you guys,” I told them.

My mom wrapped her arm around my dad’s, leaning into him. “We’re glad that you felt comfortable coming to us about this.”

Dad nodded. "Remember what I said last time, we just want you to be happy."

"I am just so excited for you, but I'm trying to hold it in," Mom said, wiggling back and forth. Her tail was probably going a mile a minute. "I can't wait to meet her."

I laughed. I loved how happy she was about this. "I promise that as soon as it happens, I'll let you know, and we'll come for a visit."

"We'll be looking forward to it," Dad said.

"Love you, sweetheart," Mom said, still swaying from the force of her tail. "We are so happy for you."

"Thanks. Love you, too."

We said our goodbyes, and I ended the call feeling slightly better about things.

I needed to talk to Tegan, but she'd already had a lot dumped on her today that she wasn't ready for. If she was really my mate, there wasn't any reason to rush the convo. We had a lifetime together.

Thirty-Six



TEGAN

I COULDN'T STOP THINKING ABOUT mating. Since Atlas mentioned it, it was the only thing on my mind. I had so many questions, but I was too afraid to ask them.

I mean, what if I was totally jumping the gun here?

The way Atlas brought it up kind of made it seem like I was his mate, but what if I was just projecting my own feelings?

Every time we hung out, it just felt like there was something lingering between us. Something that neither of us was ready to admit or acknowledge. For us, that was really unusual.

The full moon was only a few days away, and he hadn't even asked me to spend it with him yet.

And maybe he wasn't going to.

I let out a big yawn as I turned onto the gravel driveway that led to the cottage. Selene was off today, and after working by myself, it was obvious just how much I needed her. I was exhausted—not just mentally over the whole mate thing but physically. I couldn't wait to take a warm shower and crawl into bed.

Not without texting my sexy wolveren first, though.

"Fuck," I muttered under my breath as I pulled up to my house.

A deep green Briar Glenn Parks Department truck was parked in the driveway, my asshole brother propped against the driver's-side door, a sour

expression plastered on his stupid face.

I stopped the car and stepped out, slamming the door behind me. “What do you want, Reece?”

My brother shoved his hands in his pockets and shook his head. “Now, Tegan. What kind of greeting is that for your big brother? Aren’t you happy to see me?”

“If I’m being totally honest, no. What are you doing here?” He was the last person I wanted gracing my doorstep after the day I’d had.

“I talked to Mom for a bit today. She said things between you and the guy you’re seeing are getting pretty serious. You aren’t planning on spending the full moon with him, are you?”

And there it was. The reason he was here.

To lecture me about my relationship with Atlas.

I glared at him and put my hands on my hips, showing the six-foot-four muscular idiot that I wasn’t backing down. “So what if I am. Do you have a problem with that?”

He stepped closer to me. “Yeah, I do have a problem with that, Tegan. You just met the guy. Aren’t you rushing into things a little too fast?”

Too fast?

I knew how I felt about Atlas. The attraction I’d felt from the moment we first met had only intensified since I got to know him. Sure, maybe we were mates, but I genuinely liked Atlas for who he was.

Anger ignited inside of me and my hands instinctively clenched into tight fists. “Rushing into things?” I asked through gritted teeth.

“What if he hurts you?” My brother was shouting now. He was coming from a place of concern, but he was going about it all wrong. Instead of meeting Atlas and getting to know him, he was making assumptions.

“Atlas would never hurt me. Never.” I kept my voice low and even. I wasn’t going to give him the reaction he wanted. “Leave. Now,” I said as I pointed down the road.

Reece opened the door to his truck and threw me a glance before getting inside. “I just want to keep you safe.”

“Go.”

He dipped his head and climbed into his truck.

I stomped inside the house, slamming the door so hard, I rattled the windows.

The universe had really been testing me lately, and I couldn't decide if I wanted to scream or cry.

Before I could do either, my phone vibrated, and I pulled it out of my pocket. Atlas had impeccable timing.

Atlas: Hiii baby. Miss you 😊🥺👧💕🦊

A wide smile spread across my face, and with a few words and a string of emojis, all the anger I felt over my brother evaporated away.

Tegan: 🥺 Hiii. Miss you too. I needed that today.

He replied immediately, like he was staring at his phone, waiting for me to respond.

Atlas: We're gonna have our tough days, baby, but we'll get through them together. What are you doing?

Gods, he was so fucking sweet. And what was I doing? My fingers tapped against the phone screen.

Tegan: I'm thinking about when I'll get to see you again.

Atlas: Why don't I come over? I'll bring dinner and we can talk.

Food and a sexy wolf?

Tegan: Say less.

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Thirty-Seven



ATLAS

TEGAN OPENED HER FRONT DOOR and launched herself at me, wrapping me in a tight hug and pressing her cheek against my chest.

“Hey, baby,” I said, leaning down to nuzzle her head. “Everything okay?” I asked. Her text earlier made it seem like something happened today.

“Better now that you’re here,” she said without elaborating. “What did you bring us for dinner?”

“Mac’s Barbeque. One of my all-time favorite cheat meals.” I’d been having a lot of those lately. Oddly enough, I didn’t care all that much. I was enjoying myself. Enjoying this.

Enjoying Tegan.

“Sounds delicious,” Tegan said, leading me inside.

“It is.” I set the bags of carryout on the counter, my mouth watering slightly at the scent of the food. “I wasn’t sure what you liked, so I got a little bit of everything.”

Tegan’s eyes widened at the sight of all the barbecue and sides I’d brought. “This is like a buffet.” She leaned over the pulled pork and took a deep inhale. “Fuck, it smells amazing.”

I barked a laugh, amused over my sweet thing’s appreciation for good food. “Get us some plates, baby. Let’s eat.”

Tegan pulled a plate for me from the cupboard. After I loaded it up with a generous serving of barbecue, mac and cheese, and cornbread, I took a seat at the tiny table in the corner of the kitchen.

“What would you like to drink?” she asked as she set her plate down. “I have water, sweet tea, or lemonade.”

My precious little hostess with the mostest.

“Some water would be great, please.”

Tegan grabbed us both a glass of water before sliding into her chair. I watched with anticipation as she brought her pulled pork sandwich to her mouth. If she didn’t like it, this would be a deal breaker. Not really, but I mean, who doesn’t like barbecue? Even vegans like barbecued jackfruit.

“Oh my gosh,” she groaned through a bite of her sandwich. “This is freaking delicious.”

My dick was hard. Watching her eat did things for me.

“I’m glad you like it. I was going to have to reevaluate our relationship if you didn’t,” I teased.

She snorted. “What’s not to like about sugary slow-cooked meats?”

I couldn’t help the smile that spread over my face, tightening my cheeks so hard, it almost hurt. “Attagirl.”

She bit her lip and smiled at me before taking a drink. Her and that praise kink would be the death of me.

We sat in companionable silence while we ate, quickly scarfing down our food.

“I don’t think I could eat another bite,” she said as she pushed her chair away from the table and patted her light pink lips with her napkin.

“Same.” I wiped my muzzle, making sure to get any trace of barbecue sauce or lingering crumbs. Being furry was tough.

Tegan grabbed our plates and started to clean up the kitchen.

“Why don’t you let me help—”

“I’ve got it,” she insisted.

“So did something happen today?” I asked. “Your text earlier made it sound like you had a rough day.”

Her back was turned to me while she did the dishes, and she whipped around to face me. She leaned against the counter, crossing her arms over her chest. “My idiot brother was here waiting for me when I got off work. He came by to lecture me about how fast our relationship was moving.”

Well, he was going to be in for a real surprise when he found out we were mates...

“Yeah, um, I, um, I actually came over to talk to you about that.” I rubbed my claws through the fur of my thighs, trying to ground myself.

“Atlas, if this is about Jade and what happened the other day—”

I cut her off before she could continue.

“No, I don’t even want to think about her.” I growled under my breath. Jade wasn’t part of this equation. “I want to talk about us. About the full moon,” I said in a calm, even tone, focusing my gaze on Tegan. “Why don’t we sit on the couch,” I suggested.

“Okay.”

We made our way to the living room, and Tegan sat down on the couch.

I sat next to her, making sure my thigh was touching hers. I wanted to pull her into my lap and hold her tightly, but eye contact was probably best for a conversation like this.

“I’d like us to spend the full moon together, Tegan. Here, in the woods by the cottage. I—I know we talked a little bit about rut, and what happens to wolverines during that time, but have you ever heard of primal play?”

She shook her head.

“It’s role playing, where one partner is the predator, and the other is the prey. For wolverines, it’s instinctual.” I bit my lip, anticipating a negative reaction over what I was about to say next. “You’d run, and I’d chase after you.”

I could see her chest heaving, her breathing picking up. I wasn’t sure if she was nervous or excited.

“And what would happen,” she said, her voice low, “when you caught me?”

“I’d fuck you—hard. Over and over again.”

She nodded. “I want that.”

I chuckled, reaching for her hand. “I do, too, but I want us to use a safe word. If there’s any point where you’re scared, or I’m hurting you—I want you to use it. Whatever it is we’re doing, you use your safe word, and it stops right then. Your safety is my top priority.”

Her expression brightened, and she smiled wider than I’d ever seen her smile before. “I know you’d never hurt me, Atlas.”

“You do?” I asked, my gruff voice higher pitched than usual. She really did a number on me, this woman.

“Of course I do.” She tightened her grip on my hand.

I leaned closer and kissed her, savoring her scent and the way her soft lips felt pressed against mine.

Tegan slid her tongue inside my mouth, and I groaned. “Fuck, Tegan. You are so fucking sexy.”

“Am. Not,” she said against my lips, alternating between speaking and kissing.

“Yes, yes, you are.” I grabbed her body and hoisted her onto my lap with ease. She faced me with her legs straddling my hips, and my cock throbbed against the heat of her pussy.

I growled against her neck as she rocked her hips against my erection. “Gonna fucking rut this pussy during the full moon.” The sharp tips of my teeth trailed across her pulse point and Tegan moaned. “You like it when I talk dirty, don’t you? Just like you enjoy a little bit of pain.”

“Uh-huh,” Tegan mumbled as I thrust my hips to meet hers.

“Such a good little slut for your big bad wolf.”

“Atlas, please,” she whined into the fur of my neck.

“Nah, baby. You gotta rest up. This pussy has to be ready to take me again and again during the full moon.”

I grabbed her hips and held her firmly in place.

“Fine,” she groaned, and stuck out her lower lip in a pout.

It took every bit of self-control I had not to rip her clothes off and take her right there on the couch, but I wanted to give her some time to recover before the big event in a few days. *Speaking of that...*

“Baby, we should talk about one more thing.” The thought of having this conversation with Tegan, right here and right now, had my heart racing.

But she needed to know what could happen. She needed to know the truth.

Tegan stared up at me while running her fingers through my ruff. Gods, her touch felt amazing. She gave me so much comfort and she didn’t even know it. “And what’s that?” she asked.

I grabbed her hand and held it still right over my heart, the steady *thump thump thump* pounding under our fists. “Tegan, uh. Wow. This is hard to talk about. Especially so soon.” I puffed out a breath of air. “I don’t want to totally freak you out.”

“I think I know what you’re trying to say.” She brought my hand to her lips and kissed my knuckles softly. “I might be your mate.”

“I *know* you’re my mate. And when we spend the full moon together, I might try to claim you.” I stared into her eyes, waiting for her to tell me this was crazy. To tell me that there was no way that we could be mates, but it never happened.

With our fingers still intertwined, Tegan leaned into my chest and nuzzled her face into my neck. “I can think of worse fates than spending my entire life mated to you, Atlas Oberon.”

“Are you sure this is what you want?” I asked, needing total confirmation.

She nodded. “I’ve never wanted anything more.”

Thirty-Eight



TEGAN

EXCITEMENT BUZZED BENEATH MY SKIN as I watched Atlas's taillights disappear down the driveway. I felt like I was living in a dream.

There was no way this was happening to me.

I went inside and paced back and forth across my kitchen.

This was big, and I needed to talk to someone about it.

Someone who would understand.

So, I did the only thing I could think to do.

I called my mom.

"Please pick up," I murmured to myself, waiting for her to answer.

After a few rings, she finally picked up the phone. "Hey, honey. What's up? Everything okay? You don't normally call me this late." Her voice sounded rough from sleep.

Shit. It was late.

"Mom, I—I didn't mean to wake you. I just..." There were so many thoughts and feelings swirling in my head that I didn't even know where to begin.

"Teg, I'm your mother. You wouldn't be calling me this late at night if there wasn't a reason." She used her stern maternal tone on me to bend me to her will. *Moms.*

I took a steadying breath. "Atlas just left. We had a pretty serious conversation tonight."

Before I could continue, she said, "Let me guess, it was about mating?"

"How did you know?" I asked in disbelief. My mom and I were close, so she knew things between me and Atlas were serious, but I'd never mentioned mating. Not even after the whole thing with Jade when Atlas implied I could be his mate.

"I told you about my friend's niece. Things with her and her mate moved fast. With the full moon coming up, I figured it might be on Atlas's mind. And of course your brother went off about it to me already." She sighed as if the very thought of the conversation she'd had with Reece exhausted her.

"He hasn't even met Atlas, and I feel like he already hates him." That wasn't difficult for my brother, though. He hated everyone.

"Tegan, he doesn't hate Atlas. He just doesn't know him. Reece is your big brother. He's very protective of you." It was a fair point, but sometimes it felt like my brother just delighted in being a prick. "Listen, honey. Your brother will come around. I'm sure Atlas is wonderful."

I felt sort of guilty for not introducing them to each other yet, but we were kind of doing things backward here.

"You don't think it's too soon?" I asked, worrying my lip while my mom gathered her thoughts.

"When the goddess brings two people together, she's never wrong. What's meant to be, will be." I could hear the smile in her voice. My mother was always a believer in true love, even if she never found it for herself.

I closed my eyes and took a deep breath. I thought about Atlas. His smoked-patchouli-and-sandalwood scent. The way his soft fur felt against my skin. The gravelly sound of his voice and the way it sent shivers down my spine. The *thump, thump, thump* of his tail wagging and those glowing yellow eyes.

I knew in my heart that this was what I wanted.

I knew in my heart that we were mates.

"You're right, Mom."

She laughed. “Of course I’m right, honey. I am so happy for you, and I look forward to meeting Atlas.”

“I can’t wait for you to meet him, either. Sleep tight, Mom.”

“You, too. Get some rest.”

After hanging up with my mom, I changed into one of my favorite pajama sets—one with dancing hot dogs printed all over it—and climbed into bed. Just as I was drifting off, my phone vibrated on my chest, and I about jumped out of my skin.

It was Atlas.

Atlas: Are you still awake, baby? 💕

A sleepy smile tilted up the corners of my lips ever so slightly.

Tegan: Yesss, I’m awake, wolf daddy.

Atlas: OH GODS NO. FALLON CALLS ME
THAT 😭

I giggled and rolled onto my side, holding the glowing screen close to my face.

Tegan: Alright, we’ll stick with sir then 😊

Atlas: I miss you already 🐺

To say I squealed would be an understatement. Gods, he was everything.

Tegan: I miss you too.

Atlas: What are you wearing right now? Send me a pic 🙄🙄

I turned on my bedside lamp, pulled off my comforter, looked down at my pajama set, and snorted. I hoped Atlas found dancing hot dogs sexy. Awkwardly, I fumbled with how to hold the camera so I could get my entire body in the shot and still hit the shutter button. When I got a decent picture, I sent it over.

Atlas: Holy shit, baby 😏
those are some sexy jammies 🌭🙄
Wear those the next time we have a sleepover

He was ridiculous, but I loved it.

Tegan: You should get to bed, sir. 🙄 Four AM tomorrow?

Atlas: You're right. 🙄 For sure. Bright and early, baby. Sweet dreams 🙄

I held my phone tight to my chest, smiling as I reread the messages, feeling so fucking lucky that I was going to spend the rest of my life with him. The full moon couldn't come fast enough.

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Thirty-Nine



TEGAN

I WATCHED WITH BATED BREATH as the full moon rose above the tree line that surrounded my cottage. I could have sworn I heard the low sound of rustling leaves coming from outside, but it was probably just the wind. Either that, or my anxiety getting the better of me.

I was just a little bit on edge. Even though Atlas had done a good job of explaining what to expect, tonight was a big deal. My first full moon with Atlas and the night he'd claim me as his mate.

That was the reason why I'd chosen to dress up a bit instead of wearing something more fitting for running around the woods at night.

The black pinafore dress clung tight to my breasts and waist and flared out over my hips. Underneath, I wore a simple white long-sleeve shirt to provide me some relief from the chill of the evening air. A pair of black lace high-waisted underwear hugged my ass, and black thigh-highs covered my legs, completing the look. When the time came to head out, I'd put on a pair of combat boots to ensure my feet were protected.

I checked the time on my phone and blew out a breath as I threw myself onto the living room couch. While I waited for Atlas to text me, my mind wandered, thinking about the wolverine of my dreams watching me under the cover of darkness, his sharp claws and teeth waiting for me. I imagined him chasing me through the woods, pinning me to the ground, rutting me with that thick cock of his, and forcing me to take his knot while he claimed me

as his mate. My hand started to drift down my thigh and underneath the hem of my dress, but I caught myself.

Fuck. I needed to chill out and wait for Atlas. It would be worth it. My phone vibrated, making me jump.

Atlas: It's time baby. Are you hydrated? Did you stretch?

I snorted. Thankfully, he'd been training me for this moment.

Tegan: Yes, I am well stretched and hydrated.

Atlas: And what's your safe word?

I chose something that was easy to remember. Something that played a big role in my life and our relationship.

Tegan: Cake 🍰

Atlas: That's my good girl. Don't be afraid to use it. See you soon 🥰

Tegan: I won't. I promise. 🥰 I'll see you soon.

When my boots were tied tightly to my feet, I stepped off the porch and walked straight into the dark woods, alarmed by the overwhelming quiet. It was as if all the animals in the forest had fled for the night—even the crickets and frogs were silent—which was unusual for a mild spring evening.

Something stirred in the trees off in front of me and a chill ran down my spine.

I knew it was Atlas.

My heart pounded loudly in my chest with anticipation.

Prey animals have certain instincts. They can tell when they're being watched. When they're being hunted. The primal part of my brain was screaming. Screaming at me to turn back, that I was in danger, but another part of my brain, the part that was truly wild and lived for the thrill—that part demanded I keep moving farther into the black depths of the woods.

Leaves crunched under my feet and streaks of white moonlight slipped through the tree branches. Every so often I'd see a shadow that didn't belong. A large lumbering form moving from out of the corner of my eye.

A twig snapped behind me and I whipped around.

I could hear my pulse racing in my ears, and my chest was tight. A low growl sounded from the opposite direction, and I spun around again.

"Atlas?" I said under my breath, knowing he'd be able to hear me.

Dark laughter broke the silence of the woods, and a pair of golden eyes gleamed through the dark. They were wider and more predatory than I had ever seen them.

Atlas stalked closer. When he paused under a ray of moonlight, I managed to get a better look at him.

He was naked, and his enormous frame was even larger, with his muscles bulging more prominently than they normally did. The clawed tips of his fingers were longer, as well as the sharp points of his canines. His fur was a wild mane of gray and black whorls that gleamed silver under the light of the moon. And his cock—his cock was thick and erect, the red tip leaking a thick stream of precum down onto his shaft and his already-swollen knot.

"Tegan," Atlas growled in a raspy, inhuman voice. He focused those wide yellow orbs on me, cocked his head to the side, and smiled, showing a full mouth of dangerous teeth. "Run."

I sucked in a breath and whirled around, the loose strands of my hair whipping into my face and eyes as I scrambled to put distance between us.

Faster.

Faster, my instincts screamed as my boots pounded against the forest floor. I raced through the trees, bobbing and weaving, splashing through a creek and up a muddy embankment. Thorns and brambles reached for me with their spindly branches, snagging my thigh-highs and my dress, slicing my skin as I fought to get away.

An ear-splitting howl sounded from close behind me, signaling that I was losing ground. Atlas was closing in on me, and there was a part of me that wanted him to. I wanted to feel his muscular weight pinning me down and those sharp teeth and claws grazing my skin.

“Run, run, run, my sweet thing,” Atlas roared as he tore through the trees.

“Come and get me, wolf daddy,” I teased, spurring him on.

Up ahead of us, I could make out a clearing illuminated by the moonlight. My muscles screamed at me, and I fought to pump my legs as fast as I could toward the stretch of open land.

I tripped over a rock and fell to my knees in the middle of the field, my chest burning with each breath I struggled to suck in. The woods around me were eerily silent. I could no longer hear Atlas’s panting breaths, heavy footfalls, or excited yelps. There was no sound except for the gentle swaying of tree branches in the breeze.

My body trembled from adrenaline and I wrapped my arms around myself. Sweat streaked down my temples and a nervous laugh slipped out of my mouth. I was completely and utterly afraid—but I loved it.

Forty



ATLAS

I WATCHED TEGAN FROM THE shadows as she sat on her knees. I could sense the fear rolling off her in waves but she was also laughing?

It seemed as if my little human liked being prey.

I'd show her just how scary the big bad wolf could be.

Without warning, I pounced and gently pinned her body against the grass, my hands restraining her hands above her head.

"A-Atlas," she gasped as I ground my cock against the warmth of her pussy, smearing my precum all over her black dress.

I lowered my snout to her neck and flared my nostrils. She smelled amazing. Intoxicating, even.

My tongue slid out of my mouth, and I licked the pale column of Tegan's neck as her body shuddered underneath me.

"Did you like being chased, baby?" I asked with a growl.

"Y-yes," she stuttered, thrusting her hips up to meet mine.

"Mmm, such a needy little thing. Even when you're scared, you're still a horny mess for me." I removed one of my hands and brought a clawed finger into view between us. The sharp black tip gleamed in the moonlight, and I slipped it under the collar of Tegan's shirt before slicing her dress clear down the middle.

"Fuck," Tegan moaned. Her eyes swirled with a mixture of fear and arousal.

I released my grip on her arms to peel off her clothing, taking a moment to admire her black lace bralette and panties. Her body glowed in the moonlight, and I longed to mark every inch of her with my scent. Or better yet, my teeth. Her legs were covered in a pair of black thigh-highs that had my cock throbbing.

“Take off your bra and underwear,” I commanded.

With shaking arms, Tegan pulled her bra over her head, exposing her breasts to the chill of the evening air. She shimmied her underwear over her thighs, and an impatient growl slipped out of my throat as she struggled to pull them over her boots. I reached down to help, shredding the thin piece of lace with my claws.

She stared at me, her eyes wide and her chest heaving. “The stockings, too?”

“No, those stay.” I groaned, palming my cock as I took in the sight of her pussy laid bare before me. “Do you want me to touch you, Tegan?”

“Gods, yes.” My sweet thing was needy, but she was forgetting something.

“Yes what?” I rasped from a breath’s width away, as close to her as I could get without touching her.

“Yes, sir.”

I let out a dark laugh and parted Tegan’s legs, gently running a claw over her thigh-highs as I did so. “I like these. I like these a lot.”

“I knew you would.” Her voice was so breathy, so desperate.

“So good to me,” I said as I brought my nose to her landing strip and flared my nostrils, taking in the sweet scent of her pussy. “I think you deserve a reward for being such a good girl. Such sweet prey.”

Tegan gasped as my tongue darted out and teased her cunt with slow strokes. She was already dripping wet from the chase, and her distinct flavor made me moan when it hit my taste buds.

“Atlas,” she whined, clutching the hair behind my ears, pulling me tighter to her cunt. Normally in this state, I demanded complete submission, but at this moment I was so desperate for her that I didn’t care.

My tongue lapped at the entrance of her pussy, and I tightened my grip on her thighs, allowing the tips of my claws to dig into her skin before I focused my attention on her clit. Tegan pulled my fur, writhing beneath me as I swirled my tongue against the sensitive bud. Over and over, I stroked it with the textured pad of my tongue, spurred on by her needy gasps and moans.

“Atlas. Atlas,” she chanted as I drove her toward her orgasm.

“That’s right, my little monster fucking slut. Come for me.” I pressed the tip of my tongue to her clit, flicking it wildly until her body trembled with ecstasy.

“Fuck, yes. Yes!” Tegan’s cries broke the silence of the forest, and a possessive part of me hoped someone would hear how well I pleased my woman.

My woman.

“Mine,” I groaned against her cunt as I licked her through the last waves of her orgasm.

She was mine.

“Please,” she said with heavy-lidded eyes. “Please fuck me.” She reached down between us and gripped my cock. I groaned as she pumped me, a thick stream of precum dribbling over her fist.

“Fuck,” I hissed. “Turn over. Get on your hands and knees for me.”

Tegan did as she was told without objection. Her ass shined under the light of the moon, perfect and plump, and I gave it several sharp nips that had her moaning.

“Mine,” I growled from deep in my chest. “This ass. This body. *You*. You are mine, Tegan.” I ran two fingers through her dripping cunt, checking that she was wet enough to take me, before popping them into my mouth. *Delicious.*

My claws dug into her waist as I notched myself at her entrance from behind. “Are you ready, baby? Ready for daddy’s monster cock and knot?”

“Please.” She sounded so sexy when she begged, I had to oblige.

Gently, I slipped the tip of my cock into her pussy. The copious amount of precum I was leaking mixed with Tegan’s arousal made sliding in easy,

but her pussy was still so fucking tight on my cock.

“Tegan,” I said through clenched teeth.

“Oh gods!” she cried out as I inched in farther, stretching her around me.

I tightened my grip on her hips, slowly thrusting in and out, working my knot closer to the opening of her pussy.

Leaning over her back, I whispered in her ear. “That’s it. That’s my good girl. Look at you taking me so well.” I pulled back to watch my cock disappear inside her pussy with each slow snap of my hips.

“More, Atlas. Please. *Harder.*” Tegan’s words came out a breathy plea. She needed more and I wanted to please her.

I grunted and slammed into her. My knot grazed her entrance, tearing a moan from the back of her throat. I snarled, digging my claws into her skin, drawing tiny rivulets of bright red blood to the surface. Harder and harder I fucked her, rutting her, pounding my cock deeper inside her than I had ever been.

“Mine,” I growled in a gruff, inhuman voice.

Mate. Mate. Mate.

Knot. Knot. Knot.

Claim. Claim. Claim.

A soft voice in the back of my head recited the words over and over.

Tegan’s cunt started to relax around my cock, and with a deep thrust, I forced my knot inside of her. With a slight pop, we were locked together.

“Fuck. Yes!” she screamed out as she came on my cock, her words echoing in the empty clearing.

I grabbed a fistful of Tegan’s hair and pulled her against my chest while I slowly rocked my hips, rubbing my knot against her G-spot to stretch out her orgasm.

“You took my knot, baby. Gonna mate you now, my sweet, sweet thing. Make you mine forever. Do you want that, Tegan?” I kissed her neck as I whispered. I needed her to say yes. I needed her to need me.

“Y-yes,” she whined, running her fingers through the soft fur of my ruff as she tilted her head, baring her neck to me. “I’m yours.”

I held her still and bit down, burying my teeth into the smooth skin where her neck met her collarbone until the taste of her blood filled my mouth. I moaned around her skin and lapped at the bite with my tongue.

Tegan yelped, but it quickly turned into a cry of pleasure as her pussy spasmed around me, the mating bite bringing her to orgasm again.

“That’s right, baby. Come on my cock. Come on your mate’s cock,” I praised her as I licked her blood off my lips.

My spine tingled and my cock throbbed, filling her with shot after shot of my cum, my knot keeping all of it inside of her. I couldn’t wait for her to get that IUD out. To fill her with my cum over and over. Breed my sweet thing until I put a baby inside of her.

But we had plenty of time for that later.

“Atlas,” she moaned as my cock pumped the last of my cum inside of her.

“Baby,” I groaned against her neck. “I love you so fucking much. My everything. My mate.”

“I love you, too.” She leaned into me and rubbed her cheek against my shoulder. “My mate.”

I wrapped my arms around her, easing our conjoined bodies onto our sides. She let out a contented sigh and twined her fingers through mine, her thumb rubbing tiny circles over the back of my hand.

Tegan and I were mated.

We would be together forever.

A low thrum started deep in my chest, and I purred for her until we both drifted off to sleep.

Forty-One



TEGAN

A WARM PUFF OF AIR tickled my forehead, and I burrowed deeper into the warmth of Atlas's fur as he dozed next to me.

I felt a dull throb where my neck met my collarbone, and my hand traced over the blood-crusted wound.

The mate mark.

Atlas Oberon mated me last night.

I, Tegan Rollins, who had resigned myself to a life of being a single workaholic shackled to her bakery, had a mate.

My heart pounded in my chest as a smile spread over my face.

"Atlas," I whispered to avoid startling him. "Atlas, wake up."

The sun was starting to rise, and birdsongs rang out from the trees.

"Shh, baby. Ten more minutes. Sleepy." His voice was raspy from sleep, and leaves and mud were stuck to his fur. Gods, he was fucking adorable. It was a stark contrast to the Atlas I'd been introduced to last night during the full moon.

Talk about wolf daddy.

He rubbed his muzzle against my head and placed soft kisses along my temple. "Last night was amazing, little mate," he mumbled.

Just hearing him say those words made me giddy. "It was. I knew you wouldn't hurt me." I snorted. "Well, not in a way I didn't like."

He pulled away from me and gave me a smug smile. “You are such a little monster fucker, baby. A little freak.”

“Just for you.” I closed the distance between us and kissed his lips, claiming his mouth.

I was so captivated by him. This handsome, sensitive, complex being that the goddess had blessed me with forever.

Atlas’s stomach growled, and I broke our kiss with a laugh. “Hungry?”

“I’m starving,” he whined.

I looked down at my naked body—minus my boots and what was left of my stockings—and surveyed the field around us. “I forgot to bring a change of clothes.”

Apparently, now I was feeling modest after a night of fucking outside under the full moon.

Atlas chuckled. “I have robes for us to wear on the walk back to your house.” He cupped my chin, gently tilting my head to the side. “Ouch,” he hissed as he examined my mate mark. “I got you good, sweet thing. It should heal up fast, though.”

“I’m gonna have a scar, right?” I asked as I trailed my fingers over Atlas’s chest.

“Yeah, you’ll have a little scar. It’ll let other wolverines know you’re mated.”

I smiled and tugged him closer. “Good,” I said before giving my mate another kiss.

Epilogue



ATLAS

"IS THIS THE LAST BOX?" Tegan asked as I walked through the front door of the cottage. We'd spent the better part of the day moving my stuff, and the sun was just starting to dip below the tree line of the surrounding forest.

"Yep, that's the last of it." I set the box down on the living room floor and pulled Tegan into my arms.

"It's going to be nice having all your stuff here," she said, rubbing her fingers through my fur. "You won't have to run all over the place."

For the past few months since we'd mated, I'd been living at Tegan's while going back and forth to the mansion to get my things. The housing market had finally improved, and I sold the place as soon as I could.

I preferred the coziness of the cottage, but in truth, I'd be happy wherever my mate was. We couldn't handle being separated from each other. Even an eight-hour shift at work was almost unbearable.

My four a.m. gym sessions were few and far between these days. Sure, I was still working out, but I'd let myself fall into a less restrictive routine. I was learning to love my softer physique. It certainly made Tegan happy.

"Mmm," I groaned, and pressed my lips to Tegan's. "I can't wait to use that new walk-in shower later. You know what that bench would be good for—"

Tegan cut me off with her giggles. We had been fucking pretty much nonstop since we'd mated.

“It is really nice,” she said. “And so is the handsome wolverine who installed it for me.”

I puffed out my chest with pride. I’d been doing all sorts of renovations around the cottage to make it the home of Tegan’s dreams.

“The full moon is tonight, baby,” I whispered against her throat before skating my tongue over her mate mark.

Tegan let out a breathy sigh. “I didn’t forget. How could I?”

“Are you going to be a good girl for me and run as fast as you can?” I growled against the shell of her ear. Her body trembled with excitement. It was one of Tegan’s favorite games.

“I’m always a good girl for my wolf daddy.” She winked.

I wanted to do this before I lost myself to the full moon. Something about this moment just felt perfect. Felt right.

“I have something for you, Tegan.” It was rare that I called her by her name and not a term of endearment. My heart raced as I dug around in my pocket and pulled out the tiny velvet box. I flicked it open, revealing a ring with a large diamond, flanked by gold crescent moons on either side.

“Atlas—” she gasped as I dropped down on one knee.

“Tegan, baby. These past few months have been everything to me. You’ve shown me that I’m worthy of love just how I am. Thank you for being patient with me. Thank you for accepting me.” I could feel tears forming in the corners of my eyes. “I love you, Tegan. And I know that we’re already mated, but I want you to be my wife, and have my babies, and be mine forever.” I focused my foggy yellow eyes on her. “Will you marry me?” I asked as my lip quivered.

A tear slid down her cheek, and she nodded several times before dropping to her knees in front of me. “Yes, a million times, yes,” she sniffled as I carefully slipped the ring onto her finger.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

My tail wagged against the floor.

I’d never been happier. I would have never guessed a gym bro’s archenemy—cake—would be what brought me my everything.

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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

It's weird writing this three years after the original iteration of *Muscles & Monsters* was published, but thanks to the most amazing group of readers—here we are! Thank you for all the love and support you've shown me and this series. As I said in the updated dedication, none of this would be possible without your support.

A special thank-you to my husband for holding down the fort at home, making sure I'm fed and watered when I'm planted in front of the computer for eighteen hours straight, and helping me unravel any tricky plot points. Your love, support, and unwavering faith in me makes this possible. I am endlessly grateful that you followed me on Instagram all those years ago, and wherever this journey takes us, I know it'll be amazing with you by my side.

Conky: I am a firm believer that your cover art played a big part in this book's success. You plucked Atlas and Tegan straight out of my head, and your depiction of them will always be my favorite. Thank you for taking on this project all those years ago, for allowing Berkley to repurpose the original art, and for being an amazing friend. I can't wait to see what you create next.

My agent, Jessica Watterson: Thank you for taking a chance on me and my books, and for holding my hand through this entire process. Your kindness, understanding, and knowledge of the industry have made the transition from indie to trad much easier than I thought it would be. From fielding all my frantic text messages to giving me the best news of my entire career, none of this would be possible without you!

My editor, Kristine Swartz: From that first meeting, I knew you'd be a good fit for me and my books. While the original plan was for Berkley to pick up *just* my vampire romance books, I'm so glad you saw the potential

for Leviathan Fitness. Thank you for talking me through all the plot issues I grappled with during this expansion, and for being flexible every time I needed to push back a deadline. I appreciate all of your feedback, and the care and dedication you show my manuscripts. My books are better because of you.

Trinity: You have such a keen eye for detail, and I appreciate how thorough and thoughtful you were while doing a sensitivity read of this manuscript. Your feedback helped shape this book into something I can be proud of, and the comprehensive trigger and content warning list you compiled will help keep readers safe and informed. I appreciate your patience as I transitioned to a new publishing schedule, and I look forward to working with you for the rest of the series! *For sensitivity reading and trigger and content warning compilation, Trinity can be found on Instagram [@ireadtoomuch](#) or contacted via email at trinityreads10@gmail.com.*

Ahren: Thank you for being my best friend and for helping me with all things book (and life!) related. I'm so sorry for all the messages about the structure of one sentence, for all the times I've spiraled, and for all the times I've had you read my manuscripts. You take it all in stride, showing up for me with a smile and a positive attitude that always pulls me out of my funk. You get my jokes, my quirks, and my love for Creed. Thank you for everything you do for me.

Anne-marie: You have been here since the beginning, and I am so appreciative of your feedback and the support you've shown me and my work. You are one of the sweetest people I have ever met, and I can't wait to visit you in Canada someday. I might need a few boxes of maple cookies to tide me over until that day comes.

Liz: Thank you for your alpha and beta feedback on *all* my manuscripts, and for being such a great friend. As far as I'm concerned, you *are* the Moth Madame, and there's no one else I'd rather laugh in elevators with.

Clio: We've been through the wringer together, and you've supported me every step of the way. Your faith in me and my work has pulled me through some of my darkest days, reminding me that I *can* do this—that I

was meant to do this. It's been amazing watching our careers grow, and I can't wait to see what the future has in store for us. 😊

Lana: None of this would be possible without you. Thank you for introducing me to Jess, and for all the kindness and support you've shown me. Now that this is finished, I can finally watch *KPDH* and fangirl over it with you!

Becs: I'll never forget the moment you introduced yourself at a signing and told me that you were a fan of my work. I was starstruck, and my admiration for you has only grown since I've gotten to know you. Going from indie to trad has been an adjustment, but having someone in my corner who knows what it's like has made it so much easier. I appreciate you so much, and I know we're making Harford County proud.

To my Patrons: So many of you have been here since the very beginning—when *Muscles & Monsters* was just a concept. Your support, especially during those early days, made me realize that maybe I wasn't too bad at this whole “writing” thing. Thank you for sticking with me as I make this transition. I can't wait to share more stories, artwork, and all the good things with you soon.

And last but not least, my parents: It breaks my heart that you're not around to see this, but I know you would be so, so proud.

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Leviathan Fitness series

TENTACLES & TRIATHLONS

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CYRUS

I BLINKED AT THE BRIGHT white canvas in front of me, willing something, *anything*, to inspire me to paint.

My art dealer, Eduardo, had been ringing me nonstop about new pieces, but over the last few months, I'd been at a creative standstill. Everything in my life had become boring. Repetitive. Bland, even.

Being one of the oldest monsters around, and potentially the last of your kind, could do that to you.

My tentacle clenched the paintbrush tighter, almost as if commanding it to move, but it was no use.

"Bollocks," I cursed, and whipped the brush at the canvas, coating it with a splatter of yellow paint.

The door to the studio cracked open, and my roommate, Fallon, peeked his head inside.

"Everything okay in here?"

"Fine." I huffed and collected the brush from the floor.

Fallon's beady eyes followed my movements before focusing on the smeared canvas. "Still nothing?"

"Not a damn thing."

He stepped through the doorway, his paws padding across the wood floor, and gave me a sympathetic look. *Well*, as sympathetic as someone with a beak and a feathered face could look.

"Cyrus, are you going to be able to handle tonight? I can find another ride and we can always say—"

“I’ll be fine,” I said in a clipped tone. “This is important to Atlas and Tegan. As one of his oldest friends, I should be there to show my support.”

Atlas had always been there for me when I needed him. Through my most recent college experience, my move to Briar Glenn, and now in my current existential crisis. After everything he went through with Jade, he deserved happiness, and tonight I’d be there to celebrate him and Tegan’s engagement.

Fallon dipped his head in a slow nod, his tail flicking back and forth behind him. I could tell there was more he wanted to say, but for once he didn’t press the issue. “Okay, then. Well. I should probably start getting ready.”

With that, he headed down the hall to his room, leaving me alone in my studio.

I tilted my head from side to side, rolled my shoulders, and let out a deep breath. My frustration and anxiety were getting the better of me, leaving my body feeling sluggish and drained.

There wouldn’t be enough time to make it to the gym for a swim, so a soak in the tub would have to suffice.

I shuffled across the hall to my bedroom and into the adjoining en suite. Popping sounds filled the space as the suction cups of my tentacles stuck to the tile floor with my movements. The sticky buggers could be a nuisance, but they had their advantages. I never had to worry about slipping in the shower.

While the tub filled, I stared at myself in the mirror, the fluorescent lighting reflecting off my skin. I admired the perfect turquoise shade, decorated with deep blue-green stripes and splotches that allowed me to blend into the water. In terms of my appearance, they were probably my favorite attribute.

Unlike humans, I didn’t wear clothes. My muscular chest was always uncovered, tapering down into a narrow waist that flared to my tentacles. I had eight in total, but preferred to use six of them for movement, keeping the other two wrapped around my arms. They were quite helpful, serving as extra hands for painting or cooking or whatever task I was undertaking.

Some days I truly enjoyed being a kraken, but others, I felt like a total abomination. Even by monster standards, I was quite odd.

I shut off the tap and used a tentacle to open the jar of raw sea salt I kept on the edge of the tub. I sprinkled a generous amount into the bath and used the strength of my tentacles to agitate the water, dissolving the crystals.

“Mmm,” I hummed and slid into the warm, salty water.

My tentacles fanned out around my waist, slithering and sliding with delight. It often felt like we were two separate entities. There was me, and then there were the tentacles acting of their own accord.

While they soaked, I grabbed my phone from the ledge of the tub and scrolled through my social media accounts.

A series of engagement photos of Atlas and Tegan popped up on my feed.

His snout was scrunched into a happy smile as he stared down lovingly at his human mate.

Simply put: The two of them were adorable.

I was happy for them.

Truly I was.

But if I was being honest with myself, I was also quite jealous of my friend and the love he’d found.

Being one of the last kraken, the majority of my seven- hundred-year life had been quite lonely. Sure, I had partners. Trysts with monsters and with humans who found a certain appeal to my tentacles. But in comparison to mine, their lifespans were rather short. There was no point in embarking on a long-term relationship with someone unless they were my fated mate.

For krakens, our mating bond clicked into place the moment one of our tentacles made contact with our mate. An innocent touch that often culminated in an orgasm. There was no mating bite, no claiming. Just a deep connection krakens formed with their partner, one that tied their lifespans together.

At this point, it was unlikely that I’d find a mate. And even if I did, would they want to be with me? Rejection would be more than I could handle.

I dug the sharp tips of my teeth into my thin lower lip, willing myself not to cry. I was supposed to be replenishing my saltwater stores, not depleting them.

With a sigh, I set my phone aside and submerged myself under the water, allowing the warmth to wrap around my body.

As I floated, weightless, my thoughts drifted back to the photos of Atlas and Tegan.

Would I ever be worthy?

Would I ever find that type of love?

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Ashley Bennett is a small-town paranormal and monster romance author from Baltimore, Maryland. She writes stories that are equal parts spice and swoon. When she's not writing, you can find her reading webtoons, playing cozy video games, and taking care of her houseful of rescue animals.

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